

*Preserving Our
Fellowship—
Our Challenge*

**THE FORTY-SIXTH ANNUAL MEETING
OF THE GENERAL SERVICE CONFERENCE
OF ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS**

*1996
Final Report*

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Confidential—full names used

Since this report is a *confidential* A.A. document, for members only, it contains members' full names and addresses.

This usage—to facilitate communication within the Fellowship—was approved by the 1975 Conference. Such confidential use does not, of course, violate in any way our Tradition of anonymity in *public* communications media (press, radio, TV, etc.).



46TH GENERAL SERVICE CONFERENCE

Preserving Our Fellowship— Our Challenge

The 46th General Service Conference of Alcoholics Anonymous met at the Crowne Plaza Manhattan, New York City, April 21-27. Chairing the Conference was Jim Estelle, Class A (nonalcoholic) chairman of the General Service Board; assisted by G.S.O.'s general manager George Dorsey; Doug Mead, Southern Minnesota, this year's delegate chairperson; and John Chappel, M.D., Class A trustee. Richard Bush, G.S.O. staff member, was Conference coordinator.

A.A.'s annual "business meeting" is made up of 135 voting members: 92 area delegates, 21 trustees; and directors and staff of the two corporations, A.A. World Services and the A.A. Grapevine. For the first time in 23 years, the Conference welcomed a new delegate area, Washington State East (Area 92), represented by Ben Beigler.

When the 1996 Conference theme — "Preserving Our Fellowship — Our Challenge" — was selected by the previous

Conference it was met with some skepticism. "Preserving," to many, conjured up images of pickling and canning, or shelves of specimens in jars of formaldehyde (images that were mentioned in several presentations throughout the Conference).

However, "preserving" and "pickling" were soon forgotten. The themes that emerged were "We," "Our," "Unity." These concepts were addressed in various ways and from many different angles—in presentations, sharing sessions and committee discussions— and were reflected in such A.A. basics as carrying the message, Twelfth Step work, self-support, and the Declaration of Responsibility.

Conference week officially opened with roll call Sunday morning, followed by greetings from the delegate chairperson and the keynote address. Following the opening dinner Sunday evening, attended by Conference members, spouses and friends, there was a five-speaker open A.A. meeting. Also

Sunday evening, Jim Estelle, presented the 15 millionth copy of the Big Book to Ellie Norris, widow of A.A.'s "Dr. Jack," "...with our deepest appreciation for your friendship and continuing commitment to the work of Alcoholics Anonymous; and in recognition of the pioneering and towering service of your husband, former chairman of the General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, our beloved Dr. Jack Norris. Your steadfast dedication to our Fellowship is a striking witness of extending the hand of A.A. to others. With love and many grateful memories."

Monday morning began the busy week of Area Service Highlights (page 54), Sharing Sessions, Presentations (page 11) and committee meetings and reports. From the deliberations of the 11 standing Conference Committees came recommendations and suggestions that were presented for discussion and vote to the entire Conference. Many of these items became Conference Advisory Actions (page 8).

At the Wednesday afternoon regional trustee elections, Carl Budd of Rock Springs, Wyoming, was elected the new West Central trustee; the new Western Canada trustee will be Garry McAuley of Stettler, Alberta. Chuck Crist, of Chandler, Arizona, who has been serving as a director on the Grapevine Board, will become a general service trustee. At the Delegates Only Dinner on Tuesday evening, Jack Shaver, Manitoba, was elected delegate chair for the 1997 Conference; Linda Fredricks, NW Ohio/SE Michigan, will be the alternate chairperson.

Some highlights of Conference week:

- Tuesday afternoon delegates, family and friends headed uptown for a tour of G.S.O. and Grapevine offices and to view demonstrations at various computer sites.
- Each morning the self-supporting G.S.C. Serenity Group met at 7:30 for an open A.A. meeting. And, no doubt some very important A.A. sharing went on at the "informal" meetings in Club 404 (a.k.a. "The smoking room").
- Friday afternoon saw farewell talks from two retiring longtime employees: Ann Warner, Grapevine's executive editor, and G.S.O. staff member Helen Turnquest.
- A climax to Conference week was a visit to Stepping Stones, the home of Bill and Lois W., on Saturday afternoon.

Saturday morning Conference members met for the last time at the closing brunch—the Happy Hour—Jim Estelle called it, using a term most would understand. After brunch it was time for the closing talks from the rotating trustees: Gerry Flegel, Western Canada regional trustee; Les Leuthaeser, West Central region; and Fran Polek, general service trustee.

What's it like to spend a week at the General Service Conference? G.S.O.'s general manager, George Dorsey, put it this way: "Sunday we board the Starship General Service Conference—leave the world behind, and go into orbit. Today, (Saturday) we come in for a nice soft landing." George, a veteran of eleven Conferences found, as did many others, a kind, gentle and respectful Conference—all "treating each other like recovering alcoholics."

Profile of a Delegate

The average age of a delegate is 52.4 years, with the oldest being 67 and the youngest 37 years; average length of sobriety 15.4 years, longest sobriety 37 years and shortest 8 years; average length of service 12.8 years, longest 31, shortest 6 years. (Compiled on responses from 90 delegates.) Another interesting statistic that didn't show up in this survey: tallest delegate, 6'7"; shortest, 4'11".

Greetings from Delegate Chairperson

I would like to extend a warm welcome to all members of the 46th Annual General Service Conference. Many staff and trustees bring the experience of years of previous Conferences. Myself and the other Panel 45 delegates feel like veterans, with only one year under our belts. And if the Panel 46 delegates are anything like I was last year, you have come to this Conference to clean up the messes the rest of us have left behind. I am grateful for all of these perspectives, each serving as an important ingredient in the group conscience we will cook up this week.

This year's Conference theme, "Preserving our Fellowship — Our Challenge," is appropriate for this point in the life of our Fellowship. I get a lot of teasing in my area because I told them I voted against the Conference theme last year. Something about the word "preserve" brings images to mind of dead specimens in glass jars filled with formaldehyde—hardly what I wanted to do with our Fellowship. It wasn't until I was preparing this presentation that I reread my Area Highlights report from last year. The last sentence reads, "Area 36 is active and is showing a greater willingness to shoulder the responsibility to make sure A.A.'s message is carried and preserved." Needless to say, I have moderated my opposition some.

I bring up this example for a couple of reasons. First of all, it demonstrates that while the business of A.A. is serious, each of us should not take our part in it quite so seriously. Furthermore, we can exercise the Right of Decision, perhaps misjudging the collective group conscience we represent, and still be okay. I was scared of the Right of Decision when I came to last year's Conference. It would be easy to vote as a proxy for a group having already decided how it wants to vote on everything; however, with the Right of Decision, we could be wrong. Or can we?

For years, each of us have been steeped in gallons of coffee, cured in countless smoke-filled halls, driven or flown thousands of A.A. miles, to the point where our Creator has brought us here today. Whether our service life has been in the offices of G.S.O. or our area assemblies, we are more a product of our experiences and the group consciences we represent than we know. All this insures us that any time we exercise the Right of Decision, we are acting with faith in the trust placed in us by those who elected or appointed us. In many ways, this is a key to our Fellowship's preservation.

As I mentioned earlier, the title for this year's Conference is fitting. Our world changes more rapidly each year, and A.A. tries desperately to keep pace with it while maintaining its integrity. How do we pass along what was so freely given to us to the child born tonight destined for alcoholism? One path would be to rely on collective self-will and oppose anything offering change to our Fellowship—the formaldehyde and glass jar approach. The other path calls us to take prudent, responsible action, trusting in a Creator guiding our deliberations and decisions. If we are to become "...the perpetrators of the world services of our Society, the voice of the group conscience of our entire Fellowship, and the sole successors of its co-founders..." (*The A.A. Service Manual*, p. S30) we must continually walk in faith.

The other day, while reading a book for work, I came across the following quote: "People can't live with change if there's not a changeless core inside them. The key to the ability to change is a changeless sense of who you are, what you are about and what you value." A few years ago, the Conference theme was "A.A. in a Changing World" and during those workshops it became clear that while the face of A.A. may be changing, at its core it remains the same. Now as we consider the "preservation" of our Fellowship, what we really seem to be asking our-

selves is how do we reinforce what is “changeless” about our society? If I had to pick a starting point for discussion, I would borrow the words of one of our co-founders when he distilled all of A.A. down to two words—“love and service.”

As we go through this week, each of us needs to speak the truth of our experience, not what we think it should have been. Our experience, however imperfect, has successfully brought us to this point and will sustain us well into the future. As we carry out the responsibilities of “service,” let us not forget about the “love” we experienced somewhere that enabled us to reach out to a Power greater than ourselves. The same Creator, in an environment of love, will guide our group conscience down the path we are to travel. I would like to thank each of you for sharing this part of the journey with me.

*Doug Mead, Southern Minnesota
delegate chairperson*

Keynote Address

My Higher Power very definitely has a weird sense of humor. You all know how difficult it is to get nine alcoholics to agree on anything, so when the Conference Agenda Committee unanimously recommends a theme for the upcoming Conference, *nobody* questions it on the floor—right? Wrong! It seems to me, if my memory serves me correctly, that last year this trustee got to the microphone and suggested that *preserving* has the connotation of “canning” or “pickling,” that is, putting things into sealed containers, and up on a shelf to gather dust; and that certainly this would not be an appropriate theme for this Conference. I’ll give you just one guess to figure out who gets picked to give the keynote address on this very same Conference theme! I think I need to have a word with my Higher Power about a few things.

Well, it didn’t take very long at last year’s Conference, after being shot down at the microphone by my good friend, Charles, for the realization to set in that there are many, many ways to preserve things. It’s true that, if you want to preserve something that is dead, you can pickle it, or immerse it in formaldehyde, or just sterilize it, seal it and shelve it. But that is not what we are dealing with at all. Our challenge is to preserve something that is alive and growing, and delicate, and forever changing.

So, all of a sudden, I get a whole different picture. The question now is how to preserve a young plant that is freshly out of the ground and just about to come into blossom. There is physical nourishment, obviously, and water to get the nutrients into a useable form. Then the plant needs air and an abundance of sunshine for the vital transformation to take place. We also need neighboring plants for fertilization, and finally, protection from extreme outside conditions like temperature, winds, floods, etc.

If we look at Alcoholics Anonymous as enduring for millennia, then we are just barely into the early blossom stage. We here at this 46th Conference are pioneers in A.A. We are the current co-founders of the Fellowship. When the delegates gather for the 1000th General Service Conference, and look back over their long history, they will talk about the early pioneers at the 46th General Service Conference who helped shape the face and the character of Alcoholics Anonymous.

The quality and abundance of the fruit that a plant bears is very much determined by the health and well-being of that plant at blossom time. We may think that this gives us a very awesome task to fulfill. Yes and no. Left to our own resources it would truly be an awesome, if not an impossible

task to accomplish. Fortunately, we have access to a power, a source of direction that has guided the evolution of this Fellowship from the very beginning. All we have to do is tap into that source, and we do that individually by considering all points as they come up, by letting go of our own ideas when we need to, and by accepting only the very best for our Fellowship every time.

The physical nourishment for A.A. is the groups across North America that have selected us and provided the means for us to be here. While the groups understand that they have the ultimate authority and responsibility for Alcoholics Anonymous, they choose to make use of us, this Conference, to be “...the actual voice and the effective conscience for our whole Society.” (*Twelve Concepts for World Service*, p. 10) Collectively here, we have the varied resources and talents we need to tackle each of the issues that will be facing us this week. We just have to be sure that we are open to the sunshine of the spirit to work its divine alchemy on our very human efforts.

You know what struck me when I took a second look at this Conference theme? It wasn’t “preserving,” nor was it “Fellowship” and even the “challenge”—it was “our.” It’s the only thing that is mentioned twice. It is not *my* Fellowship (alone I don’t have a Fellowship) and it is not *my* challenge alone. It is *us* here, who are “the actual voice and the effective conscience.” As the delegate from Manitoba, Jack does not come here as a representative for Manitoba at this Conference. Nor does Sarah come here to represent Corrections at this Conference. Nor does Jacques come here to represent A.A.W.S. Nor Tom, the Grapevine. And certainly, Gerry does not come here to represent the board or Western Canada. We are all here, each and every one of us, plucked out of some geographical location, or out of some position of service to the Fellowship that we happen to be in at the moment, and the *only* thing we represent is Alcoholics Anonymous—together, as a cross-section of A.A. as a whole.

If we manage to keep this in mind, we can likely endure some very late nights, and some rather heated discussions, because we recognize that we are all on the same side—it’s just that each of us is certain that we know a little better than all the rest, what is the absolute best way to carry the A.A. message of hope to the still-suffering alcoholic.

I was going to ask for a show of hands of those who are here for some other purpose—but I think I won’t. I have to remember that I came here as a first-year delegate with a sticky-note taped to the back of my mind that said, “Check up on those trustees. Make sure they are above board, and not leading A.A.





die. The same is true in A.A. Each of us here contributes our own little part. On cue, we in turn stand up and throw our hands in the air, and then sit down. We, each of us individually, make our own little, almost insignificant, contribution; but the overall effect is electrifying—something much greater than the sum of all the parts. The service we provide to the Fellowship as G.S.R.s, D.C.M.s, area officers, and now as delegates or trustees is really just a little blip in time—almost insignificant, but at the same time, absolutely essential. Actually, the only way that this thing will not work is if the majority of us just sit here with our arms crossed, and just decide to have a bad day. I believe that this is our real challenge—to be willing servants. To be willing to stand and be heard when our conscience prompts us, and to be willing to be guided by our group conscience—the voice of the spirit that watches over us all.

I just want to say a few words about “fellowship” before I close. This actually does concern me sometimes. It just seems to me that there are more and more A.A. members in my part of the world that seem to belong to something called a Twelve Step program instead of A.A. They “work their program,” or more specifically, “I’m working my program!” and they go for coffee “with other program people.” I think we may need a Conference Action to change that item from the Grapevine that we refer to as the A.A. Preamble—you know the one that, I guess, should read: “Alcoholics Anonymous is a program of recovery for men and women who...” One of the biggest things I looked for in the bottle, was fellowship; but found only loneliness. When I finally gave up and joined A.A., I discovered the fellowship I had been searching for all along. And now it’s becoming a program? Maybe we do have a challenge to preserve our Fellowship.

I don’t know about you, but when I think about preserving our Fellowship, my mind tends to move into the future and to see all sorts of trouble and obstacles ahead. There may indeed be some of those, but we will also have future boards and future Conferences to deal with those problems. As we well know from our “program,” it is this 24 hours in which we live and make decisions. All I need to concern myself with is to make sure that my own house is in order today; that I am plugged into my Higher Power, willing to accept His will for me today and willing to do whatever is required of me to be of maximum service. It is God’s job to see around the corner to the next day, and to prompt me to take the right action today.

Although I don’t like quoting stuff, I’m going to do just that, and close with a quotation from our Big Book. I happened to be reading Chapter 11 when I was preparing this presentation, and this paragraph just popped out and seemed to fit our situation here perfectly. It says:

“We realize we know only a little. God will constantly disclose more to you and to us. Ask Him in your morning meditation what you can do each day for the man who is sick. The answers will come, if your own house is in order. But obviously you cannot transmit something you haven’t got. See to it that your relationship with Him is right, and great events will come to pass for you and countless others. This is the Great Fact for us.” (*Alcoholics Anonymous*, p. 164)

Gerry Flegel, Western Canada trustee

astray.” Fortunately, it didn’t take very long for me to crumple that little sticky, and send it flying to the nearest appropriate filing cabinet. If you are here with some little caution from a well-meaning old bleeding deacon from back home, don’t ignore it—but do come to work with an open mind and trust your senses in what you see, hear, and feel. God will guide you, as we all work together toward our one common goal. Remember that we, here, are the co-founders of Alcoholics Anonymous. Next Sunday at this time A.A. will be different than it is now. A few specific actions will have been taken, some new policies may have been introduced, and likely, some old ones modified. But the face of Alcoholics Anonymous will be different, and that makes us the co-founders—the ones that nourish and prune and protect the Fellowship that has saved our lives.

So the key word for me in this theme is “our.” Each of the two extremes that I associate with this idea is, I believe, equally dangerous and damaging. If I choose to act on my own (ignore the group conscience decision) because my group or area or this Conference obviously doesn’t know which end is up, then I become part of the problem, and no longer contribute toward a healthy solution. If, on the other hand, I just sit back and don’t share my experience, and quite literally, “Let George do it,” then I equally become part of the problem. This was illustrated recently by a past trustee in my area in one of his presentations. He stated that the two greatest dangers that he currently sees in A.A. are apathy and a lack of knowledge. And then, with tongue in cheek (I hope), he said that he asked someone named Gerry what he thought about that, and Gerry’s reply was that he didn’t know and didn’t care! The participation of everyone here is vital to truly arrive at an informed group conscience.

One of the greatest moments in my A.A. life so far was the celebration in San Diego last summer. I was one of the 21 trustees sitting on the stage on Friday night before the flag ceremony when the “wave” was started in the stadium. The energy in the place was just awesome, and it seemed to be focused right toward the stage. Even my hair tingled with the energy of the moment. Then a thought crossed my mind. I could see some drunk (that could very easily be me) seated in about the 15th row, up in the 3rd tier, and just having a bad day. He’s sitting there with his arms crossed, watching the wave come around toward him, and *nobody* is going to make him join in. So he sits there. Does the wave stop? Not at all. It just washes on by, and nobody really notices that he really showed us! But then another thought crossed my mind. What if most of the people there decided not to join in. The “wave” would just fizzle and

Workshop:

Preserving Our Fellowship — Our Challenge

Wednesday morning Conference members divided into groups of 12 to 14 for workshop discussions based on the Conference theme. Following are the questions and a summary of responses from these discussions.

What are we doing and how are we doing in our home groups, districts and area assemblies to ensure the future of Alcoholics Anonymous?

1 Are we extending the hand of A.A. to newcomers? Do we work at providing good sponsorship?

a) Extending the hand of A.A. to newcomers

Beginners meetings, greeters, newcomers packets containing meeting schedules, literature, and sometimes phone lists—these continue to be the customary “hand extensions” to the A.A. newcomer. Yet some express concern that “we extend A.A.’s hand in the beginning, but fall short as time goes on. We need to give the newcomer better focused, follow-up attention.” Suggestions include: calling newcomers; adding newcomer names to a “two-way” group member phone list; providing assistance with finding sponsors; stressing the value of the home group; and making “temporary” contact lists available.

Some perceived that newcomer attention often remains solely on individual recovery, overlooking the value of unity and service. Group discussion of A.A.’s Three Legacies is one possible means of addressing this concern, sharing experience about the value of each, especially related to “the early days in recovery.” Other concerns expressed were: the impact, and misunderstanding of sober “clubs” on the newcomer trying to find their place in A.A.; addressing the needs of both low- and high-bottom newcomers; and dealing effectively with the newcomer “forced” to attend Alcoholics Anonymous.

b) Providing “good” sponsorship

Whether for recovery or service, Conference members emphasized that the key to effectively carrying the A.A. message rests with active sponsorship. Sponsorship is an invaluable tool in helping newcomers find their path in recovery. However, it may be more advantageous to stress the concept of *temporary* sponsorship in the early days of recovery. Many newcomers are encouraged to find a sponsor “right away,” but often pick the first available person without knowing what to look for, i.e., “*quality sobriety*.” More in-depth sponsorship workshops might be a solution, but concern was expressed that these workshops are often not attended by those who really need them. Also reported was a general sense of apathy about sponsorship. While some A.A.s have expressed concern that treatment facilities have “weakened” this concept, others feel “we cannot assign blame outside of the Fellowship. It is the responsibility of *active* A.A.s to utilize the tools available within Alcoholics Anonymous to inform the newcomer, as well as others, of the importance and value of sponsorship.”

Some groups feel that one should not have to ask where to find the longtimers, and suggest “reverse sponsorship”—go out and find them, bring them to meetings and get them involved. Also stressed was the need to share *experience*, not knowledge; showing, not telling—leading by example; while remembering A.A. is a program of attraction, not promotion.

2 How many of our meetings are focused on the Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions?

Workshops and presentations stressing “Living the

Traditions” are invaluable to some groups, especially when connected to A.A. Conference themes. But, even though the Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions are widely respected and valued, meetings dedicated to their study continue to consistently fall far behind “general discussion” meetings. Regardless, Step meetings persevere, as do the slower-to-emerge Tradition meetings. Where the latter are held regularly, they generally fall behind Step Meetings at a ratio of 3:1, and weekly Tradition meetings still appear to be few.

Conference members reported that a small number of Twelve Concept meetings have begun, but focus on the Concepts is primarily incorporated into the district meeting, area assembly and workshop spheres.

3 Do we know our A.A. history?

One group reported “using A.A. history as a way to inform the misinformed and uninformed” about the A.A. Fellowship. However, interest in A.A. history is often overshadowed by a prevailing desire to “just get on with the meeting.” This sentiment is reportedly common among, but not limited to, the Fellowship’s newer members.

It is believed to be the responsibility of “longtimers” to instill a respect for history within the A.A. community. This responsibility is linked to ensuring the future of the Fellowship—by giving back what was freely given to them. Oldtimers can help further understanding of our history when they: focus on A.A.’s primary purpose; suggest workshops to study *A.A. Comes of Age*; participate in oldtimers meetings; work with Archives Committees to broaden awareness of our history at the area, district and group levels; help organize and explain the value of special events, such as: Unity Day, celebration of A.A.’s inception, months dedicated to A.A. appreciation and gratitude, and special topic workshops.

Such events have inspired unity and put gratitude back into action. In one workshop attendee’s words, “We learn where we come from as a Fellowship, how we got to where we are; we learn the lessons of our past.” By emphasizing this participation, many A.A.s also develop a greater appreciation for the concept of “self support.”

4 Do we regularly discuss group concerns? Are we listening?

Through regular discussions, groups reported experiencing a greater sense of unity. There is, however, a definite consensus that A.A.s “need to do better” in addressing group concerns. Many group members feel improved listening skills would enhance participation in such discussions. These can be facilitated by taking regular group, as well as district, inventories. Some topics believed in need of discussion are: combating misinformation about A.A.; lack of group registration; misguided sponsorship; and whether smoking meetings should be changed to non-smoking meetings so that more members are able to participate.

The extent to which group members are listening to discussions, whether regular or irregular, was not reported and appears to be an area for continued growth.

Overheard at Conference

“If you asked for a bagel in Charlie’s area (Charlie Bartell, Louisiana) they are likely to bring you a little brown, white and black hound dog.”

When George O’Neil (NE Ohio) was asked if his town of Hubbard was going to bid on the International for the year 2005, George quickly shot back, “Our Post Office is too small to handle the registration.”

Conference Advisory Actions

Conference Advisory Actions represent recommendations made by the standing committees and approved by the Conference body as a whole, or recommendations discussed and voted on by all Conference members during general sessions. The group conscience of the Fellowship in the United States and Canada was expressed in the following Advisory Actions, which the General Service Board accepted in its legally required annual meeting following the 1996 Conference.

AGENDA

It was recommended that:

1 The theme for the 1997 General Service Conference be "Spirituality — Our Foundation."

2 The following be presentation/discussion topics for the 1997 General Service Conference:

- Group Conscience — Seeking Our Ultimate Authority
- Carrying A.A.'s Message Around the World
- The Hat — Where Money and Spirituality Mix

3 The following be the workshop topic for the 1997 General Service Conference: Spirituality — Our Foundation:

- Spirit of Rotation
- Working with Faith, Serving with Love
- Unity — We Are Responsible

COOPERATION WITH THE PROFESSIONAL COMMUNITY

No recommendations.

CORRECTIONAL FACILITIES

It was recommended that:

4 Sample video footage be made that focuses on encouraging more A.A. participation in carrying the message into Correctional Facilities, and brought back to the 1997 General Service Conference for review. The following should be reflected in the footage:

- Singleness of purpose
- Correctional Facilities Workshops
- Reaction from men and women inmates attending A.A. meetings at their facility, and from outside members who carry the message inside
- Inmate speakers at an A.A. event
- Unpredictability and roadblocks to carrying the message inside
- How to improve communication within A.A. and with prison administrators
- Once A.A.s are involved, how to keep them involved

5 A one-page newsletter be published quarterly, whenever feasible, for A.A. members on the inside, which would reflect sharing from inmate letters to G.S.O. and which would be sent to Conference members, area correctional facilities chairs and to inmates who write to G.S.O.

FINANCE

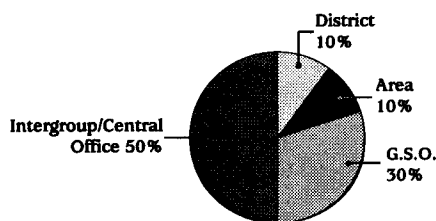
It was recommended that:

6 The pamphlet "Self-Support: Where Money and Spirituality Mix" be revised to include only two pie charts, as follows:

Under the heading:

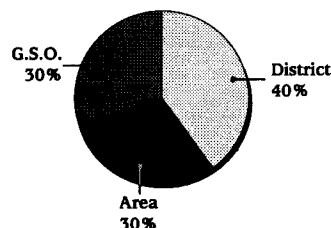
"Examples of Group Contributions to A.A. Service Entities"

Distribution of funds from groups that support four service entities:



AND

If you have no intergroup/central office, distribution of funds from groups that support three service entities:



Also, information be added adjacent to the pie charts under a new heading "After group expenses, what is your informed group conscience for distribution of excess funds?" which includes space for the group name, group service number, and the percentage the group wishes to contribute to each entity. (Page 16 in the current pamphlet is suggested.)

An example is as follows:

Distribution Plan of _____
(YOUR GROUP NAME)

Your Group Service #	_____
District	_____ %
Area	_____ %
G.S.O.	_____ %
Intergroup/Central Office	_____ %
Other	_____ %
Other	_____ %

And further, space be provided for the group to list addresses of the various entities to which it wishes to contribute, along with G.S.O.'s address. (Page 18 of the current pamphlet is suggested.)

7 In order to allow for a smoother and more understandable flow of the process that financially supports the Grapevine, beginning with fiscal year 1996, the interest income earned from the unfulfilled subscription investment with the General Service Board Reserve Fund, after adjustment to ensure that the liability is appropriately funded, be transferred to the Grapevine's operating cash on an annual basis.

EVOLUTION OF A CONFERENCE ADVISORY ACTION

1	An idea suggestion, question, concern or subject comes from A.A. members, G.S.R.s, D.C.M.s, Area Committee members, Delegates, Trustees or G.S.O./GV Staff, and may be shared or discussed at the group, district and Area Assembly and sent to the	Conference Coordinator G.S.O.
2	The idea is reviewed by the G.S.O./GV Staff and forwarded to	Appropriate Trustees' Committee
3	which then may refer the matter to the	Appropriate Conference Committee
4	which meets during the General Service Conference week and makes recommendations that are presented in the Committee Report to the	General Service Conference
5	if a Conference Committee recommendation is approved, after full floor discussion, it becomes a Conference Advisory Action , which becomes binding when approved by the	General Service Board
<i>"Were it not for Committees it is doubtful that any Conference could get over a fraction of the ground it now covers. As the Conference has grown in size and influence the Committees' importance has grown even more". . . from the A.A. Service Manual</i>		

GRAPEVINE

It was recommended that:

- 8** A manuscript be developed for a pamphlet providing basic information on the A.A. Grapevine magazine and its place in

Alcoholics Anonymous and be brought to the 1997 Conference for approval.

INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS/REGIONAL FORUMS

It was recommended that:

- 9** The undernoted four (4) cities, expressed here in alphabetical order, be given equal consideration as a site for the International Convention in the year 2005: Atlanta; St. Louis; San Antonio; Toronto.

LITERATURE

No recommendations.

POLICY/ADMISSIONS

It was recommended that:

- 10** The delegate from Area 73, West Virginia, Larry Cassady, Panel 45, be seated as a Conference member in place of Martha (Marty) Wright, Panel 45, who has resigned.

- 11** The 49th General Service Conference be held April 18-24, 1999, since these dates do not conflict with any major religious holidays.

- 12** Any sitting delegate on the Conference International Conventions/Regional Forums Committee whose area is presenting at the General Service Conference as a possible International Convention site city withdraw from that committee and a replacement be selected.

- 13** "Washington State East Area 92" and "Western Washington State Area 72" be approved as the new names for these areas.

PUBLIC INFORMATION

It was recommended that:

- 14** The 1996 Membership Survey be conducted by area on a random basis as was done in the 1992 Membership Survey.

REPORT AND CHARTER

It was recommended that:

- 15** The title of the chart on page S23 of *The A.A. Service Manual* be changed from "Structure of the Fellowship" to "The General Service Conference Structure (U.S. and Canada)" to more accurately describe what is depicted.



16 To be consistent, the title of the chart on page S46 be changed from "How the A.A. Group Fits into the Structure of the Fellowship" to "How the A.A. Group Fits into the General Service Conference Structure (U.S. and Canada)."

17 The following description of the qualifications and responsibilities of an area registrar be added to Chapter IV of *The A.A. Service Manual* following the paragraphs describing the Secretary Qualifications:

In some areas, *registrars* now develop and maintain records of all groups within the area. The records include group information such as group name, meeting location, time, and G.S.R. or contact for the group. Registrars may also be responsible for names, mailing addresses, phone numbers of the G.S.R.s, D.C.M.s, district officers, area officers and other area committee members. Another duty of the registrar may be to provide mailing labels for area publications such as a monthly newsletter or a mailing of minutes. A willingness to become organized and computer literacy may be helpful.

18 The description of Third Legacy Procedure on page S118, item 3 of *The A.A. Service Manual* be reworded as follows to be consistent with the wording on pages S41 and S64 of *The A.A. Service Manual*: "After the fourth ballot, if no candidate has two-thirds of the total vote, the chairperson asks for a motion, second and majority of hands on conducting a fifth and final ballot. (If this motion is defeated, balloting is over and we go to the 'hat' immediately. . .)."

19 Article 2 of the Current Conference Charter remain as is.

20 A typographical error in Warranty Two in *Twelve Concepts for World Service* on page 66, third paragraph, fourth line: "This *set* income to the groups. . . " be corrected to "This *net* income to the groups. . . " in the next printing, noting that this typographical error has existed since the first printing of *Twelve Concepts for World Service*.

21 For clarification, the third paragraph of the Preface to *Twelve Concepts for World Service* be revised as follows:

"Following the recommendation of an ad hoc committee of the A.A. General Service Board, the 1985 General Service

Conference recommended that future publication of the Concepts in *The A.A. Service Manual* and the booklet *Twelve Concepts for World Service* be in the original 1962 version. . . ."

(Underline indicates words to be added.)

22 Special International Contacts be listed if they serve special populations (young people, doctors, gays and lesbians, etc.) which meet some of the following criteria: (1) Large membership, (2) Annual international meetings, (3) Regional and state contacts, (4) Maintenance of membership lists and/or directories of special interest meetings for our Twelfth Step purposes, (5) Serve as a "bridge" into the Fellowship.

23 International correspondence groups such as International Deaf Group by Mail and Groupe Bonjour le Monde be listed in A.A. directories under the category of "International Correspondence Meetings" in order to provide additional sharing opportunities for A.A. members.

TREATMENT FACILITIES

It was recommended that:

24 A soft-cover Treatment Facilities Handbook be developed and a concise and streamlined version of the existing Treatment Facilities Workbook (three-ring binder) be produced.

25 The "Treatment Facilities Newsletter" be discontinued as the expressed need appears to have diminished.

TRUSTEES

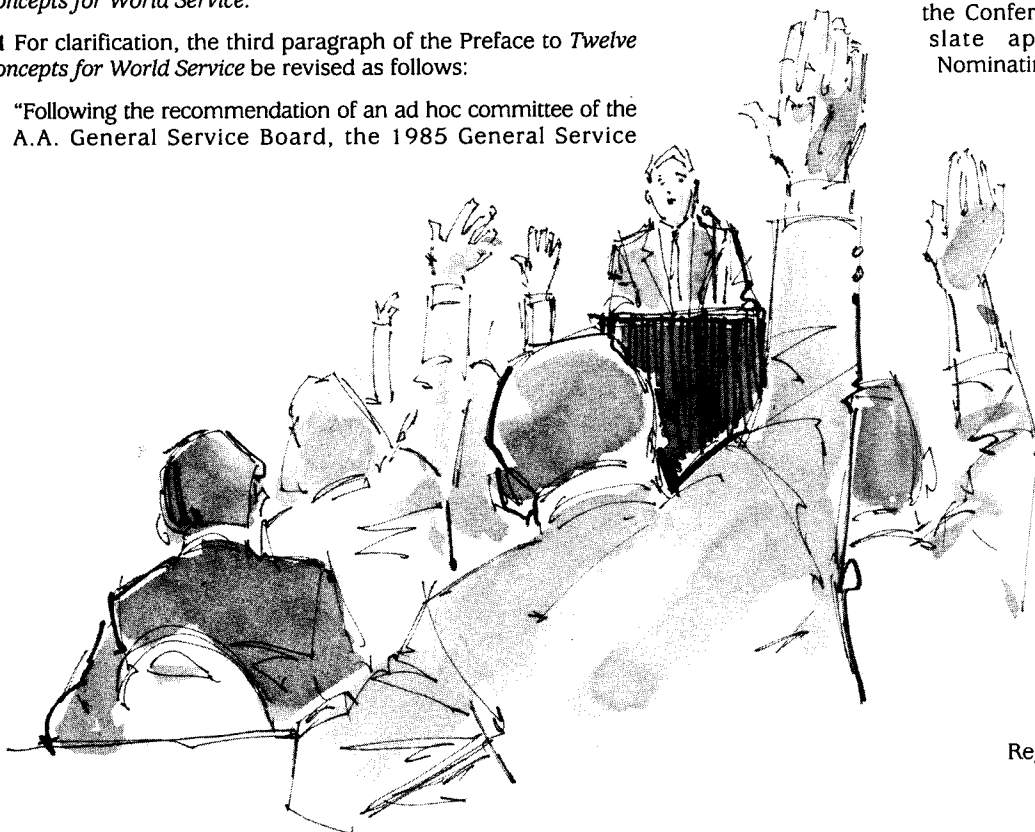
It was recommended that:

26 The slate of trustees and officers be elected at the annual meeting of the General Service Board in April 1996 (see page 44; the Conference and board approved the slate approved by the trustees' Nominating Committee).

27 The slate of directors be elected to the A.A. World Services Corporate Board (see page 45; slate of directors approved).

28 The slate of directors be elected to the A.A. Grapevine Corporate Board; (see page 45; slate of directors approved).

29 The suggested guidelines developed by the trustees' Nominating Committee for changing regional boundaries be accepted, and a reference regarding the existence of these guidelines be added to *The A.A. Service Manual* following the section pertaining to Procedures for Requesting Change of Region in Chapter IX.



Presentations and Reports

PRESERVING OUR FELLOWSHIP —OUR CHALLENGE

The first presentations of the week were based on the Conference theme, Preserving Our Fellowship — Our Challenge. The Monday afternoon session was chaired by Tom McGuire, nontrustee director on the Grapevine Board.

Preserving Our Fellowship — Let it Begin With Me

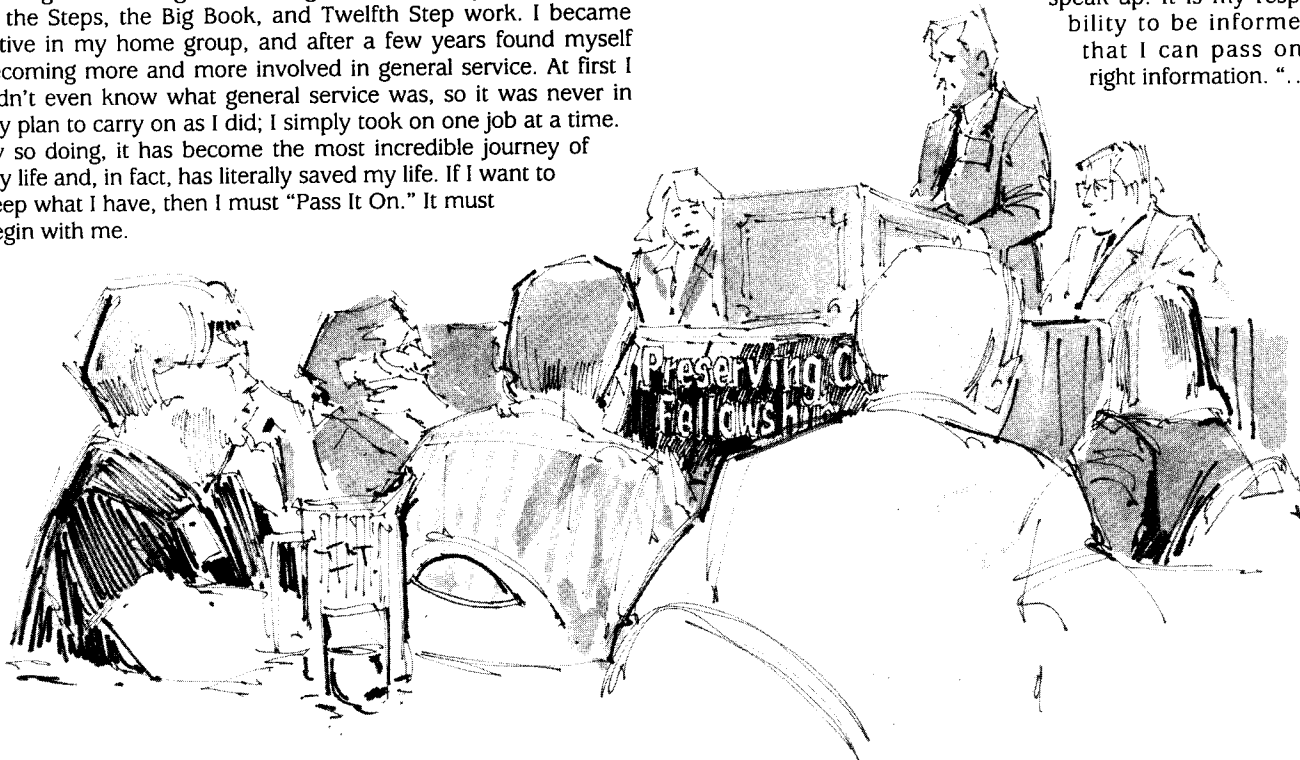
As is usual for me, I had a hard time commencing this report, so as a starting point, I looked up the definition of preserve in the dictionary. The first definition stated it was "to keep from harm, damage, danger, or evil"; the last line said it was "any place or activity treated as the 'special domain' of some person or group." Alcoholics Anonymous is certainly a very "special domain" to me, and if I want it to be protected from harm or damage, I need to assume some responsibility; it must begin with me. I also believe that preserving my own sobriety has to be a starting point if I am to be of service to the Fellowship at all. This requires commitment and dedication to our primary purpose.

In order to emphasize the importance of letting it begin with me, I feel it necessary to let you know what happened to me when I did not think that way. I first came to A.A. in 1954, when I was 23 years old. At first I was as active as I knew how, but, through various circumstances, I began to drift away. Eventually, I no longer belonged to a home group, and nothing in A.A. began with me. Although I attended meetings for a while longer, I eventually drifted away and A.A. became a distant memory. Whatever was being done in Alcoholics Anonymous was being done by someone else. The day came when I had not had a drink in over 19 years, and I convinced myself that maybe I wasn't that bad. I took a drink, truly believing that this time would be different. Four years went by before I found it possible to walk through the doors of A.A. again, and when I did, I found myself in a completely different ball game; nothing seemed the same and I sometimes lived life an hour at a time. At first I did nothing more than go to meetings, but eventually I got involved in the Steps, the Big Book, and Twelfth Step work. I became active in my home group, and after a few years found myself becoming more and more involved in general service. At first I didn't even know what general service was, so it was never in my plan to carry on as I did; I simply took on one job at a time. By so doing, it has become the most incredible journey of my life and, in fact, has literally saved my life. If I want to keep what I have, then I must "Pass It On." It must begin with me.

When I think of preserving our Fellowship I can't help but think of the difficulties that must have been encountered by those who came before us, how so much is now taken for granted by so many of our members, and why it is so important to preserve what we have been given. I think of the first 20 years, when, starting from scratch, we wound up with the Big Book, the Steps, the Traditions, the Concepts, the Warranties, and the whole general service structure. And I think of how the Three Legacies of Recovery, Unity and Service were turned over to the movement by its oldtimers. All we have to do is preserve what we have been given.

On page 332 of *As Bill Sees It*, Bill stated that since 1938, the greatest part of his A.A. life had been spent in helping to create, design, manage, and insure the solvency and effectiveness of A.A.'s world services - the office of which has enabled our Fellowship to function all over the globe and as a unified whole. It was his way of ensuring A.A. would be preserved for future generations. The idea that he spent so much time on one aspect of the Fellowship is a small indication of how important it was—and is. Bill also states on page S8 of *The A.A. Service Manual* that the most vital, yet least understood, group of services that A.A. has are those that enable us to function as a whole, namely general services, which include the General Service Office, A.A. World Services, Inc., the A.A. Grapevine, Inc., and our board of trustees, known legally as the General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous. Our worldwide unity is directly traceable to this cluster of life-giving activities.

The idea that general services are the most vital, yet least understood group of services that we have, is probably truer today than ever before. How many of our members have a good understanding and knowledge of the general service structure? How often do we hear the statement "I don't want to get involved in the politics of A.A.," or "Ya—I went to one of those assemblies once, but all they did was fight and argue. I'll never go back there again." How often do members refer to "us and them," or "Look what they did now"? Have you ever seen a newcomer given the job of G.S.R. simply because it would be good for him? When I hear these kinds of comments or criticism I have an obligation to speak up. It is my responsibility to be informed so that I can pass on the right information. "...you



cannot transmit something you haven't got." (*Alcoholics Anonymous*, p. 164)

I find it hard to believe how often I find myself discussing issues that, in my opinion, would harm or dilute our Fellowship. I have been told several times recently that our singleness of purpose is outdated; that if Bill were alive today, perhaps his drug of choice would be heroin; that whether I like it or not, alcohol is a drug and that makes me an addict. I hear others saying, "What's wrong with changing the Big Book," or, as I heard at a meeting a few weeks ago, "I've done my share, let the younger ones do it now." If I want our Fellowship to be preserved, it is up to me to have the right information and to speak out when I hear these kinds of questions and comments.

I have been given tremendous gifts since coming to A.A., not only the gift of sobriety, but the gift of a second chance, and the gift of a happy and useful life. It is up to me to pass on these gifts by not only sharing my experience with others, but by being what I propose to be. I must lead by example. If I am telling members about being active in service I must be active in service myself; if I am speaking about the benefits of the Twelve Steps I need to be practicing them in my own life. When speaking about the Twelve Traditions, I ought to be following them, and if a group conscience is being sought I need to present all the facts so that an informed group conscience can be reached. I need to resist the temptation to impose my own will. If it is to begin with me, I must demonstrate the tolerance, patience, and understanding that is so often needed and lacking. Gratitude is something to be demonstrated, not just talked about, and the only way I know how to do that is to play an active part whenever I can. This is a Fellowship of action and participation; it's being "part of" and having a sense of belonging. I emphasize the word Fellowship, because more and more I hear people referring to the "program," which to me is another way our movement is being watered down. A.A. is not a Twelfth Step program. Alcoholics Anonymous is a Fellowship, a Fellowship of men and women who share their experience, strength and hope with each other. The Twelve Steps are a program within the Fellowship. I need to know what I belong to and it's important that I let others know.

A few weeks ago, a past D.C.M. where I live related that he had met a practicing alcoholic who desperately needed help. My friend told him something of himself and of A.A. and suggested he might like to try it. The response was shocking. The potential member told my friend that he had already tried A.A., that someone had taken him there about a year ago. The problem was that he couldn't stay sober the required thirty days, could not come up with the required initiation fee, and could not afford the monthly dues. Upon further questioning, it turned out he had been taken to an Alano Club and these were their requirements for membership. He was told it was A.A., and went away truly believing this to be the case. So often in the past I have been inclined to shrug off some of the complaints I have heard about outside entities and the appearance of affiliation, but here was a case where it could quite easily have cost a life. More and more I see how incredible our Traditions are and why it is so crucial that I do my part to preserve them.

Since I was in grade one in school, I have felt more at home sitting in the back row than I did up front. In fact, shortly after I came back to A.A. I was attending a closed men's meeting and at the end someone pointed at me and said, "It's your turn to chair the meeting next week." I won't tell you what I thought but I never went back. Little did I know I would someday become delegate of our area. With all the responsibility that goes with it, it is important for me to remember where I came from and to give the same breathing room to my fellow mem-

bers that I needed. I need to guard against the idea that I know it all or that I'm always right; we all have the right to be wrong and to make mistakes, and we all in turn do just that. I need to remind myself that we are like pieces of coal—heaped together they can burn warmly and brightly, push them to one side and they grow cold and black and no longer give light. I might be the only Big Book that someone may read, and if it is to begin with me, I must be the best example I can. There is no end to what I can do to help preserve what we have.

At each meeting of my home group we read the following: "When anyone, anywhere reaches out for help, I want the hand of A.A. always to be there, And for that: I am responsible." If enough of us truly believe this, I believe that A.A. can and will be preserved for future generations, and that it can begin with me.

Alex Palmer, B.C./Yukon

Preserving Our Fellowship — Carrying Our Original Message

It is my understanding that the "original" A.A. message is contained in our basic text, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, where the Foreword to the First Edition states, "To show other alcoholics precisely how we have recovered is the main purpose of this book." (p. xiii) Bill W. often told the story of events that led to publication of the first Big Book. Bill recounted that history for members of the 1966 General Service Conference when he said "This message had to be carried, and this book could be a prime agent of its carriage."

My spiritual awakening began—against my will—when I was taken to my first A.A. meeting of the LaBranch Street Group, which became my home group. It was there that I heard that the A.A. way of life was available to me if I trusted God and cleaned house. What an order! My desire to stop drinking was real, but my repeated failures to get sober on my own resources had intensified my rebellious, cynical nature. For my first two weeks in A.A., I tried to get by without a sponsor—why would I want to spend time with a woman? At last, I was trapped by an A.A. woman who volunteered to be my sponsor. Before long, I was "handed off" to Jeanne S., who began to move me into the A.A. way of life.

Jeanne's style of sponsorship sprang from her simple, unshakable belief in A.A. as the solution for alcoholics. Her love, patience and steadfastness were so impressive that, in spite of a strong self-will, I slowly became more willing. I followed Jeanne and other oldtimers into a weekly Step Study meeting, where I began to read the Big Book.

Throughout those early days I heard that each A.A. member was responsible for the welfare of the group, and for A.A. as a whole. My early reactions to those ideas were to try to bulldoze my heavy drinking friends into an A.A. meeting, and to generally interpret A.A.'s welfare as dependent on the number of members, and the size of my group's treasury.

Observed at the Conference

Several young Asian men (hotel waiters and kitchen workers) standing in front of the display board of A.A. literature in Chinese, Japanese, Korean & Vietnamese —pointing and animatedly talking to each other.

George Dorsey searching (many times) through the foliage of the potted shrubbery in front of the hotel—looking for his cigar, of course!

Around this time, the LaBranch Street Group was having money problems, and a nearby Al-Anon group offered to donate \$100 to help us out, which sounded like a good solution to me. The \$100 Al-Anon gift was the subject of the next group business meeting, where I heard the oldtimers talk about the need for A.A. to decline outside contributions. Jeanne, my new sponsor, talked about the privilege of self-support, which also sounded good to me, but impractical. The group declined the Al-Anon gift, and resolved to look for ways that each member could participate in supporting the group and A.A. as a whole.

When the meeting ended, I asked Jeanne about the "theories" that the oldtimers had shared with the group. She said that the discussion had been based on A.A.'s Traditions, which were principles as important to the survival of the LaBranch Street Group as the Steps were to my sobriety and hers. I'd seen the Twelve Traditions hanging on the wall, but had no idea they pertained to me. Jeanne suggested that we begin to study one Tradition each week when the two of us got together to read the Big Book.

How am I to help carry our original message without getting into territory that is beyond A.A.'s scope? When I greet newcomers, or participate in working with someone still drinking, I try to rely on my first experience with making a Twelfth Step call. Two oldtimers took me along to call on a young lady who had contacted Intergroup. Our prospect vividly recounted her multiple living problems, and my A.A. friends responded with examples of how alcohol had affected every area of their lives. Twice during that afternoon and night, I tried to offer suggestions for "solving" our friend's problems with her boyfriend and his mother. Each time, I was gently interrupted by the simple statement that all A.A. can promise an alcoholic is sobriety, one day at a time. I was shown that my sober A.A. experience of three weeks was worth sharing with this young person, who was quite drunk. As it turned out, our new person did not stay sober, and I was devastated until, through repetition of similar experiences, I saw that "we," who carried the message, stayed sober.

Which brings me to "Preserving our Fellowship." Do I interpret "preserve" defensively, as in "keep safe from injury or decay?" I can be so sure that a line or two in *The A.A. Service Manual* or some other vital A.A. literature is being misinterpreted that I can overlook opportunities to carry the A.A. message. Worse yet, the example I set may discourage a newer member from participating in A.A. service. During this 46th Conference, if I compete with you for time at the microphone, or try to convey God's will for us in whispered conversations out in the hall, please know that "I" will be in charge again, and away from the trust expressed in Tradition Two.

The Nu Garden Group is now my "home" in A.A., and we recently went through a series of business meetings that were less than harmonious. You won't be surprised to hear that the subject was "money," as in rent, expenses for hospitality (anniversary cakes, cookies, etc.), and support of A.A. services. From the initial proposal to increase our rent payment to the church where we meet, the first two business meetings deteriorated into suggestions that a member had "cooked the books" to misrepresent our expenses, that others were putting their affiliation with the church ahead of the group's welfare, and that group members involved in general service appeared to believe that they were above the rest of us.

The talk was tough, and the outcome was sour looks on many faces, which carried over into the next week's meeting. The polarization seemed to be eroding the group's welfare and affecting our primary purpose. The group chairperson called four members together for a "steering committee" meeting, which some, including me, approached with reluctance.

Two of the four members came from adamant, and opposite,

solutions to our dilemma. The first hour of the meeting was devoted to some loud discussion that was occasionally interrupted by suggestions that our opinions and individual understanding of the Traditions were less important than that the group's welfare be based on solutions that sprang from God as our final authority, expressed through the group conscience. By the second hour, three members came to a decision that remained unacceptable to one. The member in the minority was given time to share at length. His words were sincere and almost desperate, when suddenly he said, "I understand that my recovery depends on A.A. unity. I will support the decisions of the majority." With sighs of gratitude and relief, we agreed to bring our consensus to the entire group conscience for consideration. In the interim, we would "turn over" the outcome of our meeting.

All was not serene in the weeks leading up to the next business meeting. The time arrived, and we were graced with a speaker sober more than 40 years, who conveyed the A.A. message in simple terms; he stressed what he found when he came in, and what he had experienced since. He reminded us that "We are people who normally would not mix. But there exists among us a fellowship, a friendliness, and an understanding which is indescribably wonderful. . . . The tremendous fact for every one of us is that we have discovered a common solution. We have a way out on which we can absolutely agree, and upon which we can join in brotherly and harmonious action." (*Alcoholics Anonymous*, p. 17)

The business meeting that followed was different in several aspects. First, the number of members present was double the usual turnout for "business." Second, the chairperson invited sharing from each member present, not to exceed two minutes. As we went around the room, there were no angry expressions. Most expressed concern that the group stay together and willingness to do whatever it took toward that end. The "money" aspect seemed remote as one member after another offered to contribute what they could. Some volunteered to take turns baking cakes for our monthly anniversary celebrations, others decided to work together to purchase coffee and other essentials in bulk, and a few, who had previously taken no responsibility in serving the group, volunteered to help set up a meeting each week. Best of all (to me) was hearing five people sober longer than ten years decide to attend the Southeast New York Share-A-Day. At the same time, our alternate G.S.R., who'd been skeptical of general service, spoke enthusiastically of his commitment to serve the group in that way.

I'm as interested as you are in "preserving our message." We may not always agree on how a Conference committee's agenda item should be handled. Perhaps, if we can agree on our basic, or "original," message, we will serve together rather than apart. I would like to suggest that we base our actions on these simple statements in the Big Book (p. 60):

"Our description of the alcoholic, the chapter to the agnostic, and our personal adventures before and after make clear three pertinent ideas:

- (a) That we were alcoholic and could not manage our own lives.
- (b) That probably no human power could have relieved our alcoholism.
- (c) That God could and would if He were sought."

Joanie Moncrief, G.S.O. staff

Arnold Ross (Maryland) and chairman of the board Jim Estelle showed up one day with the same tie (both given to them by their daughters).

Preserving Our Fellowship — Unity and Spirituality in All Our Affairs

The spirituality of Alcoholics Anonymous is the recognizable action of a loving God, reflected in the sobriety and lives of individual members and in the principles of our Fellowship. Our spirituality is based on the great truth that each of us comprehends and recognizes this loving power differently. The spirituality of A.A. is compassionate and understanding. Faith is not required for membership, the alcoholic needs only a desire to stop drinking before declaring membership with us. There is no code of conduct, not even a fee. Our chief activity is sharing our experience, strength and hope in our recovery from alcoholism. Nothing can be gained from our efforts as members — no money, no power, no prestige — only the opportunity to share and to serve and to live.

We are not unique because we've been given these principles. There are many spiritual and religious organizations, even some businesses, that incorporate similar principles and practices. I have known nonalcoholics who practice many of our principles with great effectiveness. We have at least seven with us today, our treasured nonalcoholic trustees.

The aspect of A.A. that is extraordinary is our desperate need for sobriety. For most members that I know, Alcoholics Anonymous meets a life and death need. Sobriety and the privilege of working through our Steps came to me when the Grace of God and a moment of truth awakened me to my powerlessness and the alcoholic obsession. I immediately knew freedom and received strength and insight to go on. No one but an alcoholic can understand the depths of our madness for alcohol. We are beyond human aid. We had to have God's help, and help has been given in our generation. The long chain began when Ebby sought Bill, Bill found Bob, and together they approached Bill D. The truth of our own experience, strength and hope seems to help when nothing else can. By the grace of a Power beyond ourselves we share our gift with another, who accepts it and passes it on. I look at my sponsor, at the men and women of my home group, and I see those whom God has used to save my life, and I feel purpose and hope. The conviction of obligation is overpowering. I owe my life, and in order to live I must find another and pass it on. We need each other and we need God to do the work of A.A. As these needs are met there are great joys, sorrows, pains — wisdom born from ignorance, courage from weakness, and from self-absorption rises the desire to give. We know the meaning of love.

This word, "love," brings the thought of unity, a united Fellowship seeking to share its message with the alcoholic who still suffers. We seek to reach the alcoholic, and we must individually work to this end or we may fall from the grace of God. We receive life, we share life and our experience, and we are given more. We must give more, for to whom much is given much is expected. Because we have experienced alcoholic obsession, and know the craving that never stops, new members may hear and identify.

The temptation to broaden our purpose beyond the alcoholic who still suffers has been with us from the beginning. Those who have given in to it have seen the division it brings, the insecurity and the lack of focus. Our practice of singleness of purpose is vital to active alcoholics who have begun the journey to our door. Bill, always concerned with our public relations, says it this way, "... we must still realize that the more the society of Alcoholics Anonymous... tends to its own affairs and minds its own business, the greater will be our general influence, the less will be any opposition to us, and the wider will be the circle in

which our fellowship will be likely to enjoy the confidence and respect of men." (*A.A. Comes of Age*, p. 233)

Our Traditions ask us individually to sacrifice self, to give up our natural inclination for recognition, power and prestige, to recognize our limitations, and to take a back seat to the conscience of the whole. We're given a voice, the opportunity to have an effect, but the final actions are of the whole. The voice we seek is not one voice, or a few, but the voice of all. We work for unanimity and, though never ruled by a minority, we listen and frequently respond to its often wise position. We develop that tolerance muscle during our long and arduous discussions. We give those who serve us the right to decide matters within the scope of their work, and when a committee or a board is involved, those who serve are given the right of participation by vote. When we submit ourselves to the conscience of the whole, to experience our Concepts and Traditions, we are placing our Fellowship more deeply into the hands of a loving God.

Outside of our membership there are few who are concerned for our future. Many nonalcoholics, even those who are affected by our illness, will not have a deeply felt obligation to our future. So many are only dimly aware that we exist. Perhaps, if we are succeeding in our relationship with the nonalcoholic world, we are thought of as a quiet, secure, organization to whom an alcoholic may be directed, where many have received sobriety.

Our chief means of avoiding adverse publicity and public controversy are personal anonymity at the public level, and our Tradition of self-support. Self-support, sacrificial contributions from our pockets, is a powerful tool for autonomy. It is the most tangible evidence of our taking responsibility for A.A. Literature income has supported many of our services over all our years. Relying on it, we rely a little less on conscience and a little more on the market for our products. Our Grapevine relies solely on sales of subscriptions and related items. With self-support we avoid alliances and the need for benefactors. We need never pay the piper and no piper calls our tune. This Tradition is a breath of fresh spiritual air for all those who ask: Where does A.A. obtain its funding?

The unselfishness expressed through the practice of anonymity is our spiritual foundation. A seeker of approval and human acceptance, I've been short on anonymity and long on self. In our Fellowship no alcoholic exceeds another, we are a society of equals. For a time, our responsibilities may differ, but service never lends us authority, one over another. I'll never forget my relief at learning that there was nothing I had done or could do to be thrown out of A.A. Years ago, society had begun the process of evicting me for much of what it knew about me; surely they would have finished the job had they found out much more. That first group and its members offered me the comfort of their confidence. So much has been given to ensure my life, my seat at the meeting.

A.A. and a loving God succeed in the lives of perhaps two million alcoholics worldwide. Our Fellowship at 61 may be in its youth. In Managua, Petropavlovsk, Havana, Brussels, Budapest, Prague, Bratislava, Tokyo, here at home and in so many countries around the world, A.A. has made a beginning. Perhaps in some not so distant day our international membership will exceed the members sober here at home. During the 1994 World Service Meeting in Cartagena I experienced a dimension of spirituality and unity that defies description. The depth and breadth of A.A. is beyond the limit of human description and imagination. A.A.s everywhere long for unity and for a blessed future for our Fellowship.

Deep within, each of us knows that A.A. is a gift, that we are not the source of our sobriety. The gift is given—not earned.

The Fellowship is not ours alone, it is a fellowship of spirit. The treasured unity of today and the unity in our future belongs to the constantly renewed mix of God and man that is the essence of A.A. What quality in our spirituality best insures A.A.'s future? Bill's words, from his 1947 Memphis talk, serve better here than mine: "The wine of forgetfulness might make us dream that Alcoholics Anonymous was *our* success rather than *God's* will. The very malignancy which once tore us apart personally could again commence to rend us as groups. False pride might lead us to controversy, to claims of power and prestige, to bickerings over property, money and personal authority. We would not be human if these illnesses didn't sometimes attack us.

"Therefore, many of us think today the main problem of Alcoholics Anonymous is this: How, as a movement, shall we maintain our humility—and so our unity—in the face of what the world calls a great triumph? Perhaps we need not look far afield for an answer. We need only adapt and apply to our group life those principles upon which each of us has founded his own recovery. If humility can expel the obsession to drink alcohol, then surely humility can be our antidote for that subtle wine called success." (*The Language of the Heart*, p. 68)

I believe, if we sincerely ask the God of our understanding, we will always be given all we need to live out the fidelity expressed in our statement of unity, "This we owe to A.A.'s future; to place our common welfare first; to keep our Fellowship united. For on A.A. unity depend our lives, and the lives of those to come."

Larry Nelson, trustee-at-large/U.S.

ARCHIVES – PRESERVING OUR HISTORY

All A.A.s love our history and Conference members enjoyed the two archives presentations Monday afternoon. The session was chaired by Bill Bungay, Eastern Canada trustee and chair of the trustees' Archives Committee.

G.S.O. Archives: Window on the Past, Guide to the Present, and Light for the Future

I appreciate this opportunity to share on something that I feel particularly passionate about—our collective A.A. history and its relevancy to our survival; the anchor of our Fellowship. A.A. members relish histories, consciously or not. Our A.A. lives are spent, usually happily, listening endlessly to oral histories, hearing again, and again, the underlying theme: (a) That we were alcoholic and could not manage our own lives. (b) That probably no human power could have relieved our alcoholism. (c) That God could and would if He were sought. (*Alcoholics Anonymous*, p. 60)

In each of our individual stories we hear of drinking causing collapse; then, following a serendipitous contact with Alcoholics Anonymous, a complete transformation of our lives through the remarkably simple application of our Twelve Steps. A clear demonstration of alchemy, turning lead into gold. Doesn't it appear startlingly fresh with each telling? I have listened to these personal histories now for over a quarter of a century, with a deepening sense of wonder.

With a growing recognition that our collective history also merited retention, our Fellowship's Archives was opened in 1972 by Tom Sharpe, former general service trustee; Bob Hitchins, G.S.O. general manager; and Nell Wing, Bill W.'s secretary for 22 years and the first G.S.O. archivist. Bill W. stated the purpose was "... to keep the record straight so that myth does not predominate over fact as to the history of the Fellowship." (*Handbook for Setting Up an Alcoholics*

Anonymous Repository, p. 13) In the ensuing years, the collection has proliferated. Each year has brought forth a fuller appreciation of just what we've got. Throughout the Fellowship, particularly in the last decade, the interest in our history has exploded. At last count, 63 of the 92 delegate areas had an active archivist. Many of these areas have district archivists as well. This body, joined by other interested historians, generate about 40 requests per week for detailed historical data on earlytimers, groups, districts, and areas. As some of you know from firsthand experience, our researcher, Noela Jordan, spends a good chunk of her life pouring over old directories, newspaper clippings, and files hunting up the "earliest" and "firsts." Not a few areas have published impressively detailed local histories that document A.A.'s beginnings and growth. The memories of a multitude of earlytimers have been captured on tape. And joyously, under the skill and guidance of Judit Santon, our assistant archivist, a large beginning has been made on scanning our material for computer access, with the aim of cutting future response time, making a larger body of material available, and avoiding physical damage to the fragile original documents in the collection. Is all this attention to our past necessary, some have asked?

As our co-founders, Bill and Bob, often stated, we, the present members of Alcoholics Anonymous, are links in an ancient chain of alcoholics stretching back through time. And haven't alcoholics been a perplexing problem to society for centuries? For example, Solomon laments, almost 3000 years ago, "Who hath woe? Who hath sorrow? Who hath contentions? Who hath babbling? Who hath wounds without cause? Who hath redness of eyes? They that tarry long at the wine... Look not upon the wine when it is red, ... when it moveth itself aright. At the last it biteth like a serpent, and stingeth like an adder. Thine eyes shall behold strange women, and thine heart shall utter perverse things.... They have stricken me, shalt thou say, and I was not sick; they have beaten me and I felt it not: When shall I awake? I will seek it yet again." (Proverbs 23:29-35)

It seems that alcoholics baffled Solomon; and we continue to baffle others and ourselves. Drunkenness is not new to our own shores. Someone observed that the pilgrims stopped at Plymouth Rock not because they wanted to settle in Massachusetts, but because they had run out of booze.

Let's take a brief look through an archival window at some of the attempts over the ages to offer us sufferers some relief to our malady. In 1782, Benjamin Rush, prominent physician and signer of the Declaration of Independence, wrote a 17 page medical paper on our condition entitled, "The Effects of Ardent Spirits on the Human Body and Mind." In it he terms alcoholism "a progressive and odious disease" and urges complete abstinence as the only effective treatment. The paper was widely circulated and well received, becoming a cornerstone document of the Temperance Movement. Yet, the points he made for abstinence from alcohol as the treatment for a progressive disease seem to have been often forgotten and frequently challenged. In such a fickle public arena, it's nice to remind ourselves that A.A., as such, has no opinion on the matter. Our Big Book terms it an illness. Whatever society may choose to call it, I seem to have gotten a bad case of it.

Another opportunity for us alcoholics was embodied in The Washingtonian Temperance Society, which had uncovered a workable formula. After a founding in March of 1840 by six drunks at Chase Tavern in Baltimore, the group experienced a meteoric rise, recording 1,000 members before the end of that year. Abraham Lincoln addressed their Second Anniversary celebration. Their message was simple: 1) the drunkard could be rescued; he was weak, not wicked; 2) relating personal experi-

ence by a reformed drunkard was more moving and persuasive than a lecture by a well meaning nonalcoholic; 3) the simplicity of the pledge, requiring only one thing—personal abstinence; and 4) neutrality on the subjects of politics, religion, and the distribution and sale of alcoholic beverages. Not unlike the elements in our own Preamble.

Initially, the Washingtonian movement was virtually entirely made up of reformed “sots.” Later, others flocked to their meetings and took the pledge and the “fellowship of sufferers” became diluted. In spite of their stated aims, to avoid politics, etc., many members took opposing sides publicly on alcohol reform and other issues. Importantly, there was no principle of anonymity to protect the society from erring members. Within eight or nine years it was reported that the Washingtonians “had lost their thunder.” At their zenith, the press reported that there were 500,000 recovered sots in the Washingtonians. Since the population of the country in those years was a recorded 20 million, I calculate that A.A. would have to have 7,500,000 members in the U.S. alone to have that same ratio. One can’t help but ponder the fate of those members when the fire went out.

Another promising answer for the reclamation of the alcoholic was the Emmanuel Movement, founded by a clergyman psychologist, Elwood Worcester, in 1906. Worcester had a deep conviction that the physician and clergyman could work more effectively together in the treatment of functional ills; he had studied, interestingly enough, in Leipzig with Gustav Fechner, one of the pioneers in psychotherapy and one of Carl Jung’s professors. His book outlining his theories, *Religion and Medicine, the Moral Control of Nervous Disorders*, appeared in 1908 and had nine printings in the year of publication. Alcoholism, not surprising to us, constituted the largest category within “nervous disorders.”

Two successful graduates of the process were Courtenay Baylor, who became the first paid alcoholism lay counselor, and Richard Peabody, a prominent lay therapist and author of *The Common Sense of Drinking*, a runaway best-seller of its day (1930), that had found a home in Bill W.’s library. After a couple of decades successfully treating alcoholics, public controversy entered and diminished their effectiveness. The clergymen publicly quarreled with the physicians. Thus the movement did not last much beyond the life and energy of its founder.

Our immediate ancestor, the Oxford Group, later renamed Moral Rearmament, has a similar story; it had initially impressive results through a proven method of personal spiritual transformation. Bill asserts in *A.A. Comes of Age*, that all of our spiritual principles come directly from the Oxford Group, and by way of Sam Shoemaker, its New York leader at Calvary Church, where Bill attended his first meetings with Ebby and Roland H. The Oxford Group had the ability to fill vast arenas, like the Hollywood Bowl in 1939, where 25,000 filled the inside and another 10,000 waited outside. Yet today there’s little awareness of their immense influence outside of Alcoholics Anonymous.

Our own present guide, or “founding moment” to recovery from the illness of alcoholism, is thought by many of us to have begun with an encounter just before Armistice Day in 1934, between our co-founder Bill and a childhood friend, Ebby, a recent recruit in the Oxford Group. Bill and Lois were living in Brooklyn Heights. Ebby was sober—something Bill hadn’t expected to see; he left Bill a description of a program of simple actions, one designed to produce a spiritual awakening. Bill continued to drink for a few more weeks, but after his fourth admission to Town’s Hospital on December 11, 1934, he experienced his “sudden and profound” spiritual event that changed him and the lives of the alcoholics in this room. For he then, like Ebby, caught fire and set about trying to ignite the same passion

for sobriety that had been let loose in himself. It is said that Bill tried and failed with 40 men. He then ventured to Akron and tumbled into the lives of Dr. Bob and Ann. He was to stay with the Smiths for almost three months, and together they carried the message with zeal to many others. When he left Dr. Bob’s, there was one other on the road to recovery, Bill D., a lawyer. What was to become Alcoholics Anonymous had begun.

Thus A.A. started on the Road of Happy Destiny. And, initially at least, our growth was slow. Most likely a good thing. It took almost four years to gather 100 members, and publish a basic textbook. Like those movements before us, Bill was to observe in a talk given in Memphis in September 1947, that success was a “serious problem.” He stated, “The wine of forgetfulness might make us dream that Alcoholics Anonymous was *our* success rather than *God’s* will. . . . How, as a movement shall we maintain our humility—and so our unity—in the face of what the world calls a great triumph? Perhaps we need not look far afield for an answer. We need only adapt and apply to our group life those principles upon which each of us has founded his own recovery. If humility can expel the obsessions to drink alcohol, then surely humility can be our antidote for that subtle wine called success.” (A.A. Grapevine, October 1947, p. 8)

In August, the previous month, it was reported that there were 48,613 members, in 1,650 groups, in 13 countries. Bill then set about the task of “assuring A.A.’s future” through the formulation of our Twelve Traditions. He knew that these were the Light for our future. Each of these principles has a reality in the records of our early years, and deep in the documented experience of these earlier “successful” efforts to aid the alcoholic. Earlier movements failed not because they weren’t successful, but rather because they were; they demonstrated Bill’s point that success can be more damaging to a society than failure.

As in my own personal experience, failure gets my attention; success can make me “intoxicated.” When I lose, I may ask for help; if I hurt enough I might even take the advice. I find that I need the Twelve Steps in my life more than ever to assure my own emotional sobriety.

And our Fellowship needs the Twelve Traditions in our collective lives to assure Emotional Sobriety at the group and area levels. Although records on alcoholics are difficult to gather, it is estimated that there are now 2,000,000 members in approximately 89,000 groups in 146 countries.

So many of us in service throughout the A.A. world believe that a careful study of our history is essential—to deepen appreciation for our gifts and to foster a renewed effort to remember and carry forward our original message. Archives then are about keeping our collective history and its struggles before us, stimulating a feeling of humility and trust in God’s guidance; taking the abstract wording of our Traditions and transforming them into vital tools for survival. Keeping clear this window to our past can provide the best light for our future.

All service committees are concerned with carrying our message; by design, the trustees’ Archives Committee’s chief work is preserving our original message. For, as Carl Sandburg wrote, “Whenever a Society or Civilization perishes, there is always one condition present; they forgot where they came from.”

Frank Mauser, G.S.O. archivist

Area Archives: Local Gathering Place for Our Legacies

The very word, archives, may bring to mind a musty cavern filled with dust covered, untouched manuscripts—a chamber of dead artifacts. Others may equate archives with a museum

overflowing with shiny trinkets. I suggest that neither image accurately portrays the vibrant, living vehicle an area archives can be for preserving our history. A line in the Big Book reads, "Henry Ford once made a wise remark to the effect that experience is the thing of supreme value in life." (*Alcoholics Anonymous*, p. 124) Our experience, in our Legacies of Recovery, Unity and Service, is of value to those who follow us, and that places upon us, as trusted servants, the responsibility to assure that this experience is preserved.

While it is true that the program of Alcoholics Anonymous never changes, the Fellowship does change. It changes constantly! As our Fellowship has grown and flourished, many problems have threatened to destroy or diminish it. New problems surface; new solutions must be found within the spiritual principles of A.A. How these problems developed, and their ultimate solutions is in our recorded history — a history that must be captured and updated through the years.

Bill captured this history in *Alcoholics Anonymous Comes of Age*, barely two decades after A.A.'s beginnings. This endeavor was greatly facilitated by his personal memories of these events. However, Bill was a visionary, and he must have become aware, while drawing upon the shared experiences of other early members, that future written histories of A.A. would become increasingly difficult, due to our phenomenal growth, geographic dispersement, and the demise of our founders. In 1957, the year that *Alcoholics Anonymous Comes of Age* was published, Bill said, "...We are trying to build up extensive records which will be of value to a future historian. It is highly important that the factual material be placed in our files in such a way that there can be no substantial distortion. We want to keep on enlarging on this idea for the sake of the full length history to come...." (Handbook for Setting Up An Alcoholics Anonymous Archival Repository, p. i)

Bill's perception of the need for keeping the record accurate for an ever expanding Fellowship has been greatly facilitated through the years by the G.S.O. Archives having had "a special mandate from the trustees' Archives Committee to foster the development of local archives centers throughout A.A." (ibid p.1) Today, many A.A. communities consider the preservation of the history of the Fellowship in their area to be a vital function of our Legacies.

If we are to have the time, energy and funds to remain viable as a Fellowship as new problems surface, we must be able to learn from our past what works and what doesn't. Any society of people which does not learn from its history soon perishes! If we die, we will die from within, because we forgot where we came from and, therefore, we do not know where we are going. We will have lost our vision!

Walk with me, if you will, through a "vision" for area archives — a gathering place for our Legacies. On one wall is a cabinet of tapes that area groups have collected by interviewing their earlytimers to capture their memories of how the Fellowship has changed through the years. The printed transcription of the tapes are being used to compile a book of area history. In addition, there is an accumulation of many years of our area assembly meetings on tape. Recorded along with the business meetings are workshops, presentations on various topics, and delegates' reports.

On another wall are racks of shelves where boxes filled with letters, minutes, agendas and flyers are stored. These originated from our group, district and area activities and have become a rich source of inspiration for our area's service workers. Here, too, are the papers of past delegates and trustees, with their wealth of information from the Conference, our region, and other areas; these documents stretch our imaginations and

remind us that we are truly a part of a worldwide Fellowship. All of this material constitutes the written record for our area, our collective experience, and, through painstaking cataloging, this experience is readily accessible to those who need it.

Recent research in our area archives included an A.A. group's search for their lost meeting format; a district seeking their lost service structure; the area convention committee's list of speakers over the past ten years; and the area structure committee inquiring about past redistricting methods. In addition, a D.C.M. perused ten years of area convention committee policies on complementary admissions, and one area committee researched a decade of their minutes to develop future goals. At rotation time, many area and district chairs will access the area archives for research in setting future goals and planning activities, drawing on the experience of past committees for inspiration.

Bill Wilson perceived the First Legacy as being "embodied in the Big Book, in the Steps, and in person-to-person Twelfth Step work." (*"Pass It On,"* p. 347) Our area archives contain the history of how the Big Book arrived in our area and of members' past efforts in carrying the message of the Twelve Steps to the still-suffering alcoholic — in their homes, in treatment facilities, and in prisons, as well as descriptions of how sponsorship has developed and changed in our area through the years. A study of these experiences shows clearly what worked for them and what was ineffective in carrying the message.

Perhaps no other spiritual principle is more readily apparent in our area archives than that of Anonymity. The importance of this foundation to our Second Legacy of Unity is woven throughout the materials in our archives and is, also, apparent while accessing them, for great care is extended in protecting the anonymity of members both living and deceased. While personalities are necessary in the recording of any history, our area archives emphasizes the spiritual movement of our Fellowship as forged by the personalities involved.

Here, too, are found in our area's records the birth of our area assembly, the election of our first delegate, the beginnings of our districts, and the many problems which arose throughout the years and the effective solutions found through the Twelve Traditions. With foresight, our area's future trusted servants will have no need to replot old ground.

In 1951, Bill wrote, "Our Twelfth Step — carrying the message — is the basic service that the A.A. Fellowship gives; this is our principle aim and the main reason for our existence. Therefore, A.A. is more than a set of principles; it is a society of alcoholics in action. We must carry the message, else we ourselves can wither and those who haven't been given the truth may die. Hence, an A.A. service is anything whatever that helps us to reach a fellow sufferer.... The sum total of all these services is our Third Legacy of Service." (The A.A. Service Manual, p. S7)

When our Fellowship was in its infancy, this service was performed through the Twelfth Step exclusively, as one alcoholic talked to another, sharing his experience, strength and hope. Indeed, Bill shared the history of his spiritual awakening and how it came about with Dr. Bob. Thus, the message we carry today is the history of our personal recoveries in A.A. The message remains that simple and personal.

Early in our history, it became apparent that many alcoholics would die needlessly if a way was not found to perform this service over a broader area. So, our founders compiled a history of their experiences in a book, "To show other alcoholics *precisely how we have recovered.*" (*Alcoholics Anonymous*, p. xiii) The Fellowship's much loved Big Book was its first archival activity!

"Still you may say: 'But I will not have the benefit of contact with you who write this book.'" (ibid, p. 164) This statement is as true today as when it was written in 1939; I don't have the

benefit of having met Bill. But in our Area 04 Archives, I can read all about Bill's visit to Little Rock in 1944, and how that message of recovery was carried to South Arkansas and to my hometown of Camden. And, as a member of Alcoholics Anonymous, I am a part of that living Legacy.

Our Recovery, Unity and Service occur in a cycle, not a straight line. Extremism may threaten to divide us, but our archives provides a watering hole of preserved experience on all three levels to reunite us. An active area archives gives us access to more than just a log of what we did, but the history of *how* we did it. It is the precise application of those spiritual principles that provide the reservoir of experience from which each of us can draw. Whether it be an individual who wants to find out more about the famous Little Rock Approach Plan, a new G.S.R. trying to figure out how to conduct a group business meeting, a D.C.M. looking for ideas for his district convention, an area structure committee chair working through a redistricting issue, or a delegate dealing with an anonymity break, the practical application of the principles embodied in our Three Legacies by our area's past trusted servants can be drawn from the well of past experience to supply the inspiration they need.

Bill's vision for Archives, as stated by him in 1957, has begun to be a concrete reality in area archives. The vision of a "gathering place for our Legacies," that I have shared with you, has become a part of my personal experience. It has enriched my Recovery, assisted my experiences in Unity, and inspired my work in Service. It has become the repository for the shared experiences that my fellow A.A.s and I bequeath to the next generation of alcoholics. It is their Legacy.

Mary Bridges, Arkansas

REPORT: FINANCE

Monday afternoon the Finance report was given by the treasurer of the General Service Board, who also serves as the chairperson of the trustees' Finance & Budgetary Committee. For more details please see the Finance Section of this Report.

G.S.O. gets money from two sources: contributions and the sale of literature. And we spend money on two things: providing services and producing literature. Last year we had net sales of \$8.4 million from books, booklets, and pamphlets. It cost us \$5.3 million to print, ship, and pay royalties on these items, leaving us with a gross profit from literature of \$3.1 million. \$2.3 million of the expenses of running the office at 475 Riverside Drive is allocated to publishing, which leaves net income from publishing of \$854,000. Both gross profit and net income from literature are down around \$1.25 million from last year. You might recall that when A.A.W.S. lowered prices and increased discounts in 1994, to return to the Fellowship the excess amount in the Reserve Fund, they expected to cut literature income by about \$1 million. This they have done.

The second part of the G.S.O. financial picture is contributions and services. Contributions last year were down a very disappointing \$190,000 to \$3.7

million. This decline of 5% took place in the face of an economy that is stronger than it was. I don't know why contributions continue to fall, but we really need for them to start picking up. We spent \$5.7 million on services to the Fellowship, which was \$2 million more than we took in from contributions. Contributions covered 65% of services expenses last year, down from 72% the year before. Literature income covered the balance of 35%.

There are 55,930 groups listed with G.S.O. Services to the Fellowship costs us \$102 per group. The average contribution per group was \$66, counting both groups that contribute and those that don't. If each group listed at G.S.O. contributed \$36 more per year—that is 69 cents per week *per group*—contributions would have entirely covered the expense of providing services, and we could have cut literature prices by another 25%.

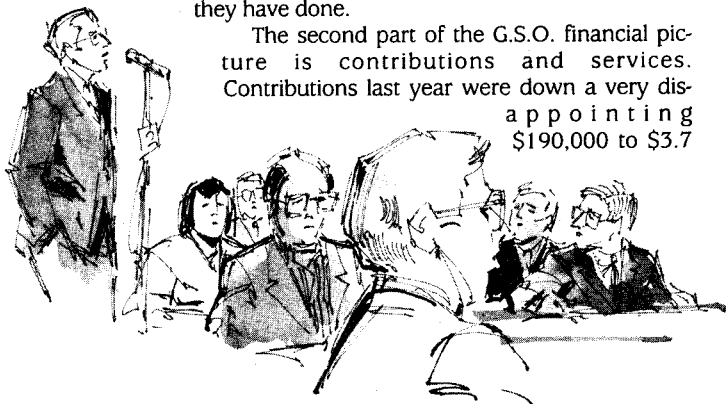
Use of literature profits to pay for services does not present us with a Traditions problem. Bill W. covered this very well in his essay on the Second Warranty. About literature income he wrote, "This set income to the groups and to A.A.'s General Services is actually the sum of a great many contributions which the book buyers make to the general welfare of Alcoholics Anonymous. The certain and continuous solvency of our world services rests squarely upon these contributions." (*Twelve Concepts for World Service*, p. 66) We should be concerned, however, if contributions should shrink to being too small compared with what we spend on services. I don't know what "too small" is, but it is something we should talk about.

Adding the \$854,000 profit from literature and the \$2 million loss from services together gives us our net loss for G.S.O. of \$1,158,000. This actual loss is larger than our originally budgeted loss of \$731,000. The two reasons for the shortfall from budget were due to higher paper costs and some lower selling prices, which put us \$294,000 below budget in gross profit from literature, despite the fact that sales were higher than we budgeted. Contributions were \$225,000 short of budget. Expenses were actually \$80,000 below budget.

In addition to the numbers I've been talking about, most of you already know that the International Convention in San Diego lost \$549,000 on-site, and an additional \$83,000 on unsold books. This disappointing result is due almost entirely to a shortfall in attendance—that is paid attendance. Our pricing and budget were based on 60,000 attendees to break even. Only 56,000 people paid to get in. We have spent a lot of time using perfect hindsight to see how we could have done better, and it is hard to see realistically what we could have done differently, other than to have made a better guess as to how many would pay to attend.

Our Reserve Fund finished the year at 11.1 months of combined G.S.O. and Grapevine operating expenses. A year ago it was 13.2 months. At the current level of \$8.5 million it amounts to \$153 per listed A.A. group. Our whole financial situation recently has been driven by the Reserve Fund. Remember, it grew not because contributions or literature sales were strong, but because we were able to control costs aggressively over the last five years. In 1994 we changed our accounting for shipping and warehousing, which added a month to this statistic, making worse our problem of appearing to have too much money. We cut literature prices by about \$1 million per year to bring the Reserve Fund back in line.

We felt we should bring the Reserve Fund below the Conference-mandated 12-month limit as quickly as possible, and realized that the reduced prices would result in losses that could not be sustained for long. If we had had more time to bring the Reserve Fund down, we would have made smaller price reductions that could have been left in place longer. Perhaps some future Conference might consider some language that would give us more time to get below the 12-month ceiling, while keeping in



place the understanding that it is not a good idea to stay above the 12-month limit indefinitely.

The Reserve Fund is now well within the Conference-approved upper limit of 12 months. Our forecast is that the Reserve Fund will total 9.5 months of expenses at the end of this year. I believe strongly that about 10 months is as low as we should go in normal times like the present. Not all of my fellow trustees are as conservative as I am on this figure, but it is clear to me that, after this year, G.S.O. should not continue to run large losses.

This year's budget takes back the 5% overall literature discount, and reduces the 30% discount on pamphlets and other nonbook items to 20%. These changes are scheduled to take place on August 1, three months after they are announced on May 1st.

For 1996, our budget calls for a loss of \$1,250,000. Net sales will be up a bit because of the removal of discounts for five months. Contributions are budgeted to rise 2%. Operating expenses will rise by \$324,000, but \$194,000 of this is for one-time items. The normal recurring amount of operating expenses will only go up by a modest 1.6%.

If this year's change in discounts were to be in effect for the whole year, instead of just five months, and if we were to take the nonrecurring \$194,000 out of operating costs, G.S.O. would still be losing \$670,000 at 1996's budgeted level of sales, contributions, and expenses. That \$670,000 is our current annualized level of losses, and it is too high for us to maintain given the projected level of the Reserve Fund.

For 1997, one or a combination of four things will have to take place. First, unit sales of A.A. literature could increase a lot, which doesn't seem likely given recent sales trends. Second, we could raise literature prices anywhere from 50 cents to \$1.00 per book depending on how we do it. Third, contributions could improve substantially. Or, number four, we could cut costs by a pretty big amount. While we must always work on doing what we do at lower costs by being more efficient, if we don't raise literature income or contributions substantially, we would inevitably have to cut some of the services we now provide. This would be a painful step for us to take. Some suffering alcoholics might not get the message of A.A. and the gift of sobriety, and our unity would probably suffer as a result of our diminished ability to communicate with the Fellowship. The boards will face some difficult choices next year as we put together our 1997 budget. My personal preference is to provide the services needed to carry the message and price our literature accordingly, but that is just my view, and how this comes out will be the result of a wide group conscience.

What you have just heard is simply a matter of financial reality. I really hope no one views this as a threat to cut services if contributions don't go up. All you have to do is look at our numbers to realize that we can't continue to lose half a million or a million dollars a year without eventually going broke.

Why are we now faced with this difficult prospect of raising prices or cutting services? Let's look at some history. A.A. grew rapidly during the 1980s and, at least when measured by book sales or contributions, has declined in the nineties. We don't have the growth umbrella to pay the bills the way we did in the eighties. Take for example unit sales of the Big Book. Sales grew from 300,000 in 1979 to 1.2 million ten years later. That's a growth rate of 15% per year. Growth in sales of the Twelve and Twelve was the same 15%, *Living Sober* grew at 13%, and so on. With unit sales like that, literature income was growing so rapidly that it was easy to support services. During the nineties, sales of all of our books have fallen off by anywhere from 18 to 40%.

Contributions in the eighties were growing at 13% per year, which helped pay for services. Notice, by the way, that contributions peaked at \$4.4 million in 1990. Last year, they were under

\$3.7 million. If contributions had just remained at \$4.4 million we wouldn't have to consider raising prices or cutting services.

Despite the decline in sales and contributions, and despite the rising costs of printing, we have been able to maintain services and cut prices since the peak years by careful control of costs and by drawing down the excess in the Reserve Fund. Literature is cheaper than it was in 1991, even though paper, printing, and shipping costs have all gone up. Operating and warehousing expenses are actually at the same level as they were six years ago. Lowering costs from the current level is likely to be much harder than it was over the last five years, and the drawdown in the Reserve Fund has gone as far as it can without, in my opinion, putting us in conflict with the Second Warranty's promise of "sufficient operating funds, plus an ample Reserve..." (ibid., p. 63)

So, the three reasons we have been able to maintain services without raising prices are no longer available to us. The rapid growth of the eighties is probably behind us. Cutting costs without affecting services is likely to be much more difficult. And we no longer have an excess Reserve Fund to spend.

The loss on the International Convention really played a minor role in our need to make these adjustments; the way I look at it is that the loss means we must make these revenue increasing or cost cutting moves a few months earlier than we otherwise would.

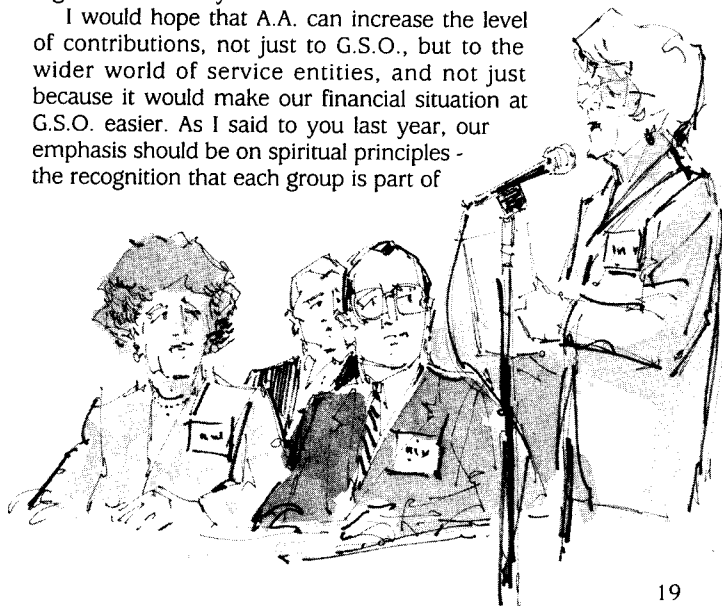
One of the reasons we didn't balance this year's budget with price increases was that we wanted to see if the Fellowship would respond to our new financial reality with higher contributions.

How much should raising literature prices bother us? Our books are really inexpensive. If the price of the Big Book had kept pace with inflation, it would sell for \$30.00 today. By any measure or comparison, A.A. literature is a great value.

The Grapevine has already faced a similar dilemma, and has announced a 25% increase in price to keep itself financially healthy, while increasing services by making all of its issues 64 pages long. You might recall that the Grapevine wanted to do this a year ago, but was asked not to by the trustees' Finance Committee. We asked them not to raise prices then because we had recently lowered prices at A.A.W.S., and because we were afraid they would lose circulation. I hope the delayed price increase helped support the excellent business moves they made to increase their circulation to 130,000 last year. I'm sure you all will tell your areas what a terrific value the Grapevine represents at \$1.25 per copy.

The other point I want to make about the Grapevine is to assure you that our thinking on the Reserve Fund includes the commitment to fund the Spanish Grapevine, so it may go on to be a successful part of carrying A.A.'s message to Spanish-speaking alcoholics everywhere.

I would hope that A.A. can increase the level of contributions, not just to G.S.O., but to the wider world of service entities, and not just because it would make our financial situation at G.S.O. easier. As I said to you last year, our emphasis should be on spiritual principles - the recognition that each group is part of



something much bigger than itself and has the opportunity to help carry the A.A. message around the world. Embracing the Seventh Tradition makes it possible to take the First and the Fifth Traditions off the printed page and put them into action. A group contribution, no matter how small, represents more than money. It represents a group's understanding of and desire for the services it pays for. It represents a contribution towards A.A. unity.

Gary Glynn,
Class A trustee & treasurer, G.S.B.

THE SEVENTH TRADITION: ITS IMPORTANCE TO THE FELLOWSHIP

Monday evening's presentations addressed our Tradition of Self-Support. Moderator was John Grant, G.S.O. staff.

Are We Self-supporting at all Levels?

"I am responsible...when anyone, anywhere, reaches out for help, I want the hand of A.A. always to be there. And for that: I am responsible."

Where and how does this responsibility begin? I recently attended a state sponsored workshop. Prior to that, I had found a presentation from a past delegate from Oklahoma, given at our 1979 Southwest Regional Delegates Assembly. Our area was very proud to be in the top three contributors to G.S.O., and proud of our responsibility for self-support. This has changed in recent years. All weekend I kept wondering what we were doing differently to drop in our percentages of contributions at all levels of service.

When I arrived home on Monday, I received this loving invitation to participate in this meeting on our Seventh Tradition of "Are We Self-supporting at all Levels?" Is that odd, or is that God?

It is with great concern that we share with each other ways of solving this dilemma. In my duties as area delegate, I have traveled to each of the districts in Oklahoma and observed several district meetings and listened to the sharing of D.C.M. reports at our area committee meetings, just as you have. Several questions have come to mind which I will pose for your thoughts.

With the ever-changing face of A.A., new challenges have developed. Many groups now meet in homes and are therefore, much smaller. Many groups only meet once a week. Smaller groups have less money, after expenses, to contribute to any service level. Many groups meet in clubhouses. Confusion and lack of understanding arise as to where contributions go—to the clubhouse or to A.A.? Many individual members also serve on the board of the clubhouses. Are they aware of their responsibility to the A.A. service structure, or is their allegiance to the making of a profit by the clubhouse corporation?

Are petty group splits creating weaker, less effective groups? We are cautioned in Tradition One in the Twelve and Twelve (p.130), that "... no personal sacrifice is too great for preservation of the Fellowship... that the clamor of desires and ambitions... must be silenced whenever these could damage the group. It becomes plain that the group must survive or the individual will not." Are members leaving their groups because their "friends" weren't elected to service positions? Are they taking negative inventories of the groups rather than their own positive inventories? Are they not accepting the ultimate authority as expressed in the group conscience?

There may be a lack of respect for people in service and for our General Service Office. Why? Are the G.S.R.s allowed sufficient time to communicate, through their reports, the needs of the service committees at all levels?

Do the groups and districts have a unified allocation of funds to all levels of service? In other words, levels mean having no part of service higher than the other. Are we remaining selfish and self-seeking by "earmarking" funds to serve a particular "pet project," thereby tying the hands of our trusted servants?

Where do our loyalties lie? Are they with our first call to the central service or intergroup office where we called for help, or somewhere else? Have we allowed one service committee to become more important than another? On a personal level, have I told the people I sponsor the importance of giving back to A.A., both of yourself and money? I began to look back over my own journey in sobriety. In the beginning, my vision was limited to my own recovery (as it should be), my own home group, my own central service office. I was perfectly content with my own sobriety, working with others through Twelfth Step calls and sponsorship and seeing them recover and families reunited. What more could there be?

Then, at three years of sobriety, I met a woman who loved this Fellowship and was committed to all areas of service—Panel 27 delegate from Oklahoma, Elizabeth E. She became my sponsor. Through her example and sharing, I became involved in service at the district level and began to learn the deeper meaning of the responsibility statement—gratitude in action.

Some years later, my husband became the Panel 39 delegate from Oklahoma to the General Service Conference. The first year I attended the Sunday Night Dinner and met some of you for the first time. I began to comprehend how large A.A. is and the role of the General Service Office in carrying the message worldwide. I knew about the services of G.S.O., but now it went from my head to my heart.

The second year there was a trip to Stepping Stones. It was during this visit that I had a spiritual experience. I had come full circle. I felt Bill's spirit of commitment and dedication to Alcoholics Anonymous and his gratitude for its way of life. It became imperative for me to pass on this commitment, to preserve the Legacies of Recovery, Unity and Service.

In studying Oklahoma service history, I learned that Panel 3 delegate, Ab B., was a good friend of Bill Wilson's. When Ab came back from the General Service Conference, he was fortunate to have the financial means to visit all of the groups in Oklahoma. Of course, there weren't 379 groups then either. Nevertheless, he conveyed to each of these groups the importance of what had occurred at the Conference and the meaning of self-support at all levels of service, as well as explaining the G.S.O. Birthday Plan. He explained what was being done at the General Service Office for the groups. That legacy of enthusiasm and commitment has been passed down to us through our past delegates.

For a period of time in past years, our area utilized past delegates for service committee chairs. They had a wealth of experience and their reports expressed much enthusiasm and gratitude—that it was our spiritual responsibility to reach the suffering alcoholic so the message could be carried worldwide.

Is this being done in all of the areas today? Could we or the past delegates perhaps be effective in visiting some of the non-

We can do anything but drink...

After a long session Wednesday evening some East Central region delegates and a few trustees departed for the Stardust Diner—and the place may never be the same! Trustee Don Weaver and George O. (NE Ohio) took the award for "best dancing couple"; Chicago delegate John Goldberg led the singing; and Tom Gore (Northern Illinois) got the "pigout award" having consumed an entire (8 scoops) "Deacon Drive."

supporting groups to convey the importance of how the message is carried at all levels? Tradition Nine in the Twelve and Twelve (p. 175), states: "Just as the aim of each A.A. member is personal sobriety, the aim of our services is to bring sobriety within the reach of all who want it."

Communication is the beginning of all understanding. Together we can do what I cannot do. Is there a weak link in our chain of communication? *The A.A. Service Manual* (p. S51) states that, "*The district committee member is an essential link between the group's G.S.R. and the area's delegate to the General Service Conference. As leader of the district committee, made up of all the G.S.R.s in the district, the D.C.M. is exposed to the group conscience of that district. As a member of the area committee, he or she is able to pass on this thinking to the area delegate and the area committee. How capably this is done is the measure of the D.C.M.'s effectiveness.*"

Are the D.C.M.s truly passing on groups' problems in money matters to the delegate? If so, what are we doing about it? Are they explaining the importance of self-support? Are they communicating to the groups the uses of their contributions at the district, area and G.S.O. levels? Are district funds being used to hold workshops on service and are newcomers urged to attend?

It has been my experience that when alcoholics are educated to the need, they rise to the responsibility. Concept IX, in *The A.A. Service Manual/Twelve Concepts for World Service* (p. 36) explains that "Good service leaders, together with sound and appropriate methods of choosing them, are at all levels indispensable for our future functioning and safety." Some of the keys to good service leadership are area-wide involvement, enthusiasm, hard-working commitment and gratitude. If the work is being done, it will be supported.

When I was elected area chairman in Oklahoma, contributions to G.S.O. and the area were both down considerably. I selected enthusiastic, hard-working, dedicated service chairpersons from as many different districts in the area as possible. By their example, they created enthusiasm in the districts; groups became involved and contributions rose. During a recent visit to a district meeting, I was asked to say a few words. I asked the G.S.R.s what they were doing with any excess money in their group treasuries. Were they using the new self-support pamphlet? The response I received was "What new self-support pamphlet?" Lack of communication? (I really *did* tell them about it.)

Another member of this district made a motion that after a prudent reserve and expenses of a district workshop, the balance in the district's treasury be divided between G.S.O. and our area committee. The motion passed unanimously. When the purpose and the need is communicated, the Fellowship will respond.

By example and communication, the importance of self-support can become clear. When I go to a restaurant, I leave a tip—"a gratuity"—a monetary expression to show that person my gratitude for his or her service. In Alcoholics Anonymous I have been given sobriety and a way of life that is truly indescribably wonderful. How much do I owe God and Alcoholics Anonymous for that? My gratitude is shown by passing on the recovery message to another alcoholic, one-on-one, and by making the message available through my contributions at all service levels. I have found that the key to a happy and useful life is to be involved in something greater than I am—Alcoholics Anonymous. You can sum up the A.A. program in six words—Trust God, Clean House and Help Others.

It is important that we recommit ourselves to strengthening the lines of communication. I am limited to working with alcoholics in my home group, central service, district or perhaps area, but through my contributions to all levels of service, I can help the suffering alcoholic in every part of the world to stay sober and

help other alcoholics to achieve sobriety, and for that—I Am Responsible.

Phyllis McCoy, Oklahoma

Are We Emphasizing the Traditions? Or Money?

Sometime within the first week of having my last drink I found my way into a meeting of Alcoholics Anonymous. Due to chronic alcoholism I had lost my teeth, my ability to read, and control over most of my bodily functions. I couldn't stop shaking. I was at the end of the road. I had nowhere else to go and, despite my best efforts, I couldn't die. I was welcomed at the door of the meeting by a man who, several years earlier, had asked me to leave a rather shoddy bar because of my inappropriate behavior. I went in. I figured if it was all right with him then I would probably be allowed to stay. I don't remember much about that meeting except that I was given hope that maybe I didn't have to drink again. No one told me how to believe in God or tried to sell me anything. I was encouraged to just show up and take what I wanted. It had been a long time since I felt welcome anywhere, and finally, here were people who understood where I had been and where I was now. I came back and did what was suggested, I got a sponsor and started on the road of recovery. My life changed that night.

During the initial meeting with my first sponsor he asked if I had a Big Book. When I said no he bought me one. I told him I'd pay him back and he said he expected nothing less. The day I received my first paycheck, from a not so good job, I did pay him. I also started contributing to the Seventh Tradition basket. I really wanted to be part of this thing. That first night he told me I couldn't keep what I had if I didn't give it away, and that I couldn't give away what I didn't have. He started me on my journey through A.A.'s Twelve Steps of recovery and got me into group service as the greeter for the 8:00 meetings.

Shortly afterward I went to my first steering committee meeting and was astounded to find that our treasurer had lost a great deal of the group's money, that he had brought a new car and left the group. We were in severe financial trouble, but no one felt it was appropriate to seek legal recourse. They were concerned he might drink and that they needed to be more careful when electing trusted servants. They felt they had let the man down by putting too much pressure on his short sobriety, and had let the group down by not having the foresight to see potential problems. I thought they were just nice people; I had no idea that what I was witnessing was the development of a greater understanding of a Higher Power at the group level. I came up with the incredibly wonderful idea of seeking help from a local charitable organization to get us through this dilemma. My sponsor began teaching me about our Twelve Traditions that very day, and once again, my life changed.

While studying the Seventh Tradition I learned that self-support is money in the basket, but it's more than that. It's participation by individual members to the group and by the group, through its elected trusted servants, to local service entities and A.A. as a whole. I found out that he who pays the bills calls the shots. At first, the most important thing to me was the need to have the freedom within our group to make all our own decisions. As my mind cleared I began to realize that with each freedom there is a responsibility, and that if we as a group didn't pay our way, no one would.

The Seventh Tradition became very important to me as an individual; it meant that I could belong. I could be a small part of a great whole, something I had never been before. It also meant that I could earn a living and start making financial amends in order to pay back the many debts that had built up through the

years. It meant that I had a chance to really be free one day.

I became very involved in my home group and then with service to our local Hospitals and Institutions Committee. I went to places that I never dreamed of going to help to carry this message of hope to the hopeless. The history of Alcoholics Anonymous became extremely important to me, as did serving this group of drunks that didn't drink and had literally given me life. I started to put Alcoholics Anonymous in front of my wants and needs.

As I was able to secure better jobs I found myself giving not only much of my time to Alcoholics Anonymous but also more money, usually in the basket and at times in a rather showy way. Through the process of maturity, which for me seems to be best gained through service and constantly living within the principles of our last three Steps, I became aware that if the Seventh Tradition was just about money, the haves could and certainly would support the have nots. Then we would likely become a society racked with perilous wealth and power, and the voice of Alcoholics Anonymous would not be heard through group participation but only through those who, in Bill's words, "paid the freight." The Fellowship had to be supported through a broad base of groups and the group had to be supported through a broad base of individual members. I was to give my fair share and not more. I learned that I was to be an example of leadership, not someone filled with the false pride that comes with carrying the group, either financially or through self-appointed positions of importance. I came to realize this was a Fellowship made up of the dregs of society who had found freedom and happiness in a Power greater than themselves through the Twelve Steps of Alcoholics Anonymous. I came to realize that serving the Fellowship and trying to carry its message was the highest goal I had ever attempted.

It took wiser people than our early members to see that A.A. must be self-supporting or the entire movement could be lost forever, with the fate of thousands destined to the slow death of alcoholism. As A.A. grew in numbers and maturity it became apparent to many that what we had was truly a gift from God. One of the surest ways to maintain the existence of our marvelous Fellowship was to ensure that it remain self-supporting, refusing outside gifts, no matter how compelling the need or loving the offer. In 1937, during discussions concerning possible financial support from the Rockefeller Foundation, Albert Scott, an early friend of Alcoholics Anonymous, asked, "Shouldn't we be most careful not to do anything which might lead to a professional or propertied class within your ranks?" (*The Language of the Heart*, p. 60)

This profound statement is one of the cornerstones that has kept our beloved Fellowship in the unique position of actually practicing corporate poverty and out of harm's way. When all was said and done, the Rockefeller Foundation had helped in a very minor financial way, but its spiritual contribution was immense.

Throughout those early years, and later after the inception of the General Service Conference, discussions of funds have continued. These talks seem to have offered us some of our greatest opportunities for spiritual growth. Sales of literature have always been key in paying for needed services. Occasionally, it appeared that group contributions would support all our services, except for the cost of publishing. There have been times when we have gone to great lengths to accomplish that goal. The concept has thus far stayed out of our reach. Maybe it should remain that way in order that literature pricing can be the throttle that keeps us on an even keel while we attempt to maintain a balanced operation of the Reserve Fund. We need to encourage all groups to continually contribute to our various service entities, not only to ensure that those services will be adequate, but also to allow each group the freedom and benefits of our Legacy of Service.

In November 1957, Bill wrote in the Grapevine, "Our spiritual way of life is safe for future generations if, as a Society, we resist

the temptation to receive money from the outside world. But this leaves us with a responsibility—one that every member ought to understand. We cannot skimp when the treasurer of our group passes the hat. Our groups, our areas, and A.A. as a whole will not function unless our services are sufficient and their bills are paid." (*The Language of the Heart*, p. 221) With this commentary Bill makes it clear that the Seventh Tradition is money in the basket, but it's also participation at the group, area, and world service levels.

Concept IX speaks of A.A.'s leaders as being examples and of the absolute necessity to choose the best we can. In order for us to accomplish this it becomes imperative that we give every person new to A.A. the same chance that was offered to us. That's what the Traditions are for. Self-support is about money, but it's also about participation and service. It's about anonymity and our common welfare. It's about leadership and our singleness of purpose. Most of all, it's about the very essence of Alcoholics Anonymous, trying to carry this message to alcoholics, and, as the result of paying our own bills, the Fellowship will be here for all the years to come when hopeless drunks walk into A.A. meetings looking for sobriety and a new way of life.

Jim Madger, California Northern Coastal Area

A.A.s BEHIND THE WALLS

Wednesday afternoon, three presentations addressed carrying the A.A. message into correctional facilities. Sarah Price, G.S.O. staff member on the Correctional Facilities assignment, was the moderator.

Cooperating With Prison Officials

The first word of the title of this presentation is the key to successful Twelfth Stepping behind the walls. Cooperating. Mr. Webster defines cooperation as the "association of persons for common benefit." What we have in common with prison officials is the alcoholic who happened to get caught in the midst of their personal adventures sitting in a cell not knowing that it was alcohol that put them there; that person sitting in a state of hopelessness and helplessness that we all know so well. Remember that total aloneness of not knowing if anyone gave a damn whether we lived or died? I remember those feelings well, and I wasn't in a lockup when I had them. I can't begin to comprehend the overwhelming futility and frustration if I were feeling that unwanted and locked up somewhere, unable to be in contact with the people with the answer—the people from A.A.

I also have something in common with that alcoholic who has found the hope of our Fellowship because someone cared enough to see that the message of Alcoholics Anonymous was carried behind the walls of the their institution. We have a common solution today because someone cared enough to share what they had been given so freely. What we *don't* have in common, is easy access. Those early A.A.s who brought hope to me could call me any time they wanted—and sometimes when I didn't want it. And I could call them if I felt like it. Obviously, those people behind the walls, no matter why they're there, don't enjoy that freedom. That is a brief reminder of what we have in common with those who haven't yet had the opportunity to find a way out of that prison of total bewilderment; that total aloneness and despair—the overwhelming fear, that we disguised so well with a bravado and a callousness that forced those who wanted to help us to turn their backs on us in despair. Our common goal is to help penetrate that callous facade by sharing that ray of hope that was shared with us somewhere along the way.

The difficulty lies in the simple fact that these people are not readily available to us. And, I'm sorry to say, in far too many places we are not available to them. Frequently, we are not available to them for no other reason than that we failed to cooperate with or associate with the prison officials. We failed to associate ourselves simply by not going in and talking with that warden, or county sheriff, or jailer, or activities director, about what we have to offer and how we can help them help the people who are in their care. Far too many of these people have no idea of what we are about or that we are even available to them as a resource.

Two short years ago, two members of our trustees' Correctional Facilities Committee attended the National Conference of Volunteers in Correctional Facilities. I was surprised to hear that they hadn't really considered A.A. as a volunteer resource! And that's at a national level! It's really ironic when we consider that 80-90% of the people in correctional facilities today are there because of alcohol-related offenses. And we say that we're doing our job? I don't think so. I want to say right here and now that there are many, many areas out there doing a bang-up job of cooperating with corrections officials and, as a result, our message is being carried into those facilities and the problem drinker at least has a chance. I feel like I'm preaching to the choir when I think of what many of you and your areas are doing. And I know that you will keep on doing what you've been doing so well. We appreciate the experience you have shared with G.S.O. and the C.F. Committee so that we can share what is working for you with others. You are the ones that made our C.F. Guidelines, the C.F. Workbook, and other C.F. literature possible. I'm talking today more toward those areas and districts who, for whatever reason, have not yet picked up these simple tools and carried our message to their particular corrections facility administrators.

Carrying the message does not imply waiting for them to come to us. Working in corrections is not limited to taking meetings inside or talking one-on-one with the inmates. We have to carry the intent of our message to the prison officials. We have to go to them, and ask what their needs are. Once we have associated ourselves with the people that can open the doors and let us inside, once they see that we are available and want to help them, we usually get their full cooperation. Then all we need to do is cooperate. But, you say, "They don't cooperate with us." They don't need to. Tolerance is our code. And you might say, "Their security policy is too rigid." They have to do what *they* think is necessary to do their jobs. Acceptance does not necessarily mean approval. Or, you say, "I don't think I can talk to a prison official about A.A. and getting us into their facility." Have you ever tried? Our C.F. Workbook is full of suggestions and examples of how to handle these situations. Many prison officials come to us asking for help in fulfilling their need. If you know of a jail or prison where A.A. meetings aren't scheduled on a regular basis, go and see if you can be part of the solution.

Another area of C.F. work involves cooperating with the parole and probation officers. This phase is frequently overlooked because now the inmate is leaving the facility and, seemingly, is no longer part of the C.F. domain. The process of developing a temporary contact or bridging the gap system for that soon-to-be-released inmate is essential to their success when they hit the bricks on the outside. Parole and probation officers need to know what they can expect from us and how we operate. How many times I've heard some A.A. member say, "Oh, those probation people don't know anything about us, they don't cooperate at all." Whose fault is that? Have we even tried to let them into our loop? Think how much easier it would be for them *and* us if we would only take the time to talk with them about our program and its message. Think about how much easier it would make the transition for that newly-free alcoholic. The best part is that you don't need to be an ex-con to cooperate with any of these professionals!

I doubt that most of the professionals working in corrections or parole or probation offices have spent any time behind bars. So why should this be a consideration as we try to carry our message to prison and corrections professionals?

I've heard many members of the Fellowship say that we don't have any Twelfth Step calls anymore. That the treatment centers have ruined good old Twelfth Step work. The treatment centers didn't do that; we let them—and then we blamed them for not doing things the way we thought they ought to be doing. Let's not be caught with our collective pants down when it comes to corrections.

I submit that the greatest resource for Twelfth Step work and carrying the message in the not-too-distant future lies in corrections. When we consider that the majority of the nations' correctional facilities are operating at 125-150% capacity, when we see new prisons and jails popping up all over the country, we can't help but wonder where things are going in the prison system. The trend toward rehab and treatment programs behind the walls tell me that prison officials are, of necessity, trying to do something for their inmates. Juvenile detention centers are in proliferation and as yet there doesn't seem to be enough experience to share how we should approach this issue. Privately operated facilities are becoming common in many areas. This, as it did with the treatment center era, will involve additional considerations and it will be interesting to see how it all develops. But our part in it, the role we play, can't develop unless we go to the prison officials and let them know that we want to cooperate with them. I think that when Clinton Duffy, in 1942, brought a bunch of drunks into San Quentin to work with those in his care, he perhaps was responding to a vision for the future. He could envision the help that would be needed, both then and now. And remember, he came to us. That tells me that prison officials want—and need—all the help they can get. Let's give it to them.

I've had the privilege of serving on the trustees' Correctional Facilities Committee for the last four years and as chairman for the last year. As I prepared this presentation, I tried to think of something profound or innovative to impress you with. I tried to recall something the committee did, or some astute observation that would solve all the problems in corrections for you. As I reflected upon the past four years I recalled that we took the shared experience of what was working out there and, with the devoted help and guidance of our staff secretary, condensed it into a very practical and to-the-point C.F. Workbook. Our C.F. Guidelines were rewritten, hopefully to clarify and simplify the original suggestions. We reviewed and discussed the many trends that are developing in the corrections field. We addressed concerns and sharing from the Fellowship relative to C.F. work. We discussed ways that the General Service Board and the C.F. Committee could help in paving the road into correctional facilities, or whether this should be left to local and area autonomy. All these things were done in the spirit of helping to make Twelfth Step work possible, and in the spirit of carrying the message to those who still suffer under the cruel lash of alcoholism and don't enjoy the freedom to seek us out.

I am firmly convinced that the trustees' and the Conference Committees on Correctional Facilities are fulfilling their roles in making Twelfth Step work possible behind the walls. Their primary purpose is to see that the effective methods of cooperation and the collective experience of those working in the field are available to us all. The actual cooperation with prison or jail officials has to begin at the local or area level. That's you and me as we envision what we can do at our own doorstep. The committees and the service structure can only provide guidance based upon past experience. The action must take place in the areas, the districts and in the groups.

If we don't pursue this opportunity to serve, if we don't cooper-

ate with prison officials, may God have mercy on the souls of those we might have reached and didn't; and may He have mercy on us for not trying to pass on what was given to us so freely.

Les Leuthaeuser, West Central regional trustee

Carrying The Message Inside

I attended my first correctional facilities meeting in September 1979 at a work farm in Sylvester, Georgia; I didn't want to be there. I've been involved in the endeavors that Les spoke of and the ones that Eva will share with you. I've helped start, maintain and close down correctional facility meetings. I still love doing what small part I can to carry the message inside, and I currently serve on the trustees' Correctional Facility Committee.

So, with all of that background, I should be able to stand here and spout off wisdom, the "how to's," and the specific direction in which we should proceed. It would be great if it was that easy, but it's not. What I have to share with you today is the experience I've gained by having had contact with some very loving and spiritual men, both inside and outside of these facilities. The main thing that has happened during this whole period is—I've stayed sober! We stay sober by doing this work!

It's my experience and opinion that Alcoholics Anonymous members must function in a variety of ways to insure that our message is carried to those who are incarcerated. Besides the most logical way—going inside—the Corrections Correspondence Service is a tremendous method. The Correspondence Service is one of the least painful methods of carrying the message to someone behind the walls that I know. If we, in fact, practice what we preach and work the program—which the Twelfth Step is a part of—then why do we continually hear staff members like Sarah asking, to the point of pleading, for people to correspond. Rarely do we have a shortage of inmates asking for A.A. members to correspond with them! We sit around these beautiful rooms here and in other cities, thinking of ways to make the process less involved, yet we struggle to find enough volunteers. I've read the letters from inmates that beg to have someone help them work the Steps or try and understand how God works in their lives. I've talked to inmates that have had the benefit of corresponding with another recovering alcoholic, sharing how helpful it has been. Allow me to share one of those experiences with you.

I attend a meeting every other Monday night at the Arizona State Prison in Florence, Arizona. Sadly, we have a meeting at the Rynning Unit every Monday night, and Lew and myself are the only outside attendees, with approximately 50 inmates at each meeting. On March 18, I attended the East Side meeting and their topic was "Spirituality, Contempt Prior to Investigation," and how do we apply that in our daily lives. It was a great meeting with a lot of sharing. Toward the end of the meeting a man named Lester (he said I could use his name) asked to share. He shared a short version of his history with alcohol and crime, noting that never did he think he was an alcoholic. During his ins and outs of prison he attended different A.A. meetings. This time though, he felt he had reached his bottom and decided to give it his all. He had heard of the Correspondence Service and decided to see if it would work. He has a recovering alcoholic in New Jersey that he corresponds with regularly. All of Lester's life he had been in the fast lane and on a fast pace. He was sharing this with his correspondent and explaining the difficulty he was having grasping the program because it didn't come fast enough. His friend wrote back and asked a simple question, "Have you ever slowed down?" This started a whole new dialog between the two and has helped Lester understand more about the program and how it works.

This never would have happened if the gentleman in New Jersey had not been willing to get out of himself and carry the message of recovery in this manner. This is a fabulous way to carry the message inside and there is no doubt but that it truly works! We constantly talk about the hand of A.A. always being there—let's show it by encouraging more recovering alcoholics to get involved in the Corrections Correspondence Service.

Carrying our message inside a major facility is simple: You suit up, show up, share your experience, strength and hope. You do it on a consistent basis! You see, those men and women you're visiting don't trust very well therefore, showing up when we say we will is essential. Be yourself! Talk about what you do on a daily basis to stay sober. Talk about how you work the Steps. Just listen! Our message is the program of recovery contained in the first 164 pages of the Big Book. The inside meeting isn't special, except in the manner we get access to it and its location. If we try and make it any more special than that we are doing every inmate that attends a disservice. One asset you have on the inside is those inmates who have gained, and continue to maintain, their sobriety in prison. You talk about leading by example; their presence is the ultimate leadership.

I feel one of the toughest areas is carrying our message to those in local jails and correctional facilities. Usually the local correctional facility houses those sentenced for less than one year. This is the true test of what all of our work is really about, staying sober! The reason I say this is, when you show up at that facility you may be the only one present for the meeting. But remember, show up! In these smaller facilities you don't have the opportunity to build relationships with the inmates, because when you come to the next meeting they may have been released, on an overnight pass, on work release, etc. These meetings take on a First Step flavor because of the turnover of inmates. Another characteristic of these meetings is that you may do the majority of talking, especially if you have come alone. You see, they aren't real chatty at first. So you hang in there, keep showing up, keep going home sober, and keep telling everyone how great it was.

Another difficult area is carrying our message to the young individuals housed in some form of state facility. These young men and women (some would call them kids or children) are usually 14 to 18 years old and have been convicted of felonies. If you want to test your ability to carry the message inside and work on your sobriety, your patience and tolerance, your live and let live abilities, your listening skills, then work with these incarcerated young people. But here again, remembering that we are there to carry the A.A. message and be the best Big Book they may see. And, we will stay sober from the experience; that is what this deal is all about.

Chuck Crist, Grapevine director

Attracting Outside A.A. Members to Correctional Work

There is a paragraph in the foreword to the third Edition of our Big Book (p. xxii) which reads: "In spite of the great increase in the size and the span of this Fellowship, at its core it remains simple and personal. Each day, somewhere in the world, recovery begins when one alcoholic talks with another alcoholic, sharing experience, strength, and hope."

I doubt that I would be here today had it not been for a sober member of Alcoholics Anonymous sharing with me the morning I reached out for help. I didn't get the message in prison. As a matter of fact, I never had to go to jail or prison in all my drinking days—except to visit my less fortunate acquaintances who got caught. In my first year of sobriety my sponsor was quick to point out, after a judge had placed me on probation for three years, that if there had been any real justice I might have been hung the night

before. She had a way of making me count my blessings. It was not until well into my fourth year of sobriety that I was able to go behind the walls as a result of getting involved in our local correctional facilities committee. In California this committee, known as H&I (Hospitals and Institutions), carries the message to those confined in hospitals and institutions.

I wasn't someone who walked into the doors of A.A. and immediately raised my hand to inquire if there was anything I could do to help. Like most of us when we get here, I was too busy keeping intensely focused on me. But, gradually, my attention began to shift outward as a whole new set of concepts were incorporated into my daily life. For me, it started when I got a sponsor who nudged me into service and guided me into this new way of life, which not only included taking the Steps, but in giving a helping hand in A.A. wherever it was needed—"inside" or "outside." My sobriety from day one has been continually blessed with your living examples of love and service.

What was the attraction in getting involved in carrying the message behind the walls? In listening to members talk about their experiences visiting inmates at the jails and prisons, the level of gratitude and love that emanated from their sharing caught my attention. Hearing sober members share on how they got a message of hope from an A.A. panel being brought in while they were incarcerated; picking up a Grapevine and reading the language of the heart shared by an inmate from a state penitentiary; going to a local convention and attending the workshops on carrying the message to those confined; seeing the pink cans fill up with loose change to buy A.A. literature for the panels to take in. All of this made me aware of how important it is to extend the hand of A.A. to those "inside," and the realization surfaced that these inmates can't go to meetings as freely and as often as we on the outside can. They can't go for coffee after a meeting to talk to another drunk, or call and visit with a sponsor at any time, or run by the local central office to pick up the A.A. literature, or participate in the A.A. activities we get to enjoy.

There was a woman in my home group who was very active in carrying the message to the women who were locked up in the local county jail, and she often shared the incredible sense of joy she experienced each time she visited these women and of the new friends she had made behind those walls. What I heard and saw in her, and all those members involved in correctional work, was a phenomenal thing going on; they may have gone into those places thinking they were going to give, but it always appeared to me that they ended up on the receiving end of something incredible. It was so magnetic. I remember early on in my sobriety going to our annual Southern California Area oldtimers event. I heard these oldtimers share about being involved in corrections work and how those commitments helped them through the peaks and valleys of their sobriety. The attraction may have been the sparkle in their eyes, the warmth and glow of their smiles, the humor and lightness in their hearts, or the sense of freedom and peace in their spirit.

I really don't think I can present any new or clever ways to attract members into correctional work; but I do believe that we attract by our example. Sharing the experience, strength and hope we gain from this kind of Twelfth Step work is the best form of attraction. But I also believe we need to inform and remind our Fellowship of the work that needs to continue and which will never be finished as long as there are alcoholics and prisons. In Dr. Bob's farewell talk, at the First International Convention in 1950 in Cleveland, he said: "None of us would be here today if somebody hadn't taken time to explain things to us, to give us a little pat on the back, to take us to a meeting or two, to do numerous little kind and thoughtful acts in our behalf. So let us never get such a degree of smug complacency that we're not willing to extend, or attempt

to extend, to our less fortunate brothers that help which has been so beneficial to us."

So how can we encourage others to get involved? Some of the ways we can inform and attract our members to correctional work include inviting oldtimers, who were once involved in carrying the message behind the walls, to local workshops; arranging to have members who got the message behind the walls to speak at our conventions and round-ups; showing the video "It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell"; and having available the A.A. literature related to our correctional work. At our speaker meetings we could include speakers that carry the message to the various local institutions. Local and area newsletters might feature articles written by inmates who got the message behind the walls or stories submitted by members who have successfully carried the message "inside." Some home groups have members who are actively involved in correctional work and who keep the group informed of the local activities and what the committee's needs are in order to continue carrying the message. Our home groups might consider having panel members from our local correctional committees share with our members what happens behind those walls.

Many of our members may not be aware that having been in jail or prison is not a requirement for going into these institutions. One of the things I heard in the very beginning was that we are not there to share about jail time—they already know about that—but we are there to carry the A.A. message. And then there are members who are hesitant to go into jails and prisons because they are afraid. It's usually the fear of the unknown that paralyzes us and keeps us from receiving some of the greatest benefits of service. Sometimes we just have to walk each other through the fear by sharing what it was like, what happened and — when we get to the part about what it's like today—that's the attraction.

I remember one evening going in to the county jail on a panel and, upon getting up to leave, I pressed the wrong button to signal to the officers that we were done. Now that was a frightening experience as the red light and alarm sounded off all around us. And there I was, trying to appear so tough and cool and I just couldn't help but get humble real quick. The next time I went in there, the women and I had a good laugh about it. Today I can laugh at myself and share the precious memories of the laughter and the tears I experienced with those women. Perhaps the most important thing we can do, when sharing at A.A. meetings, is to include some of our gratitude for what this service opportunity has given us.

There are no commitments too small to help in correctional work, whether it's donating A.A. literature to the local committee; old Grapevines or subscriptions to our meeting in print; providing cassettes of A.A. material; corresponding with an inmate; sponsoring meetings; signing up to be a "contact upon release"; or going into a detention center on a panel to share with, possibly, some of our future trusted servants. As in any A.A. committee there is always plenty to do, and in corrections it doesn't necessarily mean going into a jail or prison. Our Correctional Facilities Workbook provides us with information on how to do correctional facilities work and ways to get started, as well as working with the Traditions, tools and ideas.

The rewards of service are not always easy to explain or describe. Sometimes the only way we can get to experience them is to get involved. I am grateful that you shared your precious service commitments with me and that the spirit of rotation gave me the chance to experience some of what you openly shared. One of the hardest commitments I had to give up was the Tuesday Night Book Study at the local women's Honor Farm. The women in these named it "'Inside' the Big Book." As I got more immersed in general service it was no longer possible to continue in correctional work. As we are taught in sobriety, "You can't keep it unless you give away." I guess I need to remember that in passing along

God's work to others, the circle of love and service continues to grow. There really is nothing more moving than a good old Twelfth Step call, whether it's talking to a drunk at their bedside or behind the walls; and there's nothing like the "high" of sobriety we feel when we have carried the message to those confined. We feel it in our hearts when we see the look of hope in the faces behind those walls. In so many dimensions, this is a program of attraction. The Twelfth Step in action is a moving and powerful example of God's grace. As we discuss and reflect on the ways of preserving our Fellowship and ways to continue to provide services so that recovery is possible for anyone, "inside" or "outside," I hope we will never lose sight of one drunk talking to another.

In the 1971 February issue of the Grapevine, under the featured articles on "Carrying the Message To Those Who Can't Come to Us," a former inmate wrote: "Please let me beg you A.A.s everywhere to support our institutional A.A. Remember, these alcoholics cannot come to us, but we can go to them. My heart will always be in institutional A.A., for I know what it has done for me. What it has done for me, it can and will do for others. The alcoholic is not in prison by choice; he is there because he is alcoholic and could not handle the bottle. But he can be shown a beautiful way of life through A.A. if we will only take the time to carry to him the A.A. message of love and understanding; that no alcoholic is so free as he who is bound to A.A. The head may seek A.A., but only the heart will find it, and the will of God will never lead us where the grace of God cannot keep us."

*Eva Sanchez,
Southern California*

A.A. AND CYBERSPACE

Thursday morning's presentation moved into the future to explore the role of A.A. in Cyberspace. Jane Murphy Schulberg, trustee on the Grapevine Board, was the moderator.

What's Going on Now?

When I first saw the subject of this presentation, A.A. and Cyberspace, I thought that I would be talking about A.A. and Soberspace. This presentation is to inform you about what is presently happening with Alcoholics Anonymous and the Internet. The sources vary from individual A.A. members, central offices, districts, areas, other twelve-step organizations, international G.S.O.s, our General Service Office in New York and many more.

First, I would like to tell you how I got involved with the Internet. I worked for a telecommunications company in Canada and was responsible for Systems and Methods, coordinating the implementation of projects for various mechanized systems that were replacing manual methods of doing things. Part of the project was to transmit to the programmers the client's needs so that they could, in turn, produce a system that would be efficient and user-friendly. The biggest challenge was not to produce the system itself but to bring the individuals to accept the system and then to utilize the system as described.

I realized then that the human being is the most important factor in any changes that occurs, and the same applies in our Fellowship. In all our service experience, I am certain that many of us tried to bring changes, no matter how small, and always had to deal with those who objected because they needed more information or needed to be secure about the change.

When I was elected trustee-at-large, I was assigned to different trustees' committees and the trustees' Public Information Committee was one of them. On that committee we had various issues to discuss, among which was the use of the Internet as a

public information tool. During the board weekend of October 1995, we had an online presentation of the Internet and were able to view some of the existing information. That weekend, at the trustees' P.I. Committee, we recommended that G.S.O. create an A.A. Web Page, in three languages—English, Spanish and French—and that we use the A.A. Fact File on the A.A. Web Page. A letter addressed to all Conference members was sent out to inform the Fellowship. So far there have been thousands of accesses to our Web Page by online users. The P.I. Committee also created an A.A. Web Page subcommittee to study the inclusion of additional information in the future.

The subcommittee discussed the addition of other literature on the Web Page and decided to delay any additions. Instead, we presented a report to the trustees' Public Information Committee, suggesting that it recommend to the General Service Board the creation of an Ad Hoc Web-site Committee, which was accepted at our board weekend in January 1996. The main reason for this committee is to ensure that all trustees committees and the A.A.W.S. and Grapevine Boards also assess the need of the Internet as part of their scope and forward their input to the Ad Hoc Web-site Committee. This will be done during 1996 and, hopefully, will contribute to a coherent approach to the Internet by our Fellowship. This decision also allows you, as Conference members, to express your views which will, of course, determine our actions for the future.

As some of you already know, we have been receiving requests from A.A. members, and also some congratulations, on our A.A. Web Page. Some of the requests are as follows: Why do we not have an e-mail address for Alcoholics Anonymous? Why do we not refer to the online groups on our A.A. Web Page? Why do we not have our literature catalogue on our Web Page? Why do we not register online groups at G.S.O.?

While all this is going on within the structure of the Fellowship, some 30 million users have joined the electronic superhighway and, of course, some of them are members, or future members, of Alcoholics Anonymous. A.A. members are finding each other in chat rooms and sharing on recovery from alcoholism. Some members started A.A. groups on the Internet with the same structure as face-to-face A.A. groups. Some online groups have open A.A. meetings and some have closed meetings, with a full slate of elected officers, including G.S.R.s, secretaries, treasurers, greeters, birthday keepers and even an intergroup representative. There is an online intergroup which provides a meeting directory and other support services. The A.A. members that belong to those groups are from all over the world, just like any face-to-face groups that have members coming from different parts of the world. The online A.A. groups have but one primary purpose—to carry the message to the alcoholics who still suffer. Just like face-to-face groups, some of them are very well structured, while others are progressing. The online groups are now looking to harmoniously integrate themselves into the traditional service structure of Alcoholics Anonymous. Yes, they are looking to belong to A.A.—just as we did—as a member, a group, a district, an area. Some A.A. members have chosen the A.A. online group as a home group, for various reasons—like health, geographical location, odd working hours, etc.

Many, who are regular A.A. online group attendees, also attend and belong to face-to-face groups. The online groups suggest that A.A.s attend face-to-face groups. Online groups are self-supporting and, like one member says, the rent is cheap and the coffee is available. One of the online groups has been contributing to the International Literature Fund established by the World Service Meeting.

Electronic technology also permits anyone trying to enter an online meeting to bounce back to the listkeeper, who then verifies

the reason for the inquiry; from that point the person can either become an A.A. member (maybe they already were a member) or they may have just been looking for information. But, the important part is, the contact was made.

I read an article in the March 1996 Grapevine (p. 29) about a close involving the Twelfth Step on the Internet that had a happy ending. When a Twelfth Step call is received in a face-to-face situation, or via a house phone, a public phone, a cellular phone, a fax or a modem, we don't ask any questions. As A.A. members we simply answer the call and carry the message the best way we know how. Our co-founders never even dreamed of such a direct way to reach the still-suffering alcoholic. Imagine, with the Internet we can be available directly in the home of the suffering alcoholic.

What's going on now also includes existing areas, districts and groups that are on the Internet. What a wonderful way to make ourselves available to A.A.s who travel or to professionals who are looking for information about Alcoholics Anonymous, therefore preventing public misunderstanding, but also to be concerned with misinformation about A.A. at the public level. We all know that there is all kinds of information on the Internet that use A.A.'s name and can be misleading. It is our responsibility (A.A. members, groups, districts, areas and the Conference) to ensure that the proper information is available.

At this Conference, the Conference Committee on Report and Charter is dealing with an issue regarding online A.A. groups. Our G.S.O. staff is also dealing with some questions about A.A. and cyberspace and are doing a great job at responding to those requests. Our trustees' committees, the General Service Board, delegates and many other trusted servants have been dealing with this issue and will continue to do so during the year.

So far, the Ad Hoc Web-site Committee of the General Service Board has received input from A.A.W.S. and the Grapevine and are awaiting input from the various trustees' committees. Following are some of the items being considered by the Ad Hoc Web-site Committee and by our General Service Office:

- Policy for adding Conference-approved literature and other service material onto the A.A. Web-site.
- Develop a service piece for groups, districts and areas who are considering accessing the Internet with a home page.
- Add to the existing A.A. Web-site the pamphlet, "Is A.A. for You?" with the twelve questions.
- The linking of our existing A.A. Web-site with other international Web-sites.
- Create a generic e-mail address on our Web-site so that members and nonmembers can communicate directly with G.S.O. on the Internet.

We, as a Conference, will be dealing with the issue of the Internet and we do have a responsibility toward our Fellowship worldwide to express our Conference opinion on this matter. There is unanimous agreement, from A.A.W.S., Grapevine, G.S.O. and the Ad Hoc Web-site Committee, that we move with caution in assessing the content of the A.A. Web-site. We have decided to hold off putting any additional information on the A.A. Web-site until after this Conference, so that we may obtain guidance from the Conference members.

The Grapevine has established a generic e-mail address and is receiving articles via the Internet. They are also considering adding to our existing A.A. Web-site a pamphlet which describes the Grapevine. There is a complete, well documented article, "Online A.A. — A Report to Our Readers," in the May 1996 Grapevine. I think it will answer many questions that you may have and help you form an opinion. This will certainly contribute to an enlightened group conscience.

G.S.O. staff presently has e-mail addresses, as do many trust-

ed servants. I personally communicate with A.A. members all over the continent at the cost of \$10.00 a month. You can imagine the tremendous savings that are realized for the Fellowship. Some of us are in different time zones and you never have to worry about the time, or if the member you are communicating with is home or away. At the touch of a key, your message is gone, ready to be accessed and answered at the receiver's leisure. I realize that there are many issues to deal with regarding online A.A., but we must persevere in our constant efforts to help another still-suffering alcoholic by all means available to us.

In closing, I would like to quote Bill W., our co-founder, from Concept XI (*The A.A. Service Manual*, p. 51): "Dealing with the huge complex of public communications as it exists today is not a job wholly for amateurs. Skill in this area implies much technical experience, diplomacy, a sense of what is dangerous and what is not, the courage to take calculated risks, and a readiness to make wise but tradition-abiding compromises."

I don't mean to imply that Bill W. was talking about A.A. and cyberspace, but, after so many years, the challenge is still at our door step and is even greater.

Michel Girard, trustee-at-large/Canada

What Can We Expect?

In a Fellowship that promotes the concept of "one day at a time," the theme of prognosticating is a dangerous one! When I wanted to know what to expect in sobriety, I was introduced to and inspired by the Promises in the Big Book—and thought them to be totally futuristic and impossible dreams for me. But, because they were rooted in the experience of the past—from the realities of thousands who had walked the road before me—and not in the future, I came to believe that they were possible, and I can now state, from my own experience, that they are real.

With electronic communications and the future capabilities of new technologies, which seem to spawn a new generation every few months, it is downright foolhardy to make many predictions! So I shall not speculate on the technologies awaiting us in the near or far future.

I know my home computer system will continue to need upgrading about every 18 months, and I know I shall rationalize that I need to upgrade at every opportunity. I presently own three computers. Despite many years of earnest efforts at the Sixth and Seventh Steps, I know my alcoholic traits often do not disappear, they are merely transformed and reappear with new faces!

Let us focus instead on the whole concept of communications. For the World Wide Web, the Internet, the online meetings of alcoholics, and the literature from various sources available for reading and downloading are all simply new and additional ways of communicating.

I had a life before television; my family wouldn't even buy one for our home until I graduated from high school, fearing that I would not pay enough attention to my studies! There were fears that TV dinners would replace the family meal, and that outside interests and interpersonal communications would decrease as TV invaded the homes and attention of viewers. Thanks to sobriety, I was able to raise two children who also found time to play soccer, take music lessons, join the Scouts, and ride their bikes. And I now have two grandsons, who spend more time with educational and fun activities on the home computer than watching TV!

Over time, TV became a part of everyone's life, and has many assets and liabilities which continue to challenge us. And while there is no network A.A. television programming, we have developed guidelines based on our experiences to protect the Eleventh and Twelfth Traditions when A.A. members are part of televised

programs. TV has the capability to inform, educate, and entertain. It has powerful forces which shape its products: federal regulation, finance, and consumer response are the big ones.

All of us here have had a life before computers! Many of us were hesitant to become personally, actively involved in this new world, but all of us are affected by it in every aspect of our lives—the way we shop, bank, and conduct routine daily business. It's a power greater than we are, for sure! Some of us moved to personal computers, either required in the workplace or by choice, as we learned how they could save us time and effort. The addition of the modem and telephone links to place computers in contact with each other added another dimension. With my home computer and a modem I soon became totally convinced that both added to my life—efficiency, accuracy, flexibility, new information, memory—all traits which were fast becoming “shortcomings” in my unaided personal life! In many interest areas of my life—recovery included, but not exclusively—I have made wonderful new contacts with people I would not have met otherwise.

We can read magazine articles about fears that some people are becoming “addicted” to computers, and we can smile with the unique knowledge that surviving alcoholism can bring. Alcoholics, I was told as a newcomer, have three operating speeds: overdrive, reverse, and revving in neutral! And we will find the same challenges to create and maintain a balance in our lives with computers, as with many other of life's opportunities. Some of our skeptical and “computer-phobic” friends are predicting dire disasters as A.A. “plugs in” to the electronic era. But it's not a sudden change. Do you think they still keep all our records here in New York, for 54,000+ groups, on file cards? Have you seen the ever-expanding computer capabilities up at the General Service Office? Have you had the fun of e-mailing the G.S.O. staff?

Sure, there's a new “language” emerging from computerization—and sure, it's confusing to the newcomer. Bits and bytes, RAM and CD-ROM, Web Pages and Home Pages—and some of us have to learn about it from our kids! In my workaday world, I come into contact with international visitors, professionals coming to Washington, D.C. to learn more about alcoholism. Some bring interpreters and that makes the exchanges a little slower. But, each and every time lately—as I present ways in which we may continue to stay in communication with these health care providers and policy makers from around the world—I say one word which has come into the universal language—“Internet?” And, without exception, at least one in the group of visitors gives a nod and a smile, and we exchange our Internet addresses.

Communication is the heart of the A.A. Fellowship. In Akron, on that lonely day in 1935, Bill W. knew that to stay sober he had to communicate with another alcoholic. The early members took their message to the public as soon as they could. We also needed friends outside the Fellowship to communicate the message. Where would A.A. have been without Jack Alexander's article in *The Saturday Evening Post*?

A.A.'s new Home Page is simply an electronic pamphlet posted for all the world to see. It is a Public Information booth capable of communicating more information to more of the public than ever before possible. And we can expect that the message of hope and recovery will be thus carried to the most remote corners of the world.

But we all know that communication is not a one-way street. To have real communication there must be a speaker and a listener, who take turns and exchange thoughts. Is posting electronic pamphlets enough? What can we expect to do to respond to the online message reader? When folks read Jack Alexander's article in 1941, they wrote to the address for more information.

And, true, the A.A. Home Page has the mailing address for more information.

We consider such other actions as posting on the A.A. Home Page the phone numbers of central offices and intergroup answering services around North America. These dedicated A.A.s have established systems in place to respond to phone calls. Of course, someone has already beat us to it, and a list of intergroup and central offices around the world is already online, at another Web-site! And a complete “A.A. Conference-approved Literature” catalog, including discounts and packages, is already online, at another Web-site! But let's take the view that such lists were uploaded by “friends of A.A.,” with no motive other than to “carry the message” while awaiting an official A.A. presence online!

The potential for reaching out via computer connections is awesome. The Big Book, published in 1939, took 22 years for sales to reach one half million copies in 1961. It took 12 more years to reach one million total copies sold by 1973. In the mid-1990s, we see Big Book sales have leveled out at around one million copies each year.

It is already technically possible for World Wide Web sites, such as A.A.'s new Home Page, to elect to count the number of connections, or “hits” made by outside computers to the Page in a day or a week or a month. While still maintaining total anonymity for the caller, we could measure the number of contacts and the general geographical origin of those contacts. It is also technically possible to expand the A.A. Home Page so that people can choose to leave a personal message, which could be read by G.S.O. staff. Requests for literature could be filled at G.S.O., and requests for contact by an A.A. member could be forwarded to area delegates for referral to local groups in the caller's community. This is no different than phone calls to a central office in any region. But the numbers of potential contacts are enormous!

Could such activity be considered to be “promotion” rather than “attraction”? We can seek the collective and informed group conscience of A.A.s everywhere on that idea, as we will do here in the Public Information Committee.

The subject of existing online A.A. “meetings” has been explored a lot lately; many of us visited the Living Cyber Hospitality Suite at San Diego last summer. Whether these meetings are “groups,” how they can be listed, how they can participate in the Seventh Tradition, are questions already under discussion here tonight, and in print in our newsletters and the Grapevine, and—of course—online!

A.A. online is no replacement for community group meetings—or as they say online in computer shorthand “F2F” (Face-to-Face)—the great majority of online users are very convinced of that. They belong to hometown groups, make coffee, talk to their sponsors over ice cream after the meeting. Online is a “dessert” or a between-meetings “snack” for these members. For a few A.A. members—the home-bound, the geographically isolated—A.A.s online can be a true lifesaver and the only quickly-accessible connection to complement letters, audio tapes, or occasional personal visits from other A.A. members. And, sure, as individual A.A. members who may elect to join an online meeting, we will experience the same risk for violations of “singleness of purpose,” and “anonymity” as we find in our community A.A. group meeting places. And we can deal with that the same way we do in our home group.

In preparation for this presentation, I reconnected with several online services which include sections for alcoholics. Nearly all post very visible disclaimers that they do not represent A.A. or any other Twelfth Step organization, and many services have several sections devoted to specific addictions to things other than alcohol. I stayed with the A.A.-related sections, and I asked them the questions we are asking here this week. I received many

thoughtful replies, which I have turned over to the Public Information Committee here at the Conference.

What Can We Expect? A.A. has taught me that it's unwise to dwell in the future—that I can make plans, as long as I don't plan all the results! We have no idea what to expect in the future of online communications; it's a roller coaster ride of marketing mayhem, communications chaos, and special connections. If we expect a sober cyberspace that is calm, serene and predictable, we're a bit unrealistic. If we expect changes that might expand our growth, stretch our capabilities, and strain our resources, then we're understanding what the early members felt when that Saturday Evening Post article was published over 55 years ago! But it's here, folks! A.A. has taken the plunge and jumped off the high board into the pool of possibilities, again. We're not afraid of the future—we'll live it and learn from it, a day at a time, as we've been doing since 1935!

I can hardly wait for my first visit to Stepping Stones. I've seen so many pictures, and heard so many stories from others about the experience. But I have a feeling that it won't take much for me to imagine Bill Wilson in 1996, sitting in that little cottage, with his long legs propped up on his desk, tapping away at a keyboard—or walking in the woods with a cellular phone in his pocket!

What Can We Expect? The future, friends, is history. In the late 1700s, the founders of the United States, creating the Declaration of Independence and the U.S. Constitution, could not anticipate the technology which has developed in the 200 years since. They knew nothing about automobiles or airplanes, automation or atomic power, yet their thoughtful vision, their abiding principles, and their words have endured to remain the invincible foundation of this great nation.

The co-founders and early members of Alcoholics Anonymous, who created the Steps, Traditions, and Concepts by which we now guide our personal recoveries and our worldwide Fellowship, could not have anticipated the technology which has developed—even since Bill's death in 1971.

But the inspired ideals of our co-founders, their vision of hope and recovery for the suffering alcoholic, their trust and belief in a Power greater than themselves, their words, their experiences—have forged a foundation for us today that is solid, strong, simple and spiritual. Those of us here today, charged with safeguarding the integrity of Alcoholics Anonymous while guiding its growth, can rest assured that the informed group conscience of the 46th General Service Conference, and the Conferences to follow, will provide the balance to guide us on our journey into cyberspace.

Bill Wilson wrote the following in October 1949 which supports this view: "...I am deeply, yes, fervently convinced that Alcoholics Anonymous will weather all adversities and every test of time for so long as God shall need us. My faith in our future rests upon certain facts of our experience: ... we are sure there must be a million alcoholics who would join Alcoholics Anonymous tomorrow if only they knew what we do. We keenly realize that any fundamental disunity among us could instantly disillusion tens of thousands who would again turn their faces to the wall. Hence those disruptions common to great wealth, power, or controversy ought never be for us. Too many of the 'million who don't yet know' would surely die. Therefore our Fifth Tradition declares: 'Each A.A. group ought to be a spiritual entity having but one primary purpose—that of carrying the message to the alcoholic who still suffers.' So long as we remain grateful for what has befallen us, and for as long as this Tradition of high and single purpose is indelibly emblazoned on our hearts, our destiny will be assured. We shall be worthy of God's Providence." (*The Language of the Heart*, p. 116)

And that is what we can expect.

Sandy Clunies, District of Columbia

How Do The Traditions Apply?

When I first started writing this presentation I knew very little about cyberspace, let alone how it relates to the Traditions. But after reading some of our literature and talking to members of our Fellowship who have had experience with online meetings, I feel like I have a better grasp of the topic.

Bill said, in January 1948, "Though A.A. groups are basically the same, each group does have its own special atmosphere, its own peculiar state of development." (*The Language of the Heart*, p. 78) It seems like these online meetings are just like my home group, a bunch of drunks trying to get and stay sober, only doing it in a different manner than we are used to. As with my home group, I am sure most of these online meetings do the best they can to adhere to the Traditions. These meetings are very fortunate to have these guidelines to fall back on. In the early days of our Fellowship each group did as it pleased, and though nothing was wrong with that, it caused many problems for our early groups. There were so many rules and regulations that most members today would not be able to join. As with regular groups these online meetings will learn by experience, one day at a time.

Bill also said, "The Traditions are neither rules, regulations, nor laws. No sanctions or punishments can be involved for their infraction. Perhaps in no other area of society would these principles succeed. Yet in this Fellowship of alcoholics, the unenforceable Traditions carry a power greater than that of law. ... Perhaps the secret of their power lies in the fact that these life-giving communications spring out of living experience and are rooted in sacrificial love." (*ibid.*, pp. 248-49)

The Traditions as they might apply to online meetings:

- 1 As with our regular groups, these members have to put the welfare of our Fellowship first and their own personal recovery a close second. For many of us, who had been used to being number one, this took a little time, a loving God and a good sponsor.
- 2 A group conscience is only the discussion of an issue by the group members, then letting a loving God talk through the group. This can be accomplished, no matter where the members are, in the same room or all over the country. What is important is to give every member a chance to be part of the process and to express themselves. One online meeting maintains a separate list server for their business meetings so those that wish to participate can.
- 3 Any drunk who says he is an A.A. member is; nobody can be excluded from Alcoholics Anonymous. When any two or more members go online together—without any other affiliation—then they may call themselves an A.A. group. It is said that online meetings exclude people who cannot afford a computer. This is true, but there are regular meetings that some members can't attend for lack of a car or other reasons. Another concern is that online meetings don't "meet" in the physical sense. Our Third Tradition only states "when they gather together for sobriety." There is nothing written about being in the same room—that is how us noncomputer people think.
- 4 Each group is autonomous, unless its actions affect A.A. as a whole. Are these online meetings affecting A.A. as a whole? Or, is it just a new style of meeting that some of us don't understand, and are uncomfortable with? Granted, someone could come online, stating all kinds of wrong information about A.A., but then it would be up to the oldtimers of the meeting to talk about our Traditions.
- 5 Carrying the message to the still-suffering alcoholic is our primary purpose, and these online meetings seem to be doing that in their own unique way. This is a medium that many people understand and feel comfortable with. The early members used to chase down drunks; today they are coming to us in a way no one would have ever thought possible.

6 Have three words ever caused recovering alcoholics more problems than money, property and authority? Since these meetings don't assemble in the usual sense, property should not be a problem compared to regular groups. Money, and going over what they need for their expenses will cause any group problems. As for authority—I don't know any alcoholic that handles that well. But I guess you could have bleeding deacons online too.

7 In the spirit of Tradition Seven, how can these online groups be self-supportive? Can you pass the basket during an online meeting? One group came up with a solution; they use a post office box and the surplus, after group expenses, is sent to the General Service Office. Or, like regular groups, they may choose not to contribute at all.

8 We have professional counselors in regular meetings, so why not online? But how they could ply their trade online I am not sure. Of course, I would hope that if anyone was attempting this someone would talk to them about our nonprofessionalism.

9 All groups need to have trusted servants; why would online groups be any different? One online meeting has elected all the trusted servants that my home group has. They even have something similar to an online intergroup. One question would be how these groups would fit into the general service structure? Since they are not registered in any area, where does their G.S.R. go for an area assembly? How is their group conscience passed on the General Service Conference? There has been talk of assigning special group numbers to identify them as online meetings. Of course, this still does not answer the question of where they fit in the service structure.

10 A.A. has no opinion on outside issues. Again, like our regular groups, online groups would, hopefully, not get involved with outside issues. But, is being on the Internet an outside issue? Or is it just another way to carry the message?

11 How can personal anonymity be maintained with the general public if our names are all over the Internet? This is a question that I believe will be talked about as long as online meetings are held. Some meetings can be entered by surfing the Internet, others can not. Those that require an extra step seem to protect anonymity better than others. But, when I introduce myself at meetings I use my full name, so people will know who I am and be able better to contact me. As with all things in A.A., it is up to the individual member.

12 Anonymity is so very important for us, on- or off-line, because it keeps us humble and right sized. In one sense, there is more anonymity at an online meeting than any other kind. The only thing I see are some words on a monitor—not a person sitting across a table from me—whose age, color, sex, dress, etc. might effect how I would listen to them.

I realize that we have just started to touch the tip of the communication explosion. Look back to how much the world has changed in the 60 years since Alcoholics Anonymous has been around. And where we will be 60 years from now?

I think I've raised more questions than I have answers, but that is why we are here—to talk about them. Hopefully, we will be able to discuss this concern in a loving, understanding manner and find the best possible solution for Alcoholics Anonymous as a whole, so the next generation of drunks will have something to pass on. Speaking for myself, change is very hard to accept but, as all who wish to recover through this process, we must accept these changes as they come and do the best we can for Alcoholics Anonymous. I would like to close with one last quote by Bill: "Therefore nothing can matter more to the future welfare of A.A. than the manner in which we use this colossus of communication." (ibid., p. 320)

Bob Hickey, Virginia

Friday afternoon the final presentations of the 46th Conference again reflected the Conference theme. The moderator was the delegate from Colorado, Linda Fredericks.

Singleness of Purpose in a Multi-faceted Fellowship

The opportunity to share my experience and thoughts on this very exciting topic has helped to illustrate the importance of this principle in my life. I would like to share my first introduction to Alcoholics Anonymous. Not having an opportunity to attend a treatment center, I knew next to nothing about this program. On Sunday morning, July 15, 1978, I attended my first meeting of Alcoholics Anonymous in Spencer, Iowa. As if it were planned the topic that morning was the First Step. As one member read the First Step from the Twelve and Twelve, I found myself relating quite easily. We then broke up into small groups and went into different areas of the building. The group I was with began to share their experiences of being powerless over alcohol and how their lives had become unmanageable. Though I could understand what these people were talking about, I was somehow convinced that I was not quite as bad as these folks—yet. When it was my turn I just told them the main reason I was there was that my father-in-law needed someone to drive him to meetings. At the time he was well into his fifties and I felt very good that I was able to help him get to a meeting.

On the drive home that morning I was not sure what had happened, but I had this strange feeling that my life would never be the same again. Not that the last few years of my life had been anything to write home and tell mom about, but I still had this fear that I might lose my wonderful personality and that other people might find out that I was going to these meetings. Without realizing it at the time, it was not an accident that the thing we discussed that morning was how alcohol had rendered us powerless and how our lives had become unmanageable. With all of the obvious differences with the people in that room it was clear that the one thing we could all agree with was the principle discussed that morning.

My first few months in Alcoholics Anonymous I took a lot of pride in the fact that I was a "pure alcoholic," and the only thing really wrong with me was that I seemed to drink a little too much. My home group was a Steps and Traditions meeting and we read and discussed a Step from the Twelve and Twelve each week. After going through the Steps we would then cover three Traditions each week for four weeks and then we would repeat the Steps. Usually, for these four weeks, I would try to catch up on my manicure or my much-needed rest. At the time I just could not see how these Tradition things could help keep me sober. My only job in A.A. at this time was that of a chair-filler and alternate coffee maker. I was convinced that if our group was going to continue to grow I would need only to share my profound knowledge of the Twelve Steps with them each week. I thank God today that our group continued to grow in spite of my best effort to create a controversy that might have destroyed us.

After several years of sobriety I finally *heard* my sponsor say that if I wanted to keep this gift I would need to give it away, and I would need to find a way to pay back to this Fellowship all it had done for me. And so began for me the process of trying to understand what kept this Fellowship together, even though at the time some issues seemed so intense that we would not make it until the next week. Keep in mind that these were new issues of the day—like what we would do with the new people

that were dually addicted, and we even had a few members who thought it might be better if we did not smoke at our meetings. And, to top it all off, we had a couple of new ladies, and it was suggested that we might consider cleaning up our language. Through it all some of the oldtimers reminded us to just stick to our primary purpose and it would be OK. This experience just reinforced how important the principle stated in the Fifth Tradition is to our Fellowship.

Tradition Five states: "Each group has but one primary purpose—to carry its message to the alcoholic who still suffers." "Shoemaker, stick to thy last!"... better do one thing supremely well than many badly. This is the central theme of this Tradition. Around it our Society gathers in unity. The very life of our Fellowship requires the preservation of this principle." (*Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions*, p. 154) It remains as true today as it was in 1978; it tells us that so long as we are not diverted from our sole purpose we can obtain the goal spelled out for us in Tradition One.

It would seem by the nature of this topic that we are assuming that our Fellowship has become even more diverse today than it was when I first arrived. This may be true in that technology has allowed us to reach an even more diverse group of people. We are able to translate our literature into more languages. Because of media advances we are able to reach people who would otherwise have remained unaware of this message of hope. The computer has made it possible for us to do our work easier and faster, and yet has created its own set of problems that will need to be dealt with. As we continue to make technical advances we will see more and more people coming to A.A. with even more diverse backgrounds than we find today, and it will become more pertinent that we cling to our primary purpose.

It has not been by accident that Alcoholics Anonymous has been around for more than 60 years now. Through the years our Fellowship has seen many changes in the way we carry this message to the still-suffering alcoholic. One of the best illustrations of this is on page 151 of *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions*. "These legacies of suffering and of recovery are easily passed among alcoholics, one to the other. This is our gift from God, and its bestowal upon others like us is the one aim that today animates A.A.s all around the globe." It remains today, as it was when I found Alcoholics Anonymous, the most effective way to carry this message—one alcoholic to another. As we do so, "Let us resist the proud assumption that since God has enabled us to do well in one area we are destined to be a channel of saving grace for everybody." (*A.A. Comes of Age*, p. 232) Tradition Five has pointed out that since we have had some success with alcohol, we might be tempted to think we can help with every other problem that crops up. For us to do more than to try to stay sober and try to carry this message to the still-suffering alcoholic may mean a fate worse than any known to man. In my time in A.A. I have not seen a sight more sickening than having to watch another alcoholic destroy his or her world without any awareness of hope. It seems that there are many things that we can do to destroy what we have, but only by keeping to what we do best will we be able to help the next alcoholic who reaches out for help.

As the 46th General Service Conference comes to a close, I feel confident that each of us present has been able to do his or her part in assuring that A.A.'s future will be as good as its past. I feel so very privileged just in knowing that, in some way, I have had a very small part in helping to mold the future of Alcoholics Anonymous. In many ways our future is contingent on how well we preserve what we already have. Having had this opportunity that so few of us are privileged to experience has had a profound effect on my life, as well as how I am able to

look at this Fellowship. Never before has it been more apparent to me that God's loving and gentle hand has guided us, from the first time Bill and Bob met until today. My involvement in service has provided me with an opportunity to meet people that I otherwise would not have had a chance to meet and I thank God daily for placing each of you in my life.

Jim Redemske, Iowa

Unity and Our Future

Unity and our future will probably not be much different than unity is in the present and has been in the past. Our challenges for the future may differ, but the spiritual principles that have guided us in resolving conflict and controversy will, God willing, remain the same. Bill once said, "Clearly, our first duty to A.A.'s future is to maintain in full strength what we now have. Only the most vigilant caretaking can assure this.... We have always rallied to meet and transcend failure and crisis. Problems have been our stimulants." (*As Bill Sees It*, p. 207)

Early in my sobriety, I experienced the importance and the miracle of the first two Traditions. At my home group, a group conscience meeting turned into a heated debate between two firmly entrenched factions. Being new to A.A., I was afraid this open hostility would result in the group being disbanded. I was certain I couldn't stay sober if that happened. I went to one of the oldtimers and asked him what would become of the group. He said that occasionally a group goes through periods of controversy; that usually it's short-lived, and out of that divisiveness often comes a greater cohesiveness. I don't remember the topic of debate back then, but I'll never forget the result. At the following meeting, those who had been in opposition were shaking hands and a few even sat at the same tables together. The survival of the group had taken precedence over personalities and personal agendas. If there were any hangover resentments, they weren't evident.

By example, these members demonstrated the spiritual tenet of the group as a whole being more important than its parts. Over the years, I've seen these divisions at every level of service. Sometimes the greatest unity comes as a result of major controversy. The most profound and emotional display of unity I've ever witnessed was on the floor of this Conference last year. After two years of controversy and division, it was necessary to let the healing begin. Many individual and collective inventories were taken in order to arrive at that moment. What happened here is what happens at groups throughout the land. Just when it appears that we're on the eve of destruction, we realize we've lost sight of our primary purpose and find it necessary to, once again, ask for God's guidance in determining what's best for the group or for A.A. as a whole. We find that we either get on our knees voluntarily or we are brought to them. Ultimately, personalities do not drive the Fellowship—principles do. The road signs, the path, the journey, the destination, have been posed by a loving God; we can only help to steer a steady course. In *A.A. Comes of Age* (p. 48), Bill remarked "The conscience of Alcoholics Anonymous as moved by the guidance of God could be depended upon to insure A.A.'s future."

To speak about unity and our future necessitates speaking to present issues that tend to disunite. One of the problems, at least in my area, is the occasional lack of communication and/or misinformation that tends to fuel the rumor-mills. As alcoholics, some of us jump on the bandwagon before the band. Armed with half-truths and a quarter of the facts, information is sometimes passed along that may be incomplete or skewed. This usually results in the misinformed leading the

uninformed, a practice that can be very destructive to A.A. as a whole. In an effort to counter this problem, I've found it's important to go right to the source of clarification. At this level of service, I'm ultimately responsible for accurately informing the groups. To that end, I've learned to pick up the phone and call my trustee, one of the staff members, or George D. On matters of finance, I've called Don Meurer directly. Recently, I was struggling to get the figures to add up in the financial report from the January board report. After speaking with Don, I realized I had a page missing. This is important, because it eliminates the temptation to bluff my way through or put my own "spin" on things. I've also found it's essential to type out the delegate report and include it, verbatim, in our monthly assembly minutes. Not only does it make me responsible for the content, but it reduces the potential for misinterpretation. This practice was adopted based on the realization that what people hear and how information is perceived from a verbal report isn't always an accurate reflection of what was actually said. This reminds me of the oldtimers who said, "We A.A.s seem to have mastered the art of discretionary hearing and selective remembering."

One of my main concerns regarding unity for the future has to do with how we treat each other. The love, patience, and tolerance that was afforded me when I arrived at A.A. seems to be on the decline. As I have become a trusted servant to a larger number of A.A.s, and traveled through the various regions, I am struck by the great diversity of people we have drawn into the fold through the evolution of A.A. This is truly our success story and our message; that all who arrive at our doors are welcome, regardless of age, lifestyle, race, culture, gender or background. Yet, the very diversity that makes our Fellowship unique and binds us together as one, is perceived by some to be a threat. I'm hearing more and more about group members who reprimand those who chant after the Lord's Prayer or scold those who call out during the reading of "How It Works." I've had calls asking if a group could expel someone who is an admitted atheist, or the one who refuses to identify himself as an alcoholic. I was asked if a group could ban a guy who kept showing up drunk! (Imagine the nerve of a drunk actually showing up at an A.A. meeting!) I hear from groups who want to throw someone out because they're disruptive.

Bill once stated that "Alcoholics are... true anarchists at heart." (*The Language of the Heart*, p. 7) What do we do with the rebel, the anarchist, or the disruptive one? A suggestion might be to invite them out for coffee after the meeting, for this is often the person in greatest need of acceptance and a sense of belonging. It's far more productive to make the individual feel a part of the group rather than *apart* from the group. Sometimes it takes a while to understand the group concept. This is where love and tolerance come in. I once asked my service sponsor what to do with a member I referred to as a "whirling dervish." She said "let him whirl." He later got involved in service and became an excellent D.C.M.

Along these same lines (but with a little different twist) is the attitude of "us" and "them." In A.A. today, it seems we are dwelling more on differences, which keep us separate, rather than on similarities, which unite us. At the group level we have divided into smokers and nonsmokers. We have cliques based on length of sobriety. Some A.A.s maintain an air of superiority by pointing at the "slippers." We have "pure" alcoholics who refuse to acknowledge the alcoholic with "other" problems. In some cases we have bosses who rule, rather than trusted servants who do not govern. At the district level there is competition over who has the most money, who's more active, or who's hosting more events. In some areas, there's discussion

regarding special interest groups and whether "they" constitute a real group and if they qualify to be in the directory. We have various service entities vying for a larger piece of the pie. This "us" and "them" mindset at all levels is spiritually divisive. Unity for the future might better be served by focusing on our commonalities rather than our differences; on our primary purpose instead of personal agendas; on principles versus power and prestige; on stressing the "we" and eliminating the "us" and "they."

A friend recently said "we can't legislate unity." This is a lesson I had some difficulty with. There was a time when I wielded the Traditions like a sword. I hadn't yet learned the distinction between vigilant caretaking and "attempted enforcement" of the Traditions. But I've come to believe that it's possible to strike a delicate balance of flexibility and tolerance that can co-exist with a love of and conviction for the Traditions.

Most of our unity problems today are not unique. They are recycled problems that have come back wearing a different hat. This is evident from reading Bill's Grapevine articles in *The Language of the Heart* and in *A.A. Comes of Age*.

I was taught the Traditions and the importance of unity. By example, those who came before me showed me that unity meant survival. I believe all of us lead by example and deed. And so, as I prepare to go back to my area, I will tell them that we made some decisions this week, even if I was in the minority. The reality is that the minority opinion is part of the group conscience. It's not separate from the group conscience. A group conscience is arrived at through God-consciousness. I will tell my area that the trustees, delegates, and staff—all 135 voting members from diverse backgrounds and cultures—had sufficient information to reach an informed group conscience, based on a loving God who guided us. What we accomplish may not be as important as the love, tolerance, and respect that was demonstrated in the process of arriving at the group conscience.

For the Panel 45s, our Conference journey is at an end. As I look across this room today, I realize that we are representative of A.A. as a whole; we are a patchwork quilt consisting of many colors, fabrics, and textures. The quilt began with one patch, then two, and each successive patch brought with it a history and a story. The patch alone provides no warmth or comfort, but when sewn together offers strength and security. In times of distress and controversy, our individual patch may strain and fray, but we find, for our own survival, we must find the thread to reinforce our portion of the quilt. Today, the history and the story of the quilt itself transcends the single patch. But it has no boundaries of either width or length, and it waits for the patches yet to come. I believe the multitude of individual loving Gods that have sewn us together will serve to blanket the future generations of A.A.s worldwide.

Pam Reising, SE Michigan

Our Traditions Today - Do We Keep Them Alive?

Certainly, Bill W., early in our history as a society of recovering alcoholics, realized that an effective group of Traditions was necessary, as he put it, to bring "... order, coherence, and effective functioning out of the noisy anarchy which for a time threatened us with collapse." (*The Language of the Heart*, p. 248)

The Traditions took form in A.A.'s period of rapid growth after the publication of Jack Alexander's article on A.A. in *The Saturday Evening Post* in 1941. Bill, writing in 1960, tells us that the principle of *unity* was at the core of the Traditions: "The Twelve Traditions communicate our principles of unity as the Twelve Steps communicate our principles of recovery. The

Traditions show how an A.A. member can best relate himself to his group, the group to other groups, and A.A. as a whole to the world around us. They show what A.A. membership is; they reveal A.A.'s experience in matters of authority and money; they guard against compromising alliances, professionalism, and our very natural desires for personal public acclaim. The Twelve Traditions were slowly evolved during an era when large-scale publicity was causing new groups to spring up like popcorn on a hot griddle.... The Traditions are neither rules, regulations, nor laws. No sanctions or punishments can be invoked for their infraction. Perhaps in no other area of society would these principles succeed. Yet in this Fellowship of alcoholics, the unenforceable Traditions carry a power greater than that of law." (ibid., pp. 248-49)

Both Bill and Dr. Bob realized that the Traditions would forever be at the core of A.A. Before the 1950 Cleveland Convention, where the Traditions were unanimously approved, Dr. Bob and Bill knew that a new order was inevitable. As Bill writes, "The old order was changing. In the future we could no longer depend upon the authority and influence of our pioneering people for A.A. unity. Henceforth we would have to rely upon spiritual principles, as set forth in the Twelve Traditions." (*A.A. Comes of Age*, p. 213)

It was felt that since the Traditions were "hammered out on the anvil of experience," they would remain vital to A.A.'s existence and future growth. Bill wrote in 1960 that "We obey our Traditions willingly because of the need for A.A. survival. We obey them because we ought to and because we want to. Perhaps the secret of their power lies in the fact that these life-giving communications spring out of living experience and are rooted in sacrificial love." (*The Language of the Heart*, p. 249)

The question we ask today—are we keeping our Traditions alive?—is perhaps too big a question to answer in a general way. Each member of A.A., in his or her heart, is a living expression of our Traditions in action, and it is through individual expression that our Traditions manifest themselves in the groups and in the Fellowship's various service entities.

The First Tradition, along with the Twelfth, defines both the basic structure and the nature of our heart. We state that the overall health of the Fellowship is not just a good idea, it is vital to our personal recovery. And then we insist that all of these Traditions are to be rooted in the spiritual foundation of anonymity. By reminding us to always place principles before personalities, and stressing first our common welfare, the two Traditions have served us well, and remain vitally alive.

Traditions Two, Four, Eight and Nine reflect our early experience in the Fellowship in establishing lines of authority. Tradition Two says it all in the words, "...there is but one ultimate authority—a loving God as He may express Himself in our group conscience." Tradition Four establishes the autonomy of each group, "except in matters affecting other groups or A.A. as a whole." Tradition Eight makes the point that we are nonprofessionals, and Tradition Nine says "A.A., as such, ought never be organized." The common thread stitching these Traditions together, of course, is the primacy of a loving God expressing Himself in the group conscience.

These Traditions, showing us how to generate effective and legitimate authority, served the Fellowship well in its formative years, and they serve us exceedingly well in the 1990s. As Bill says in an article on Tradition Two in a 1948 Grapevine, "With respect to its own affairs, the collective conscience of the group will, given time, almost surely demonstrate its perfect dependability. The group conscience will, in the end, prove a far more infallible guide for group affairs than the decision of any individual member, however good or wise he may be." (ibid., p. 78)

Traditions Three, Five and Six stress singleness of purpose, and there certainly can be no question whatsoever as to the primary purpose of A.A. The Third Tradition speaks of a *definite* membership requirement, the desire to stop *drinking*. The Fifth Tradition clearly and unequivocally states that each group has but one primary purpose, and that is to carry its message to the *alcoholic* who still suffers. And Tradition Six tells us we "ought never endorse, finance, or lend the A.A. name to any related facility or outside enterprise, lest problems of money, property and prestige divert us from our primary purpose." Our primary purpose, of course, is to carry A.A.'s message to the alcoholic who still suffers.

Even though these three Traditions could not be clearer regarding the fact that Alcoholics Anonymous' purpose is to carry its message to the alcoholic, A.A.'s historic attractiveness seems to be ever growing, and many group members speak of the necessity of reiterating, from time to time, the membership requirements of the Fellowship.

Tradition Seven assures us that money will always take its proper place in the Fellowship. In *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions* (p. 165), Bill tells the story about the Fellowship's early days and the temptation to accept outside contributions. But the right decision was finally made: "...our trustees wrote a bright page of A.A. history. They declared for the principle that A.A. must always stay poor.... When these facts were printed, there was a profound reaction. To people familiar with endless drives for charitable funds, A.A. presented a strange and refreshing spectacle. Approving editorials here and abroad generated a wave of confidence in the integrity of Alcoholics Anonymous. They pointed out that the irresponsible had become responsible, and that by making financial independence part of its tradition, Alcoholics Anonymous had revived an ideal that its era had almost forgotten." And the Tradition continues, from that point in our history until the present day, in groups throughout our A.A. world.

Traditions Ten and Eleven speak directly of our relationship to those outside the Fellowship. Ten states we have no opinion on outside issues, so we should never be drawn into public controversy; and Eleven reminds us that our public relations policy is based on attraction rather than promotion, that we need always maintain personal anonymity at the level of press, radio, and films.

Certainly, as the years have rolled by, we have noted many, many anonymity breaks, yet the Fellowship remains strong and unified. Although anonymity breaks are all too often observed at the level of press, radio, TV and films, the vast majority of A.A. members have proved to be exceedingly cooperative in observing this vital Tradition.

And Traditions Ten and Eleven lead directly to Tradition Twelve and the realization that all our valued Traditions are founded on the principle and practice of anonymity.

Despite our injunction about generalizing regarding the basic question asked in this presentation—are we keeping our Traditions alive?—it does seem both just and prudent to suggest yes, our Twelve Traditions are alive and well, functioning as those who put them together hoped and dreamed. Do we find perfect adherence? No, but then this is a program of progress, not perfection. The Traditions are shining beacons, ever showing us the correct way. Without them, and the unity they engender, the darkness might overwhelm. We keep them bright and alive today, with thanks to those who presented them to us, and with a promise to pass them on to those still to come.

Fran Polek, general service trustee

Reports from the General Service Board, Trustees' Committees and G.S.O.

These annual reports are submitted to each Conference—via its committees in cases where there are counterparts to the board entities; directly, where there are no counterparts. Unless the Conference as a whole takes some action to the contrary, acceptance of the reports indicates Conference approval of the activities and recommendations included.

GENERAL SERVICE BOARD

Trustees' report: As has been the custom over the last few years, the General Service Board invited the Conference Committee chairpersons to attend their January board meeting. All chairpersons were encouraged to attend their corresponding trustees' committees and also to attend other meetings of the trustees, including the meeting of the board. This practice, we feel, helps our Conference to run in a much smoother fashion due to better communication between staff, trustees and delegates.

In July A.A. celebrated its 60th Anniversary with the International Convention in San Diego, California. The Convention had 56,000 in attendance and was a huge success by all reports from those who attended. However, we lost approximately \$500,000 on the Convention as we had projected an attendance of 60,000. The next International Convention, in the year 2000, will be held in Minneapolis, Minnesota. And, believe it or not, work has already started on 2005.

The 14th World Service Meeting will be held this year in New York City, October 27-31, and we look forward to hosting the delegates from countries around the world. The A.A. General Service Board of U.S./Canada has invited the delegates to also attend our own General Service Board meeting, the weekend following the conclusion of the World Service Meeting.

There is still much work to do in carrying our message internationally, and in the past year visits by trustees or staff have been made to Cuba, Japan, Uruguay, Venezuela, Australia, Hungary, the Czech Republic and Slovakia. Many of our books and some service material have been translated into several languages and the Big Book was published in Armenian, Tagalog and Nepali. Our literature now has the capability of reaching two billion people worldwide.

The board held a Long-Range Planning Weekend in Salt Lake City, Utah, this past September to review the board's relationship to the Fellowship as a whole and to explore how the board as a body can assist the Fellowship in carrying the message to the alcoholic who still suffers.

At the October board meeting, we approved the recommendation of the trustees' Public Information Committee that G.S.O. implement an A.A. Web Site. The A.A. Web Site became available at: <http://www.alcoholics-anonymous.org> on December 22,

1995. The current A.A. Web Site includes the Conference-approved A.A. Fact File and a list of addresses to contact general service offices worldwide. In the future, the pamphlet "Is A.A. For You?," including twelve questions about drinking, will be added to the Web Site and a memo requesting permission to link to international general service office Web Sites, when created, will be sent from G.S.O. to general service offices worldwide. In January, an Ad Hoc Web-site Committee of the General Service Board was created to determine the approach to and content of the A.A. Web Site in the future.

During 1995 the board also approved the business plan regarding publication of the Spanish Grapevine. The Spanish Grapevine will need strong financial support from A.A. members in order to survive and will also be dependent on articles from Spanish-speaking A.A. members.

We are now on the threshold of a new Conference year and our commitment to carrying A.A.'s lifesaving message remains resolute, as it must. Our predecessors have handed us this gift and, as their successors, it is our responsibility to be sure that the hand of A.A. will always be extended to any alcoholic, anywhere, reaching out for help.

W.J. (Jim) Estelle, Jr., chairperson

A.A. WORLD SERVICES, INC.

Directors' report: Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. (A.A.W.S.) is a wholly-owned subsidiary of the General Service Board. It has the delegated responsibility to maintain oversight of the General Service Office (G.S.O.) which provides group services, including printing and distribution of Conference-approved and other service literature. The board met eight times since the last Conference to hear G.S.O. management and staff reports; review group services activity and progress on compliance with Conference and board recommendations; review budgets, expenditures, and salary policy; establish prices for literature and other materials; discuss publishing operations and matters of G.S.O. administration; consider requests from A.A.s and non-A.A.s for permission to reprint A.A. copyrighted literature; and address other matters as they arise.

There are nine A.A.W.S. directors; currently four are trustees, including two regional trustees; three are nontrustee directors; one is the G.S.O. general manager; and one is the staff coordinator. Also attending board meetings, but not voting, are the services director, G.S.O. staff members, the controller, publications director, information services manager, human resources director, the board secretary, and a Grapevine staff member. Through the year, we have welcomed as guests, trustees, appointed members of trustees' committees, delegates and other A.A. members.

The committees of the A.A.W.S. Board are: Publishing, which addresses reprints, foreign literature and publications concerns; Finance and Administration, which concerns salaries and budget, audit review, and retirement; Services, which addresses the needs of all service assignments; and Nominating. Long-range planning is done within each committee and by the board as a whole. During the past year, the following significant items are noted:



Finance: Contributions finished the year 1995 approximately \$225,000 (6.14%) below budget. However, contributions for January and February 1996 were \$36,000 ahead of budget. At the July 1995 meeting, the board recommended 1995 budget revisions to the trustees' Finance Committee to include: 1) Video of Twelve and Twelve in American Sign Language, \$79,000; 2) Service video per Conference Advisory Action—\$25,000 in 1995, total cost \$65,000; 3) Previously unscheduled meeting of the General Service Board in September, \$35,000.

Through its Salary and Budget Committee, the board prepared, reviewed and recommended the 1996 G.S.O. budget to the trustees' Finance Committee. This budget presumes withdrawing the price discounts implemented in 1994, effective August 1, 1996. Year-end 1995 found a Reserve Fund equivalent to 11.1 months operating expenses, which is in line with the number projected in the revised estimates prepared for the July 1995 board weekend.

Publishing: Due to price reductions of some items during the summer of 1995 and a full year of higher discounts, A.A. sales income was down 7%. Non-A.A. sales were down 7.4%; their purchases represented 26.6% of our total sales, the same as in 1994. For the first two months of 1996, sales are on budget. A.A. sales are flat compared to 1995, while non-A.A. sales are down 13%.

Effective August 1995, the pocket-sized Twelve and Twelve was priced at \$3.50 and the pocket-sized Big Book was reduced in price from \$4.00 to \$3.50. Audio-cassette albums of the Big Book, Twelve and Twelve and A.A. Comes of Age were reduced from \$35.00 to \$18.00. Videos of "Bill's Own Story" and "Bill Discusses the Twelve Traditions" were reduced from \$35.00 to \$15.00 (the equivalent of other videos). The new C.P.C. Workbook was priced at \$1.65 and the new C.P.C. kit at \$6.75. A Spanish language "Fact File" was produced and priced at \$2.00.

Big Books were produced in Armenian, Nepali, and Tagalog (Filipino). A pocket-sized Twelve and Twelve was produced in Spanish and sold for \$3.50. The following were also produced: Twelve and Twelve in Bulgarian; Living Sober in Hungarian; "A.A. as a Resource" in Czech and Romanian; "A Newcomer Asks" in Serbian; "Is A.A. for You?" in Croatian and Slovak; "Letter to a Woman Alcoholic" in Czech; "Questions and Answers on Sponsorship" in Czech and Hungarian; and "This is A.A." in Slovak. Foreign language books and pamphlets printed by G.S.O. were reduced to the price of the English language equivalent, although manufacturing costs are higher. "A.A. Fact Sheet": The "A.A. Fact Sheet" originated by the trustees' C.P.C. Committee is being translated into Hungarian, Slovak and Russian so we can share this basic information with professionals and others interested in A.A.

A new, large (containing about 500 pieces) Correctional Facilities discount package became available for \$30.00. Recovery and institutions pamphlets, which had been reduced in price during 1994, were running well ahead of previous distribution. Sales of audio-cassettes of Big Book doubled after the price reduction effected in mid-1995. We agreed to produce: Soft-cover *As Bill Sees It*; Braille format for *Daily Reflections*; Large-print copies of *The A.A. Service Manual*, to be printed in-house, and provided upon request. The committee reviewed, but tabled, a suggestion to produce audio-cassettes of *Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers* and *"Pass It On."* We also reviewed a request to produce a Spanish language A.A. Comes of Age in hardcover and deferred a recommendation, pending more input from Spanish-speaking members, due to the considerable price difference between the proposed hardcover and the current soft-cover version. A "Special Needs" Order form is being prepared.

At the suggestion of the A.A.W.S. Publishing Committee, the

Publications Department concluded research on the history of the development of new formats over a 30-year period. It was discovered that, in some instances, the suggestions for new formats for existing literature had come out of the trustees' or Conference Literature Committees and, in others, A.A.W.S. exercised its "right of decision" (Concepts III and X) and produced a new format. There were occasions when A.A.W.S. felt it advisable to first seek a broader spectrum of opinion and sought input from the trustees' and Conference Literature Committees before proceeding.

The board approved the production of a video of the Twelve and Twelve in American Sign Language. (A.S.L.) at a cost of \$79,000 and forwarded a recommendation to the trustees' Finance and Budgetary Committee for approval. The taping is nearing completion and the item should be available for sale later this year.

We granted permission/did not object to 130 requests to reprint from A.A. literature; 13 requests were denied. For the first three months of 1996, 16 requests were granted and three were denied.

In March we learned that a commercial publisher planned to publish, this summer, a "gender-equal translation" and "modernization" of the first 164 pages of *Alcoholics Anonymous*, to be titled, *A Simple Program*. Our attorneys advised that, since we no longer hold the copyright on this material in the U.S., we cannot prevent this publication in the United States. The general manager has met with and informed a representative of the publisher that A.A.W.S. holds the copyright on this material in Canada and most of the rest of the world and that the marketing and sale of the book in countries in which our copyright is in force would be a violation of our rights. Also, the phrase "Big Book" (which is mentioned by the publisher) is a registered mark and we requested that they not use these words in their formatting and marketing of the publication. They were also requested to utilize a disclaimer, which we prepared with our legal advisors, to the effect that the book is not published by A.A.W.S. and that A.A.W.S. has not reviewed, approved or endorsed the publication. The publisher's attitude seems to be cooperative at this time. A.A.W.S.'s objective is to avoid controversy with this outside entity while, at the same time, protecting our rights as publisher.

The board reviewed a number of five-year projections of income and expense based on a variety of assumptions for sales, contributions, expenses and pricing structures. We reported to the trustees' Finance and Budgetary Committee that the current price and discount structure for our literature is projected to steadily reduce the amount of the Reserve Fund. They reported that it was expected that the Reserve Fund would be at 11.2 months at year-end 1995 and would further decline in 1996; however, if the General Service Board felt that the Reserve Fund should be reduced at a faster rate, the consensus of the A.A.W.S. Board was that a 7% sales discount, in lieu of 5%, would be financially feasible. The board felt that, based on the projections at the time, it appeared the sales discount would have to be modified or withdrawn no later than 1997 as G.S.O. could not indefinitely incur operating losses that require draw-downs of Reserve Fund principal.

Services: The Services Committee continued deliberations on ways to increase contributions to G.S.O. The consensus was that a service piece, possibly entitled, "What a Treasurer Needs to Know," should be developed. It was felt that the material for this purpose already exists in various places, but needs to be pulled together. The Information Services Department started producing a monthly report on registration activity. We are now able to monitor, on a monthly basis, the year to year increase or decrease in group, G.S.R., D.C.M., etc. registration activity.

After discussion (and consultation with the trustees' P.I. Committee), a Home Page for G.S.O. was placed on the Worldwide Web on December 22, 1995, using the "A.A. Fact File" and information on G.S.O.s outside U.S./Canada. After hearing a report from the Services Committee, the board authorized G.S.O. to explore "hyper-links" with other G.S.O.s, where possible. E-mail addresses have been implemented for all staff and executives at G.S.O. G.S.O. maintains a list, which is available to members, of "online" meetings, but deferred a decision as to listing the groups in the Directories until after the 1996 Conference.

International: Preliminary work is on schedule for the 14th World Service Meeting, to take place in New York City, October 27-31, 1996. As invited observers, George Dorsey and Danny Mooney attended the IX Ibero-American Zonal Meeting in Punta del Este, Uruguay. The situation regarding Seccion Mexico was resolved by the Mexican courts. Seccion Mexico has been prohibited from engaging in further publication of literature for which Central Mexicana holds the exclusive license.

During May 1995, John Grant and Vinnie McCarthy visited members and groups in the Czech Republic, Slovakia and Hungary, to discuss publication of A.A. literature and to share our service experience, as well as meeting professionals. Vinnie McCarthy also travelled to the newly-opened G.S.O. in Poland in March 1996, to discuss publishing matters and to share experience in carrying the message. Vinnie then joined Joanie Moncrief to visit with professionals and new groups in Slovakia, followed by a visit to the Budapest Central Office. Joanie Moncrief also attended the Eighth European Service Meeting, in Frankfurt, last year, with 39 delegates, representing 19 countries, in attendance.

Portugal's General Service Assembly (similar to our Conference) has established a General Service Board, as well as a General Service Office located in Lisbon. Portugal's board has six trustees, three regionals, and three in or near Lisbon. George Dorsey was a guest at and participated in the 50th Anniversary Celebration of A.A. in New Zealand in Christchurch, in February 1996, attended by 700 very enthusiastic participants and, the following week, was the guest of the Australian General Service Board at their quarterly board meeting.

The 60th Anniversary International Convention in San Diego drew 56,000 paid participants vs. budgeted break-even attendance of 60,000. The estimate made early in 1994, in order to set the registration fee, seemed reasonable (if not conservative) considering Southern California's large A.A. population and San Diego's proximity to Mexico. However, we did not get the volume of "on-site" registrants that we expected. The on-site Convention loss amounted to approximately \$548,000 due to factors such as having 4,000 fewer registrants than anticipated (representing a loss of \$280,000 in registration income); the collapse of the Mexican peso relative to the U.S. dollar (resulting in a loss of \$62,000 in registration income from the 1,775 Mexican A.A.s who registered, as well as several thousand fewer Mexican attendees than expected); and a \$130,000 loss in connection with the college dormitories which had been contracted for but were not used by attendees. Expenses were 3.4% over budget. In addition to the \$548,000 we "wrote down" \$83,000 for the unsold inventory of the Convention Souvenir Book. This book, produced in-house, was very well received by purchasers and continues to be available for sale.

Other Board Actions: As of May 1995, Julian Rhinehart replaced rotating trustee director, Gerry Flegel. In accordance with G.S.O.'s biennial staff rotation, John Grant replaced rotating director, Pat Rosenstiel, in September 1995.

G.S.O./Staff Operations: G.S.O.'s employee count was 86 at year-end 1995, compared to 89 in 1994. At year-end 1995,

G.S.O. was utilizing the services of nine temporary and student workers, the same number as in 1994.

Retirement Plan Modification and Option for Early Retirement: We recommended a modification of the retirement plan to the trustees' Finance Committee to permit early retirement at age 55, with 10 years service, or age 60, with eight years service, and to lower the early retirement penalty from 6% to 4% per year; we also approved, for recommendation to the trustees' Finance Committee, a single, voluntary, nonrenewable early retirement offer for 22 employees who meet a rule of 64, i.e., age and service equal 64. The option became available for the six months period, March 31 through September 30, 1996, and provides: (a) Five years added to age for purposes of calculating the early retirement pension reduction; (b) Payment of 100% of the employee's age 62 Social Security benefit until the employee reaches age 62 (and will be eligible for Social Security benefits); (c) Severance pay of one week for each year of service for employees with less than 15 years service and one and one-half weeks for employees with 15 or more years service.

A.A.W.S. directors and G.S.O. staff members coordinated and attended the following Regional Forums since the last Conference: Northeast (West Springfield, Mass.); West Central (Sioux City, Iowa); East Central (Milwaukee, Wisc.); Southwest (San Antonio, Tex.); and Western Canada (Calgary, Alberta). A Special Forum for the Saguenay-Lac St. Jean District took place in Alma, Quebec.

The 10th Annual Intergroup/Central Office/A.A.W.S. Seminar was held in Atlanta, Georgia, with representation from 130 central/intergroup offices.

Staff member Sarah Price and West Central regional trustee Les Leuthaeuser attended the Fifth Annual National/International Native American Indian A.A. Convention in Rapid City, South Dakota. There were close to 400 attendees from all over the U.S. and Canada.

By the end of December, G.S.O. had counted 1,538 visitors for the year 1995, which exceeds the all-time record (at least since we started keeping records). For the first three months of 1996, there have been 276 visitors. These members come from everywhere in the world and their warmth, dedication and enthusiasm are an inspiration to all at the office.

The 1995 Holiday Edition of Box 4-5-9 featured an article on the centennial of Bill W.'s birth.

Gay Garner, chairperson

ARCHIVES

Trustees' committee: We met four times since last year's Conference. An expression of deep appreciation was made to out-going chairperson, John King, for his extraordinary eight-year commitment to the work of this committee.

Our Timeline Exhibit and brochure were well received at the International Convention in San Diego. A.A. members reported that they found the Timeline quite interesting and useful in presenting, in a colorful manner, the historical development of our Fellowship.

The real show-stoppers of archival participation at the International, however, seems to have been our twin Archival Workshops entitled "Archives: A Collective Vision I & II." In each, four area archivists, selected by our regional trustees, shared an overview of activities in the eight regions of the U.S. and Canada. Well over half of our 92 areas have a designated archivist and many have completed area histories. Most recently, histories have been received from Idaho, Utah and Georgia.

A subcommittee on Classification of Archival Material was

formed to study our present procedures and to make recommendations for possible simplification. Another exploration is being made on the suitability of reissuing "Markings On The Journey," our 38-minute video/filmstrip on the history of our Fellowship. It is felt that improvements on the sound and some of the visual components can be made economically.

We continue processing many of our ancient documents into a scanner. This new system will make retrieval more efficient and will go far in protecting our collection from damage. Progress has been necessarily slow in the beginning since the correspondence is fragile; nevertheless, to date over 10,000 items have been scanned.

William Bungay, chairperson

Archivist's report: Since our report to the 45th General Service Conference much activity has occurred within our A.A. archival community: This past summer a small band of historians ventured for a second time to video the first home of Works Publishing, 17 William St., Newark, N.J., and to trace Bill's commute to it from his home at 182 Clinton Street in Brooklyn Heights. The restored Downtown Newark Post Office, now a Historical Registry site, was one of the highlights of the tour. It was to a box in this building, where the pitifully few replies were received in response to a mailing offering the newly published Big Book to physicians.

Interest in our Prepublication Manuscript of the Big Book continues to be high. After an article on the availability of this historical document appeared in the Grapevine, we've been inundated with nearly 500 requests. In a related endeavor, two of our members, working independently, have produced computer discs of the textual alterations between this manuscript and the First Edition.

In response to a mailing to all area delegates, we've been able to partially update our listing of area archivists. Sadly, our previous listing had been lost in our computer department redesign. We'd appreciate any additions or corrections to this list.

Finally, maybe you, the reader of this report, can help us locate the source of this alleged quote by Bill W.: "A.A. is not a success story; rather it is a chronicle of our colossal human failure turned to usefulness by the divine alchemy of a loving God."

Frank Mauser

CONFERENCE

Trustees' committee: The committee met three times since the 1995 Conference. We reviewed the 1995 Advisory Actions pertaining to the General Service Conference, and approved the theme for the 46th General Service Conference, "Preserving Our Fellowship — Our Challenge." We discussed the summary of Evaluation Questionnaires of the 1995 Conference and the summary of the G.S.O. post-Conference sharing session, and asked the Conference Agenda Planning Subcommittee, appointed by the chairperson, to consider these suggestions in preparation of the 1996 agenda.

We approved a list of presentation/discussion topics for the 1996 Conference and authorized the staff to develop presentations from the suggested topics. We also accepted the proposed agenda for the 1996 Conference; reviewed and placed unsigned committee agenda items; and accepted a report on order of business and Floor Actions, that will be in place for this year's Conference, and passed the matter on to the Policy/Admissions Committee for discussion in connection with future Conferences.

Michael McPherson, chairperson

Staff report: The Conference coordinator is the contact for Conference members. The General Service Conference is a year-long process and the Conference coordinator corresponds regularly with delegates and alternate delegates in a cooperative effort to make the annual meeting of the Conference responsive to the needs of the Fellowship. The Coordinator's desk also is the contact for area and district committee members and past delegates of the 92 areas throughout the U.S. and Canada.

All A.A. members are asked, through the area committees, to submit items for the Conference to address. These may be brought to the appropriate trustees' committee for consideration and referral to a Conference committee. The Conference coordinator assumes responsibility for:

- Assembling suggestions for the Conference theme, presentation/discussion and workshop topics, which are then reviewed for selection by the Conference Agenda Committee and recommended to the trustees' Committee on the Conference for approval.
- Serving as secretary for both the Conference Agenda Committee and the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference.
- Working with the general manager and G.S.O. staff in planning and coordinating each phase of the Conference.
- Scheduling and assembling reports and all material for the Conference Manual, Early Bird edition of *Box 4-5-9* and the Conference Final Report.
- Reviewing all area and district newsletters, as well as minutes and reports received from area and district committee meetings and assemblies.

Richard Bush

COOPERATION WITH THE PROFESSIONAL COMMUNITY

Trustees' committee: The work of the Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community embodies A.A.'s primary purpose, and is guided by actions of the General Service Conference and the General Service Board. The committee focus is to assist local C.P.C. Committees in providing A.A. information to professionals who come into contact with the still-suffering alcoholic through their work.

Following the 1995 Conference, the chairperson established a subcommittee to review C.P.C. literature and service material; this being in accord with the 1995 Conference C.P.C. Committee's request that the trustees' C.P.C. Committee begin a thorough review of C.P.C. literature and service material, and send a progress report to the 1996 Conference Committee on C.P.C. The literature and service material review has been completed, and the requested Interim Report has been forwarded to the 1996 Conference C.P.C. Committee.

The committee also discussed and approved the updated lists of the C.P.C. exhibit at national professional meetings in 1995/1996.

The committee recommended that a sharing session be scheduled each board weekend for the appointed committee members of the trustees' C.P.C., P.I., T.F. and C.F. Committees, with all others welcome, to provide an opportunity to discuss overlapping service matters.

Fran Polek, chairperson

Staff report: The purpose of Cooperating With the Professional Community is to provide information about A.A. to those who may be in contact with the still-suffering alcoholic through their

professional work; these people include health care professionals, educators, members of the clergy, lawyers, social workers, union and industrial leaders, and those working in the field of alcoholism. Information is provided to them about what A.A. is, what we can do, and what we cannot do, and where to find us. The staff member on this assignment serves as a link to C.P.C. committees in the U.S. and Canada. Currently, we communicate with more than 550 area, district and intergroup/central office C.P.C. committees, through the chairpersons. When we learn of a new C.P.C. committee, the chairperson is sent a letter of welcome and background information. The C.P.C. Workbook/Kit is sent to incoming area C.P.C. chairpersons, and is available to all others through the literature catalog. The staff member on the C.P.C. desk also serves as secretary to the trustees' and Conference C.P.C. Committees.

Over the past year we have responded to hundreds of inquiries from physicians, nurses, attorneys, teachers, the clergy, social workers, alcoholism counselors, professionals working with mentally or physically challenged people, employers, therapists, organizations involved in the treatment or prevention of alcohol abuse, court officials and others. Each received a personal response, and most were put in touch with a local committee chairperson.

Periodically, C.P.C. news is carried in *Box 4-5-9*. The newsletter *About A.A.* is mailed twice a year to professionals who ask to be on this mailing list. The Fall/Winter 1995-1996 feature was "Nonalcoholic Trustees Open A.A.'s Windows to the World." The C.P.C. staff person also coordinates the traveling C.P.C. exhibit for national gatherings of professional associations, which are staffed by local committees. An increasing number of C.P.C. committees are purchasing the exhibit for use at these national professional meetings, as well as local or statewide events sponsored by professional organizations.

How we are doing in cooperating with the professional community is measured in the same way as any other A.A. service: Are we making the A.A. message available and clear? In C.P.C., when the answer is "yes," we experience the gratitude of reaching out, through the professional, to newcomers we may never meet.

Eileen Gatz

CORRECTIONAL FACILITIES

Trustees' committee: The purpose of the trustees' Committee on Correctional Facilities is to recommend more effective ways to carry the A.A. message to alcoholics in correctional facilities.

The committee discussed the 1995 Conference Committee's suggestion that they study ways to get more A.A. members involved in the Correctional Correspondence Service (CCS). Following are their ideas, some of which have been implemented: Submit an article to *Box 4-5-9*; provide more information at Regional Forums; suggest that sponsors encourage male sponsees to participate (there is not a need for female correspondents); write to area delegates and correctional committee chairs of the need (in the letter to the area delegates, we asked that the information be shared with the physically-challenged male A.A. members through their special needs or accessibility committees); that male A.A. members who write G.S.O. volunteering to serve as Loner Sponsors be invited to participate in the Corrections Correspondence Service; encourage former inmates to participate; or current inmates if the prison allows it; make presentation at the General Service Conference; possibly include a notice on the World Wide Web; suggest that Outside Correspondents get P.O. Boxes; let them know that they will receive the names of inmates living in states or provinces other than their own.

At the next printing of the Correctional Facilities Guidelines, the committee asked that the guidelines for the Correspondence Service, presently found on pages 40-41 of the Correctional Facilities Workbook, be included.

A member of the trustees' Correctional Facilities Committee and a G.S.O. staff member participated in a workshop held at the Auburn Correctional Center in Auburn, New York, September 1995. It was sponsored by the Area Correctional Facilities and C.P.C. Committees of Central New York. Over 40 state correctional personnel and more than 100 A.A. service people attended.

The committee discussed and forwarded two items to the Conference Committee on Correctional Facilities for consideration: 1) Discuss additional ways to encourage more A.A. participation in carrying the message into correctional facilities; 2) Consider a suggestion to publish a one-page newsletter with inmate sharing for those inside.

Les Leuthaeuser, chairperson

Staff report: The Correctional Facilities assignment is responsible for carrying the message of Alcoholics Anonymous to those alcoholics confined in correctional institutions. Over 400 letters a month arrive from inmates, most asking for free literature, some asking for names of outside A.A. members with whom to correspond, or for help in making contact with A.A. upon release. We try to facilitate these requests, primarily through our network of area, district and local Correctional Facilities committees.

The Corrections Correspondence Service (CCS), coordinated by this desk, is one of our most valuable efforts. Many inmates hunger for outside support from experienced A.A.s with whom they can share their experience, strength and hope. To quote from two recent letters:

"I have a major problem...trust. I don't trust another inmate enough to open up or work the Steps. I believe having an A.A. member, whom I'll probably never meet, help me through the Steps would work out better than if I just went to meetings and kept my feelings all bottled up."

"I am slowly getting involved [in A.A.] here, but find it hard to talk in front of groups, especially a bunch of convicts. The last meeting I read 'How it Works' at the beginning. That was a big step for me. If anyone would have time to correspond with and share the A.A. message, I would like that a lot."

We rarely have women inmates request this service; primarily men. From experience, we know that the correspondence service works better when we put women in touch with women and men in touch with men. We have a continuing need for "outside" men to volunteer to carry the message through correspondence. The rewards can be great as demonstrated by John T., an outside correspondent from Bakersfield, California:

"I know how important our Twelve Step work is and I enjoy writing to men who are locked up. It is one of the tools that I use to keep me sober. I myself found A.A. in prison almost 20

Strange As It May Seem...

Linda Fredericks (Colorado) and Marti Hooper (Idaho) were delegate "buddies," (pulled from the hat). When they met they discovered they have the same sobriety date and same profession. Furthermore, Linda (Panel 45) will soon be moving to Idaho, and Marti will be her delegate.

years ago, and it hasn't been necessary for me to return to prison since I was released in 1979."

To reach more men on the "outside," an attractive service piece about our CCS has been prepared for inclusion in new group packages and for group literature stands.

Sarah Price

FINANCE AND BUDGETARY

Trustees' committee: This year I am able to report that we are well on track with the plan which began in 1994 to reduce the Reserve Fund. Last year I mentioned that we had reduced prices on certain recovery pieces and increased discounts on literature sales across the board. I also reported that the slight increase in contributions reversed a three year downtrend. This year I am disappointed to report that contributions received during 1995 were \$3,664,861, approximately \$190,000 (5%) less than 1994. Of the 55,930 listed groups at the end of 1995, we received contributions from approximately 24,800, or 44%. Literature sales amounted to \$9,444,500 before discounts. This was approximately \$190,000 less than 1994 and almost \$109,000 more than budgeted.

Operating expenses were approximately \$83,000 below the original budget and \$222,000 below the adjusted budget. Two large projects (the Twelve and Twelve ASL and the service video), approved last year and provided for at mid-year, were slow in starting and most of that expense is budgeted for 1996.

Net loss from operations was \$1,158,000, compared with a budgeted net loss which was revised at mid-year to \$869,600, to include new projects. This difference is composed of gross profit from literature sales being \$287,000 below budget, contributions \$225,000 below, and operating expenses \$222,000 less than the revised mid-year budget, and approximately \$8,000 of additional interest. Gross profit from literature was below budget because of higher paper prices and because we now sell some items, like the large-print Big Book, at less than cost. The cost of providing services to the Fellowship, excluding publishing activities, was \$5,679,500 in 1995, \$314,000 (5.8%) higher than in 1994. (Combined operating expenses were only up 3.7%.) This amount exceeded contributions by approximately \$2,000,000, \$854,000 of which was made up from literature profits and \$1,150,000 by drawing down the Reserve Fund. The \$5,679,500 incurred for services represents approximately \$102 for each listed group compared with \$98 in 1994. In contrast, contributions per listed group averaged \$66 as compared with \$71 in 1994. The 1995 service dollar was spent on the following activities: Group Services 46.0%; Public Information, 3.5%; C.P.C., 4.6%; Treatment Facilities, 1.3%; Correctional Facilities, 3.5%; Loners, Internationalists and Overseas Services, 9.6%; the General Service Conference, 11.0%; Regional Forums 4.5%; Archives, 6.0%; trustees' and directors expenses, 7.1%; and Convention staff expense, 2.8%.

The G.S.O. budget for 1996 assumes that gross sales will be down only 0.6%. In October 1994, an overall discount of 5% on literature orders was put in place and the 20% discount on pamphlets and miscellaneous items was increased to 30%. The 5% discount will be taken back on August 1, 1996, and the discount on pamphlets and miscellaneous items will return to 20%. Gross margin is projected to increase approximately 5%. Contributions for the year are budgeted to increase 2% to \$3,737,000. Operating expenses have been budgeted \$324,000 (4%) higher than 1995 actual expenses; \$194,400 of the increase is directly related to nonrecurring expenses not present

Estimates of Groups and Members as of January 1, 1996

	Groups	Members
United States	50,671	1,153,795
Canada	5,259	97,397
Correctional facilities ¹	2,154	56,133
Internationalists ¹		145
Lone members ¹		333
Total	58,084 ²	1,307,803 ²
Outside U.S. & Canada ³	37,082	614,466
Grand Total	95,166	1,922,269

1. U.S. and Canada only.

2. U.S./Canada data includes only groups which ask to be registered at G.S.O., and which provide us with membership information. Although G.S.O. encourages groups to register, the process is optional. As of '94, the total number of A.A. groups reported was no longer inclusive of entities described as A.A. meetings, which chose not to be considered as A.A. groups. Such meetings had been included in the total for prior years.

3. There is A.A. activity in approximately 146 countries, including more than 40 which have autonomous general service offices. There was nearly a 100% response to our '96 request for information from the 40 G.S.O.s (in one instance, where we lacked '96 data, we used '95 information). We are not advised of the data collection methods employed by overseas G.S.O.s.

in 1995: G.S.O.'s direct net costs of the World Service Meeting, expenses for the Twelve and Twelve ASL project, the new service video, and new equipment to upgrade our data storage for all of G.S.O. Normal operating expenses are budgeted to increase 1.6% over 1995.

Because the change in discounts does not become effective until August 1, and because of the nonrecurring cost increases of \$194,400, G.S.O.'s operating loss is expected to increase to \$1,250,000. If the 1996 changes in discounts were to be in effect for the whole year instead of just five months, and if we were to take the nonrecurring \$194,000 out of operating costs, G.S.O. would be losing \$670,000 at 1996's budgeted level of sales, contributions, and expenses. In light of our still healthy Reserve Fund, the board elected to defer such possible budget balancing actions as raising prices (beyond the effective price increases caused by changing discounts) or cutting costs by reducing services. If sales or contributions do not increase significantly in 1996, price increases in literature, decreased discounts, or reduced services might be required in 1997, since our Reserve Fund would be at a level that would no longer permit losses much larger than Reserve Fund investment income.

The Reserve Fund was \$8,528,000 at the end of 1995, equal to 11.1 months of combined G.S.O. and Grapevine operating expenses. During 1995, A.A.W.S. contributed \$600,000 from 1994 net income. During 1995 the Reserve Fund transferred the following amounts to fund operations: \$1,146,973 to G.S.O. for operating losses; \$632,027 for the International Convention; \$100,500 for the Grapevine; and \$29,500 for the Spanish Grapevine. The Reserve Fund earned \$555,000. Based on G.S.O. and Grapevine budgets, the Reserve Fund would equal about 9.5 months of operating expense at the end of 1996.

The International Convention lost a total of \$632,027,

\$548,642 on-site and \$83,385 on unsold Convention books. The loss was largely due to lower than budgeted attendance. Operating expenses were only 3.4% above plan. In addition to the on site loss and write down of books, \$180,267 of G.S.O.'s operating expenses were allocated to the Convention. These office expenses have historically been regarded as a service that G.S.O. provides for the Fellowship and are covered by literature income and group contributions. We have never priced registrations to recover this expense.

In 1995, the Grapevine realized slightly lower revenue than expected on the magazine, however, this was more than offset by other publishing revenue. Circulation at the end of 1995 was 130,500 copies compared with 126,000 budgeted and 120,300 at the end of 1994. Total costs and expenses were \$1,243,300, less than both 1994 and the 1995 budget, primarily due to lower payroll costs. The Grapevine lost only \$3,295, considerably better than its budgeted loss of \$110,000, before the Spanish Grapevine.

The 1996 Grapevine budget assumes average circulation of 130,000 copies, and an increase of 25% in subscription price effective April 1, 1996. The 1996 budget calls for a loss of \$93,000 despite the price increase. Since the price increase only takes effect as subscriptions are renewed, the loss will diminish over time. The Grapevine should be profitable in 1997. The Spanish Grapevine incurred start-up costs of \$29,500 in 1995 and has budgeted a loss of \$96,000 in 1996, in line with the business plan approved by the trustees' Finance Committee. Approval by the trustees' Finance Committee was requested before the Spanish Grapevine could proceed according to the Conference Advisory Action that recommended the Spanish Grapevine.

Gary Glynn, chairperson

GENERAL SHARING SESSION

Trustees' report: The three General Sharing Sessions since the last Conference discussed issues of specific interest to the board and the Fellowship. The January topic was "Carrying the Message—Our International Commitment." The first presenter briefly outlined the scope of the Overseas assignment. Translations of A.A. literature arrive at G.S.O. in a variety of ways and sometimes are initiated by the General Service Board. The Big Book has been translated into 30 languages and numerous other books, booklets and pamphlets are available in translation. The World Service Meeting, held every two years, alternately in New York and a foreign country, is comprised of delegates from around the world and is coordinated from the Overseas desk at G.S.O. The next presenter observed that Bill W.'s thinking on the subject of translation continues to guide the Fellowship today. As A.A. general service offices in foreign lands developed, and a service structure was put in place, the overseas offices were able to handle their own translation needs, but the U.S. and Canada continued to provide (as they do today) some financial assistance in helping them print the initial copies of their books. Today, A.A. literature can reach more than one and a half billion people.

The third presenter pointed out that the trustees' International Committee was formed to explore ways in which the General Service Board and/or G.S.O. might assist in the growth of A.A. worldwide. At the 1990 World Service Meeting in Munich, Germany, an International Literature Fund was established which demonstrates the recognition of A.A. members everywhere that the responsibility to meet the need for A.A. literature is one that all A.A.s share throughout the world. With worldwide membership in excess of two million, we sometimes imagine

we are a huge Fellowship; yet if, as is estimated, two percent of the world population suffers from alcoholism, there are some 160 million alcoholics who stand in need of the A.A. program. We have our work cut out for us.

In July the topic was "The Minority Voice and Its Importance in the A.A. Group Process." The chairman shared that his thoughts were drawn to this topic because of its importance as an element in our development of a group conscience. The two presenters stimulated much thought and then invited everyone assembled to express their thoughts and experiences on the subject. Some of that sharing follows: Very often the Higher Power is found in the still, small voice. Taking the concept of the minority voice and making it into a parliamentary procedure can put it in jeopardy and it can become a tool of manipulation or become institutionalized. If something is nonsense it could be ignored. Our A.A. patience seems mercifully unlimited when it comes to listening to and loving the minority voice. At the Conference level we are asked to bring not our wisdom, but our conscience. Our responsibility is to deliver what we have to share...not to convince. We need to resist the temptation to boil everything down to how many voted yes and how many voted no...winning and losing are not part of the vocabulary of group conscience. It is possible, and has often been the practice, to reach a decision through striving for nothing short of unanimity. This was the practice in years past and is still found to be the rule of thumb in some instances now.

The topic in October was "A.A. in the Computer World." After the presenters finished their informative talks, the chairman invited those in attendance to share their thoughts and experiences on the topic. Some of the sharing follows: Our role is to be accessible, but we need to discuss each possibility available as a separate entity, otherwise it becomes confusing. It sounds wonderful for some who are isolated, etc.; yet it can be fraught with anonymity problems and confidentiality breaches, including our private business. We need to really look at this carefully before leapfrogging into this venue.

Some of the material on the computer—such as bad language, personal attacks, etc.—may not be an incentive for new members. Where should we list on-line groups? Should they be the same as regular groups or listed in a separate section? It is up to the General Service Conference, which is responsible for the content of directories, to decide how on-line groups are to be listed. What are closed meetings vs. "chat rooms"? (A closed meeting has a closed list available to members of the meeting. Nonmembers cannot access.) How do on-line meetings "feel"? (Initially they seem different, but they grow on you as you meet the members through their sharing.) What about anonymity? (Most A.A.s who are on-line are very serious about adhering to our Traditions; of course, just as people break anonymity in the "live" world, some will surely do same on line. This is a great opportunity to have material available to millions of people worldwide.

Peter Brock, chairperson

GROUP SERVICES

Staff report: The Group Services coordinator is responsible for service material distributed throughout the Fellowship. Developed because of an indicated need, the purpose of this material is to provide information and share experience not found in Conference-approved literature. A descriptive four-page list describes the items in detail. Examples of service material include: A.A. Guidelines; Regional Forum Reports; Referral List of Fellowships Similar to A.A.; Special Needs items, such as

information about A.A. literature in Braille and on audiocassettes and special literature for deaf alcoholics.

Current ongoing projects involving Group Services:

- Coordination and production of three A.A. Directories: Eastern U.S., Western U.S. and Canadian. The staff member on Group Services works closely with the Special Projects manager regarding group printouts to areas and central/intergroup offices' records.
- Supervision of G.S.O. Service files. There is a variety of service material available, upon request, to A.A. members, groups, and for service workshops.
- Supervision/production of service material such as A.A. Guidelines, Group Handbooks, and G.S.R. kits.
- Liaison with intergroup/central offices, including serving on the Policy and Site Committees of the Intergroup Seminar, which will next take place in Minneapolis, Minnesota, November 8-10, 1996.

The staff member on Group Services also serves as secretary for the trustees' Nominating Committee and the Conference Committee on Trustees.

Helen Turnquest

INTERNATIONAL/WORLD SERVICE MEETING

Trustees' committee: This committee provides shared experience and direct support to assist the progress of our message around the world. It is responsible for suggesting policies and actions to help carry the A.A. message internationally, especially in areas where there is no established service structure. The committee encourages the expansion of regional or zonal service meetings, and serves as a link between the international A.A. community and the General Service Board.

Foreign Literature Assistance— The progress of A.A. overseas provides frequent requests for new foreign language translations of A.A. literature. The 1996 budget of \$156,500 will allow A.A.W.S. to translate and publish 20 books and pamphlets, including the Bulgarian Big Book, Chinese and Slovak *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions*, Lithuanian *Came to Believe*, Turkish and Hungarian *As Bill Sees It*, and Romanian *Living Sober*, plus 13 basic pamphlets and a variety of service material. These translations are made possible through contributions from U.S./Canadian groups, and by the support of A.A. groups around the world that contribute to the World Service Meeting International Literature Fund.

World Service Meeting— Every two years delegates from countries with an organized service structure and/or literature distribution center come together at the World Service Meeting. The WSM seeks ways and means to carry the A.A. message wherever in the world the still-suffering alcoholic may be, and serves as a forum for shared experience, strength and hope. It may also represent the expression of a worldwide group conscience. This year the Fourteenth World Service Meeting will be held October 27-31 in New York City, with the theme of "Love and Gratitude in Action." Over 40 delegates representing 25 countries have indicated plans to attend.

Interim Zonal Meetings— The committee chairperson and G.S.O. general manager participated in the First Asian Oceania Service Meeting (AOSM) in Tokyo, March 23, 1995. This successful gathering concluded with plans for New Zealand to host the 1997 AOSM.

Uruguay hosted the IX Ibero-American Meeting October 18-22 with our Spanish Services staff person and general manager in attendance. Ibero-American delegates voted to rename this gathering the "Meeting of the Americas," and extended an invitation

to U.S./Canada to become a participating member. Our General Service Board accepted this invitation and the opportunity to be a part of A.A. south of the Rio Grande.

At the Eighth European Service Meeting in Frankfurt, Germany, October 27-29, 1995, the focus was "Our Primary Purpose." The overseas staff member returned from Frankfurt with ample evidence of A.A.'s growing maturity in Europe.

Other overseas visits included the publications director and overseas staff person's trip this May to the Czech Republic, Hungary and Slovakia. This was to respond to multiple requests for guidance and assistance with translations from A.A. groups and interested professionals. Among the results of this visit have been the formation of new A.A. groups in all three countries, and a rapid increase in communications.

In November, the committee's vice-chairperson combined a personal trip to Europe with visits to the Paris G.S.O. and the French-speaking G.S.O. in Brussels. December 7-10, our Spanish Services staff member was in Nicaragua for a service weekend hosted by the Managua Intergroup. The flow of communications between the Spanish Services staff person and A.A. offices and groups in Mexico, Central and South America helps assure that we are up-to-date on A.A. progress there. February 2-4, 1996, our general manager went to New Zealand to join in celebrating 50 years of A.A. in that country. Immediately following that special event, the manager traveled to Australia for a weekend of board meetings, as guest of Australia's General Service Board.

We continue to be encouraged and inspired by the international A.A. community and general service boards in other countries, who carry our message to countless thousands in new regions and across most difficult linguistic, cultural and economic barriers.

Larry Nelson, chairperson

Staff report: "Pioneering in A.A. of course has not stopped. I hope it never will. We feel secure here today, but there are still places out on the A.A. front in distant lands where right now they are going through all the pains and trials of our early days." (A.A. *Comes of Age*, p. 80) Those words, spoken by Bill W. during the 1955 St. Louis Convention, pertain to today. The A.A. message of hope and recovery continues to reach alcoholics in distant lands through traveling A.A. members, and in communications with health care professionals seeking to find out how A.A. works.

Letters from around the world come to the Overseas staff person, who responds to each request in a friendly letter often accompanied by A.A. literature. Whether sharing with a drinking alcoholic, a group struggling through difficult early days, or with members trying to set up the first central office in a land where sobriety is new, each opportunity is a reminder of the obligation inherent in the "I am responsible..." pledge. Our partners in this Twelfth Step work are 41 overseas general service offices.

The staff member on this assignment helps to implement policies and actions of the trustees' International Committee. Coordinating the biennial World Service Meeting is an absorbing aspect of this assignment. The WSM is held every two years and brings together delegates representing countries where there is a general service office or established literature distribution center. The focus is on carrying the A.A. message to the still-suffering alcoholic in countries where there is not yet a significant A.A. presence, as well as in places where A.A. is established and growing. The staff secretary coordinates mailings, welcomes new first-term delegates, and helps to organize the agenda. Four

committees of the WSM meet and discuss agenda topics submitted by delegates, and each committee presents a report to the full body.

Between World Service Meetings, country representatives gather by zone to participate in one of three meetings: European Service Meeting, Meeting of the Americas (formerly Ibero-American), and Asian-Oceania Meeting. Our General Service Board is invited to send one or two observers to each zonal meeting.

Translations of A.A. Literature— A.A.W.S. receives many offers to translate A.A. literature into a foreign language. Uppermost in each consideration is the need to ensure the integrity and authenticity of A.A.'s message. Requests that come to the overseas secretary are forwarded to the Publications Department, which has each translation checked against the English original. In countries where there is a general service board licensed to publish A.A. literature, an approved translation is often financed and published there. Where A.A. is not yet strong, A.A.W.S. undertakes the new publication when funds are available. The Big Book has been translated into 30 foreign languages, with other translations pending approval and/or funding.

International A.A. Directory— This directory is widely used by traveling A.A.s, who often return with information on new groups, as well as requests from people seeking assistance in getting A.A. underway in far away regions. Directory information is gathered by Special Projects and coordinated with the overseas staff person.

Describing how we often assist A.A. in other lands brings to mind Bill W.'s 1967 letter in the front of *A.A. Comes of Age*, "In reality, the expression 'comes of age' is used by us in a very different sense. We simply say that we have arrived at the time of life when adult responsibilities have to be faced and dealt with, as best we are able. To this end we do try to rely upon ourselves—and upon God."

Joanie Moncrief

INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS/ A.A. REGIONAL FORUMS

Trustees' committee:

International Conventions— We now know that the 60th Anniversary International Convention, held in San Diego, last July, was a wonderful experience for the approximately 56,000 participants. Eileen Garza, the Convention coordinator, other G.S.O. personnel, the Convention consultant and an incredibly supportive San Diego Host Committee combined to provide a truly International celebration of sobriety. The committee received a report from its subcommittee evaluating the 1995 Convention, and suggestions and recommendations will be incorporated into planning for the 2000 International Convention. The San Diego Convention manager reported twice to this committee giving a summation of the successes and failures of San Diego from his point of view and his recommendations for future International Conventions.

Selection of the Convention management for the year 2000 is subject to a widely distributed solicitation for bids and a recommendation will be made at the committee's July 1996 meeting. As Al-Anon has indicated an interest in participating in Minneapolis/St. Paul by holding meetings and workshops as they did in San Diego, the General Service Board has extended an invitation to Al-Anon to participate in our International Convention in the year 2000. In addition, the board, acting on a recommendation from this committee, has agreed to participate

on a limited basis in the 1998 Al-Anon International Convention to be held in Salt Lake City, Utah.

The committee considered an invitation from Australia to hold the International Convention for the year 2005 in that country. It was agreed that as the Convention is hosted by the General Service Board for the U.S. and Canada, the 2005 International Convention be held within the confines of the U.S. and Canada. It was suggested that, in the spirit of autonomy, any general service board may host an International Convention. The committee would be delighted to share their experience and answer any questions that the General Service Board of Australia may have about organizational details and our International Convention procedures. It was also suggested that, in the future, where International Conventions might be held simultaneously in different parts of the world, it may be possible to link these conventions by satellite or some other form of telecommunications.

In August 1995, invitations to submit bid proposals for the site of the 70th Anniversary International Convention (2005) were sent to delegates in the U.S. and Canada. Bid proposals were received from Atlanta, Columbus, Edmonton, Honolulu, Indianapolis, New York, Orlando, Philadelphia, Phoenix, San Antonio, St. Louis, Toronto and Vancouver. Of these the following eight cities met the basic requirements established for bidding on the Convention: Atlanta, Indianapolis, Orlando, Phoenix, San Antonio, St. Louis, Toronto and Vancouver.

At the joint meeting of the trustees' and Conference Committees on International Conventions/Regional Forums, during this Conference week, three or four potential sites will be recommended from these possible site cities. Final selection of the site for the 2005 Convention will be made by the board in late 1996, following site-inspection trips. Financial negotiations will be included as part of these site-inspection trips.

Regional Forums—Since the last General Service Conference, the following regions have held Forums: Northeast, West Central, East Central, Southwest and Western Canada. In addition, there was a Special Forum in Alma, Quebec. All were well-attended by enthusiastic members interested in service.

In response to a request for a Special Forum for the Abitibi-Temiscamingue Region of Northwest Quebec, a subcommittee was formed to design an event in keeping with the purposes of Special Forums and also tailored to the needs of that region. The subcommittee was also asked to clarify the goals of Special Forums. The outcome was a paper titled "Regional Forums and Special Forums" developed to identify the goals and objectives of both types of events. It will replace the paper "What Are Regional Forums?" in regional mailings announcing Forums.

The following forums are scheduled prior to the 1997 General Service Conference:

1996		
June 28-30	Pacific	Salt Lake City, UT
September 6-8	Eastern Canada	Sherbrooke, PQ
December 6-8	Southeast	Asheville, NC

Elaine Johnson, Ph.D., chairperson

Staff reports:

International Conventions— This assignment involves coordinating every aspect of the many processes and plans that go to make up A.A. International Conventions, held every five years. This has been a year of transition from the spectacular celebration in San Diego to gathering evaluations and suggestions from the San Diego Host Committee, a post-Convention sharing ses-

sion held at the G.S.O. and correspondence from around the world. The International Convention coordinator is responsible for making sure that the Convention comes together as an opportunity for A.A. sharing and thanksgiving. The 87 flags that were carried during the Flag Ceremony on Friday night represented A.A. meetings and members worldwide. San Diego provided a wonderful opportunity for individual A.A. members to serve, celebrate and share sobriety.

Preliminary plans are already underway for the International Convention in 2000, to be held in Minneapolis, Minnesota. Preparations and logistics are being studied to plan for three stadium meetings, celebratory dances, accommodating approximately 250 workshops, panels, regional alkathons, topic meetings and marathons which will require about 1,000 speakers and moderators. Particular attention will be paid to housing, registration and transportation. Minneapolis/St. Paul A.A. members are already excited about the unique opportunity they will have to extend the hand of A.A. to those who are able to attend the International in 2000. It is hoped that the International Convention in 2000 will provide the same experience that A.A. members found in San Diego—a milestone A.A. event filled with gratitude and the language of the heart in a beautiful setting.

Valerie O'Neill

Regional Forums— The responsibilities of this assignment involve coordinating and following through on all arrangements necessary for holding Regional Forums in the U.S. and Canada. Forums are weekend sharing sessions designed to improve communication and participation among A.A. service workers in a region, the General Service Board, A.A. World Services, Inc., the Grapevine Corporate Board, and the G.S.O. and Grapevine staffs. At the invitation of a region, four Forums are held each year. Since the U.S./Canada service structure is composed of eight regions, a Forum may be held in alternate years in a particular region on a rotating basis.

The location and agenda for a Regional Forum are decided jointly by the regional trustee, area delegates and G.S.O. The responsibility for direct contact with the hotel is assumed by a local A.A. host contact working with the Regional Forums coordinator and regional trustee. The Regional Forums coordinator at G.S.O. distributes registration forms and invitations to groups and service workers throughout the region and, working with the host contact and regional trustee, coordinates the details of the Forum.

A region may request a Special Forum, which has fewer participants from the boards and staff over shorter time periods. Special Forums require the approval of the trustees' Regional Forums Committee. They may be designed for remote, sparsely populated or urban areas. The Regional Forums coordinator works closely with the regional trustee and host contact tailoring each agenda to local needs.

Lois Fisher

LITERATURE

Trustees' committee: This report offers a summary of the literature projects of the trustees' Literature Committee since the 1995 General Service Conference.

Projects completed— Approved changes made in "The A.A. Group," including the reinstatement of a paragraph referring to Concept One; Pocket edition of *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions* published.

Projects forwarded to the Conference Literature Committee— (1) Recommended that the "Landmarks in A.A." section of A.A.

Comes of Age be returned to its original form as it was published in 1957 (the date of Bill W.'s last contribution to the timeline); (2) forwarded the draft outline of proposed content of a Fourth Edition of the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, for feedback and further guidance on how to proceed; (3) forwarded the draft manuscript of the A.A. history book project, with reviews, seeking the guidance of the Conference Literature Committee for closure; (4) referred a request to publish material on the importance of sharing our experience, strength and hope with newcomers in regard to confidentiality within A.A.; (5) recommended that a story of a bisexual alcoholic be included in the pamphlet "Do You Think You're Different?"; (6) forwarded the request for a pamphlet directed to the concerns of the nonbeliever (atheist and/or agnostic).

Ongoing projects— (1) Committee members were appointed as cochairpersons of a Literature Review subcommittee, and several items were forwarded to that subcommittee—requests to review the pamphlets "Questions and Answers on Sponsorship," "Is A.A. For You?" and "The Twelve Steps Illustrated," and a proposal to change passages in *Living Sober*; (2) monitoring the progress of the video, with accompanying service pamphlet, showing the ways G.S.O. serves the Fellowship, including the service structure, similar to the video "Circles of Love and Service."

Additional trustees' Literature Committee considerations— (1) Discussed the request to produce a pamphlet covering the history and significance of the circle and triangle to the Fellowship, and declined the request, saying that it does not feel there is a need served in the Fellowship by producing a pamphlet covering this material; (2) discussed a request to review the pamphlet "Your A.A. General Service Office" and noted that the material relating to contributions will be updated, according to the most recent Conference Actions; (3) in light of the potential for confusion and possible legal consequences, the committee denied a request to put the circle and triangle with unity, service and recovery on all General Service literature and in our A.A. *Service Manual*; (4) discussed and declined the proposal to eliminate or combine "Is A.A. For You?" and "Is A.A. For Me?"; (5) reviewed and tabled a request to consider the need for additional attention to seniors and elderly alcoholics; (6) reviewed the Foreword to the Second Edition of the Big Book and tabled the item until their July meeting in order to allow time to research background material; (7) after hearing the report of the Concepts Checklist subcommittee, it was decided to continue the ongoing study of the service piece, and the item was tabled until the July meeting.

Julian Rhinehart, chairperson

Staff report: The Literature coordinator serves as secretary to the trustees' and Conference Literature Committees and works closely with the editor, writers and illustrators on preparing all new recovery pamphlets, books, displays and audiovisuals, in accordance with recommendations from the General Service Conference. Final design and production of all this material is under the auspices of the A.A. World Services' Publications Department.

The Literature desk receives and responds to correspondence from A.A. members and groups about literature, and maintains contact with all current area, district, intergroup/central offices and A.A. group literature chairpersons. Each newly elected literature chairperson receives a welcoming letter and guidelines to assist the chairperson in this vital responsibility. Additionally, the literature coordinator is the liaison with the French Literature Service in Montreal, Quebec, Canada.

Under the present structure of G.S.O., the staff member on

the Literature desk serves as editor of *Box 4-5-9*, published bimonthly in English, French and Spanish. Work is ongoing all year for ideas for *Box 4-5-9* articles, and the calendar of events is kept up to date daily. The staff member works closely with the editor of the Publications Department and a small editorial committee to bring the Fellowship news and notes from G.S.O. through *Box 4-5-9*.

Pat Rosenstiel

LONERS, INTERNATIONALISTS, HOMERS

Staff report: As the name implies, Loners are A.A.s who are unable to attend meetings because there are no groups nearby. There are about 341 Loners in 80 countries, including the U.S. and Canada. Seagoing A.A.s, known as Internationalists, number about 150, with an additional 38 Port Contacts. Thirteen Internationalist Groups meet aboard ships or in ports. Homers are A.A.s who are housebound due to long-term illness or physical disability; we now have 125 Homers in the Loners/Internationalists Group. Loners, Homers, and Internationalists stay sober by reading A.A. literature and by sharing A.A. experience, strength and hope with other A.A.s around the world through letters and tapes.

A literature package is sent to each new Loner, Homer or Internationalist. Each also receives directories of Loners, Homers, and Internationalists, complimentary subscriptions to *Box 4-5-9* and *Loners-Internationalists Meeting*, a bimonthly meeting in print which shares excerpts of letters received at the General Service Office from LIM members. To share group activities and personal experience with the Loners, Homers and Internationalists are Loner Sponsors—A.A.s who do attend meetings regularly. There are over 929 Loner Sponsors.

A.A.'s message of hope continues to be carried around the world through traveling A.A. members, through our literature, and now through e-mail. E-mail makes it possible to offer help even faster as the following e-mail message indicates:

"Your name was given to me by someone in the Recovery Forum. My name is Hamilton and I am an alcoholic living in Korea. I live in a city in the south and there is no A.A. here. In fact, I am surrounded by a country of drinkers. I tried to call some folks I know in Seoul in the program but their number has changed. When I called the main number it too seems to have changed. So, I am in Korea without the power of the program and relying on the Recovery Forum. Perhaps you can help by sending me information on the Loners. I would be extremely happy for your help. Thanks in advance."

Since January 1996, new Loners have come from remote places such as Burma, Zambia, Bosnia, Vietnam, Pakistan, Malawi, Netherlands, Australia, Scotland, Japan, Spain and Colombia. Some Internationalists are out in the Arabian Gulf, the Mediterranean and the Black Sea. The *Loners/Internationalists Meeting-By-Mail* helps.

Much gratitude goes to Loner Sponsors who share regularly. Loner Sponsor Nat H. writes: "I'm grateful that A.A. works in so many ways — even by mail, as proved by the letters here in the LIM. And today, even by computer e-mail. I was privileged last year to be the initial sponsor for a man in a distant land where there were no real A.A. meetings for him to attend. With God's help, he will soon receive, by mail, his one-year chip. A happy day for both of us. So keep coming back. LIM works!"

Susan Ulseth

NOMINATING

Trustees' committee: To reflect the committee's responsibility for handling formation of new regions, the following statement was added to the Scope of the committee: "The committee may consider the process and procedures related to restructuring and/or re-regionalization."

Responding to the request of the 1995 Conference Committee on Trustees for more specific procedures for the formation of new regions and/or making alterations to the regional map, the trustees' Nominating Committee forwarded a draft of suggested guidelines for changing regional boundaries to the 1996 Conference Committee on Trustees for their consideration.

A draft of revised Nominating Procedures was reviewed as a work in progress. The aim is to simplify the procedures; have common language throughout, and to give some flexibility to future boards to meet the needs of the Fellowship at that particular moment.

The committee approved the following to serve as appointed committee members: Adrienne M. Brown on trustees' Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community; Sharon Lee Dubois, Mark Gornick and Bruce Henry on trustees' Correctional Facilities Committee; Anthony Hurley and Lindajo Loftus on trustees' Public Information Committee; Paul Cleary on trustees' Treatment Facilities Committee.

The committee recommended that Chuck Crist serve as general service trustee on the Grapevine Corporate Board, replacing Fran Polek, who will rotate following the 1996 General Service Conference. We also recommended that Ray Stiver and Gregory Tobin serve as nontrustee directors on the Grapevine Corporate Board, replacing Chuck Crist and Francine Ward, who will rotate following the 1996 General Service Conference.

The committee recommended the following nominations: *A.A. World Services Board:* MaryJane Roy, Northeast regional trustee, replacing Gay Garner. *A.A. Grapevine Corporate Board:* Raul Marin, Southwest regional trustee, replacing Donald Weaver.

The Nominating Committee accepted the recommendation from the Grapevine Corporate Board that Ames Sweet serve as executive editor of the *A.A. Grapevine*, and recommended that the General Service Board approve the recommendation from the Grapevine Board.

The proposed slates of General Service Board members, officers of the board, A.A. World Services and A.A. Grapevine directors were forwarded to the 1996 Conference Committee on Trustees for disapproval, if any.

The committee reviewed and will recommend the following slate of trustees at the annual meeting of the members of the General Service Board in April, following presentation at the 1996 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any:

Class A

John N. Chappel, M.D.	Arthur L. Knight, Jr.
W.J. (Jim) Estelle, Jr.	Robert O. Miller, D.D.
Gary A. Glynn	Peter Roach
Elaine M. Johnson, Ph.D.	

Class B

Peter Brock	Raul Marin
William Bungay	Larry Nelson
Chuck Crist	Julian Rhinehart
Gay Garner	MaryJane Roy
Michel Girard	Jane Murphy Schulberg
Michael McPherson	Donald Weaver

(Two regional trustees to be elected in April 1996.)

The committee recommended the following slate of officers of the General Service Board to be presented to the 1996 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any:

<i>Chairperson</i>	W.J. (Jim) Estelle, Jr.
<i>First Vice-Chairperson</i>	John N. Chappel, M.D.
<i>Second Vice-Chairperson</i>	Elaine M. Johnson, Ph.D.
<i>Treasurer</i>	Gary Glynn
<i>Secretary</i>	Michael McPherson
<i>Assistant Treasurer</i>	Donald Meurer
<i>Assistant Secretary</i>	John Grant

The committee reviewed and recommended the following slate of directors of A.A. World Services, Inc., to be presented to the 1996 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any:

Peter Brock	Gerard L. Ouellette
George Dorsey	Julian Rhinehart
Jacques Filteau	Richard Roughton
John Grant	MaryJane Roy
Michael McPherson	

The committee reviewed and recommended the following slate of directors of A.A. Grapevine, Inc., to be presented to the 1996 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any:

Charles Crist	Jane Murphy Schulberg
Elaine M. Johnson, Ph.D.	Ray Stiver
Tom Maguire	Ames Sweet
Raul A. Marin	Gregory Tobin
Larry Nelson	

Gerry Flegel, chairperson

PUBLIC INFORMATION

Trustees' committee: The responsibilities of the trustees' Public Information Committee include: Creating a greater public understanding of the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous; producing television and radio public service announcements; producing films about A.A.; preparing press releases and reports to the public; coordinating health fair and other community exhibits with local P.I. committees; conducting the A.A. Membership Survey. The scope of this committee was changed in January 1996 to include carrying the message through "electronic media" as well as "public media."

The committee met three times since the last Conference. Much of the work of the committee was done through subcommittees and the P.I. staff coordinator in the office. Following is a list of work over the past year:

- Extensive research of options for the 1996 Membership Survey regarding the statistical, financial and procedural feasibility of surveying selected groups, e.g. race, disability.
- Researched the feasibility of using machine scoring to tabulate the results of the 1996 Membership Survey.
- Implemented the A.A. Web Site, available in English, French and Spanish, which contains the A.A. Fact File and information about the location of General Service Offices worldwide.
- reviewed minor editorial changes to the A.A. Fact File.
- Based on a recommendation of this committee, the General Service Board created an Ad Hoc Web Site Committee in January 1996 to determine the approach to and content of the A.A. Web Site. The Ad Hoc Committee will also study how to

incorporate A.A. Traditions into the use of this new frontier for communication.

The following items have been referred for consideration to the 1996 Conference P.I. Committee:

- Implementation of the 1996 Membership Survey, including discussion of the content of, the Membership Survey Questionnaire.
- A review of Public Information pamphlets, looking for duplication of information and emphasis on A.A.'s primary purpose.
- Review of the Public Information Workbook.

Jane Murphy Schulberg, chairperson

Staff report: The goal of the Public Information assignment is to help to carry the A.A. message to the alcoholic, potential alcoholic and the general public through the media, health fairs, schools and A.A. Web Site on the World Wide Web/Internet. It is a crucial part of Public Information work here at G.S.O. to be a resource for the "collected experience and sharing" of P.I. committees throughout the U.S. and Canada. The staff member and staff assistant respond to hundreds of written and telephone inquiries that come into this office from the general public and the Fellowship. Currently the P.I. staff person communicates, on a bimonthly basis, with approximately 500 Public Information committee chairpeople at the area, district, intergroup/central office and group level. The staff person is responsible for handling interviews with the media describing what A.A. is and what we can and cannot do, and providing accurate information to the media, researchers and the public about Alcoholics Anonymous.

During the past year, literature has been provided for local health and community fairs. In many cases, local P.I. committees provide this literature and participate in these fairs. When possible, we try to connect the community resource with local P.I. committees so that there can be a local group conscience decision about how A.A. can best participate in these events.

New area Public Information chairpeople are automatically sent the Public Information Workbook and all P. I. committee chairpeople receive Box 4-5-9 as well as updated P.I. information from the staff member.

Extensive preparation and planning is underway for the proposed A.A. 1996 Membership Survey. The staff member coordinates several mailings to delegates who, in turn, distribute Survey Questionnaires to the groups who have been selected on a random scientific basis. The delegates are responsible for returning completed Survey Questionnaires to the staff member in either English, French or Spanish. This information, when approved, from the participating groups becomes the basis for the 1996 Membership Survey pamphlet.

The annual Anonymity letter, with a return postcard for those who wish additional information, was mailed in February as follows (each category reflects mailing to both the U.S. and Canada): daily newspapers 1,668; weekly newspapers 2,484; radio stations 684; television stations 443; black publications 239; Hispanic publications 217; the total mailing was 5,735. The staff member will receive a list of all 5,735 recipients to see if future anonymity breaks occur among our media and Anonymity letter recipients.

The staff member is researching the format of current radio and television Public Service Announcements so that formats available in our catalog will be compatible with current trends in radio and television broadcast equipment. The P.I. staff person now has an inventory of single ½ cassettes suitable for home VCRs, containing all our P.S.A.s, which are sent out upon request as an additional tool to help TV stations and P.I. com-

mittees become familiar with the contents of our P.S.A.s. We are gathering evaluations from media professionals and P.I. committees regarding updating the contents of our current P.S.A.s. A letter was mailed in January 1996 to all area and other P.I. committee chairpeople to encourage the use of radio and TV P.S.A.s in P.I. Twelfth Step work. A single-page service piece is being prepared to help local committees set up P.S.A. contacts at local TV and radio stations.

This year an A.A. member in Japan, using information provided by the General Service Office, contacted the Armed Forces Radio and Television Service. Based on that contact, G.S.O. is providing both television and radio P.S.A.s to be used on the Armed Forces Radio and Television Networks. Each P.S.A. will be aired over a period of four years and they estimate that these P.S.A.s will reach one million people.

We have received hundreds of requests from newspaper and magazine professionals asking for information about A.A. or on subjects related to alcoholism. We refer questions not directly related to A.A. to the appropriate sources. We also review movie, television and radio scripts to see that references to Alcoholics Anonymous are accurate and in keeping with our Traditions. We also decline to comment on many "hot" issues in keeping with our Tradition of not entering into public controversy. Alcoholics Anonymous is unique in that Public Information often succeeds when we do not get media attention.

The 1995 International Convention in San Diego was covered by local as well as national media and it was a great opportunity to provide information about A.A., sobriety and our worldwide membership.

Valerie O'Neill

SPANISH SERVICES

Staff report: Throughout the years, G.S.O. has provided services in several languages, including Spanish. But it was not until 1984 that the assignment of Spanish Services was formally initiated. In our general service structure there are more than 35,000 Spanish-speaking A.A. members. They meet in 1,200 groups in the U.S., Puerto Rico and Canada. The Spanish Services staff person, who does not rotate, coordinates and revises Spanish translations of material from the other staff assignments and assists other staff members in providing services to the Spanish-speaking community which are as equal as possible to the services provided to English-speaking A.A. groups. All Spanish-speaking groups receive *Box 4-5-9* in Spanish. The General Service Board's *Quarterly Report* is also distributed in Spanish, and a list of preliminary and final Conference Agenda items was distributed in Spanish to all delegates and alternate delegates.

As more bilingual people come into A.A., communication between the Spanish- and English-speaking groups is improving; the groups are represented by G.S.R.s at district meetings, where they elect bilingual D.C.M.s who represent the districts at area assemblies. Many Spanish-speaking districts have been added to the areas in our service structure. Service material is translated into Spanish and kept up-to-date. More and more Conference-approved literature is published in Spanish by our Publications Department. The Spanish Services staff member helps answer the correspondence received in Spanish by most other assignments and especially by the International assignment.

The staff member on this assignment represents G.S.O. at the Ibero-American Commission for Translation and Adaptation of A.A. Literature and attends conventions, Hispanic intergroup meetings, Regional Forums, the World Service Meeting and the

International Convention, as well as greeting Spanish-speaking visitors to G.S.O.

Danny Mooney

STAFF COORDINATOR

Staff report: Services to A.A. groups and members are provided through 12 staff assignments. In addition to assuming the responsibility for Treatment Facilities or Public Information, for example, staff members correspond with groups and members in a specific region of the U.S. and Canada, as well as with A.A.s in overseas countries. Staff members rotate assignments every two years. The staff is divided into three units so that G.S.O. mail is processed and responded to as soon as possible. These staff assignments are monitored by the staff coordinator. The International Convention assignment works parallel to all of the other units.

In 1995, G.S.O. staff received approximately 14,281 pieces of mail, and the staff coordinator ensures that mail is handled when staff members are involved with large projects, and in times of sickness and vacation. Weekly staff meetings are chaired by the staff coordinator; at these, discussion centers on problems that require direction from the group conscience, and more and better ways of providing service to A.A. groups and members. The staff coordinator maintains a calendar of required staff trips to area assemblies/conventions, making sure that the office is adequately covered at all times, and also serves as a liaison between staff members and other G.S.O. departments.

Whenever there is a staff opening, a letter is sent out to the trustees and directors announcing the opening and briefly describing the requirements for the job. The information is also posted in *Box 4-5-9*. Six years of sobriety is a requirement for a G.S.O. staff member. Business experience, excellent communication skills, and the ability to work as part of a team are among the criteria used in the selection process. The staff coordinator trains new staff members.

During 1995, staff attended a total of 93 conventions, assemblies, roundups and Regional Forums in the U.S. and Canada. These provide staff with an opportunity to communicate about G.S.O. services, to meet A.A.s throughout the U.S. and Canada and to receive information that can be shared with other groups.

In the past year, approximately 1,538 visitors from around the world came to G.S.O. Each visitor has the opportunity to tour the G.S.O. and Grapevine offices, learning about the services to the Fellowship. Often visiting members and guests attend the weekly A.A. meeting held at G.S.O. at 11:00 a.m. on most Fridays.

As assistant secretary of the General Service Board, the staff coordinator is responsible for scheduling committee meetings, distributing advance materials, preparing the minutes of the General Service Board meetings and also serves as editor of the *Quarterly Report*, the summary of the boards' activities.

The staff coordinator is a voting member of the General Service Conference and serves as secretary of the Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions. In accordance with Concept IV, the staff coordinator is also a director of A.A. World Services, Inc.

John Grant

On the subway, returning from the Tues. trip to G.S.O., staff member Pat R. and several delegates were talking among themselves when a woman next to them caught the initials G.S.O. and introduced herself as a member from Brooklyn. Right then and there she gave the delegates her group's conscience on several agenda items.

TREATMENT FACILITIES

Trustees' committee: The purpose of the trustees' Committee on Treatment Facilities is "...to further the acceptance of A.A. in hospitals, rehabilitation centers, and similar facilities, and to bring additional help to alcoholics under treatment there." (*The A.A. Service Manual*, p. S123.) Consequently, the way in which the A.A. message is finally heard by alcoholics in treatment facilities is a matter of concern, attention and development by the committee.

Since the 1995 General Service Conference, our committee has met three times. We reviewed the Composition, Scope and Procedure of the committee, current treatment facilities concerns, as well as some history of the path that treatment facilities have taken. We felt that current circumstances regarding the closing of many treatment facilities make it apparent that A.A. members need to meet alcoholics as they enter treatment as well as when they are leaving. The History and Actions of the committee were reviewed and it was noted that this was an important tool in understanding the committee's work. There appears to be a natural liaison between Public Information, Cooperation With the Professional Community, Correctional Facilities and Treatment Facilities. The three appointed committee members of the trustees' T.F. Committee have been urged to get together with other appointed committee members to share experiences and concerns.

The committee reviewed the 1995 Conference Treatment Facilities Committee Report. The committee urged that the videos: *Hope: Alcoholics Anonymous, Young People and A.A.* and *A.A.: Rap With Us* be noted as available on the Treatment Facilities Discount Package Order Form. We appointed a subcommittee to review the cover letter which accompanies the annual letter to treatment facilities administrators in the U.S. and Canada. The cover letter was to be sent to Treatment Facilities chairpersons. It was agreed that the annual letter to treatment facilities administrators in the U.S./Canada and memo to area, district and other treatment facilities committee chairpersons be mailed in November 1995, and that delegates were to receive a copy of this mailing. The mailing initiated 11 responses for more information about A.A., which we sent with a copy to the area treatment facilities committee chairperson.

We continued a general discussion on what has been happening in treatment facilities. While some hospitals, clinics and detoxes throughout the U.S. and Canada were closed, there continues to be increased growth of residential halfway houses which A.A. treatment facilities committees need to contact. In one area, a trustee reported that Twelfth Step calls tripled on the A.A. answering service.

We continued discussion on how much of a need there is for the "Treatment Facilities Newsletter," when it is so difficult to get ideas for articles. It was agreed that the "Treatment Facilities Newsletter" be placed on the Conference Treatment Facilities Committee agenda in 1996 for discussion as to whether there is a need to continue the newsletter, and to consider the real value of the newsletter.

On January 28, 1996, we warmly welcomed Tony Taschner, chairperson of the Conference Treatment Facilities Committee, visiting delegates and appointed committee members from other trustees' committees to our meeting.

The chairperson of the Conference Treatment Facilities Committee and the alternate chairperson contacted some areas to find out how area T.F. committees felt about the current

format of the Treatment Facilities Workbook, and the Conference T.F. chairperson submitted a five-page report. After a lengthy discussion on the current format of the Workbook, the trustees' T.F. Committee strongly supported the idea of developing a soft-cover booklet for Treatment Facilities committees to use, and forwarded the booklet idea to the Conference Treatment Facilities Committee for further consideration. This booklet would be used in addition to the three-ring binder Treatment Facilities Workbook currently in use.

We discussed additional topics that the Conference Treatment Facilities Committee might need to discuss: Ways to inform the Fellowship about current changes going on in the treatment field; how to get "temporary contacts" for patients being treated for alcoholism at the beginning of treatment and; to consider adding material to the Treatment Facilities Workbook on making Twelfth Step calls on "wet drunks."

John N. Chappel, M.D., chairperson

Staff report: The primary purpose of the Treatment Facilities assignment is to provide service material to assist local A.A. members who wish to carry the A.A. message to alcoholics in treatment. We have about 92 area Treatment Facilities chairpersons, 389 district T.F. chairpersons, 59 "other" Treatment Facilities chairs and 62 meeting contacts on our computer. We try to keep an up-to-date list of the chairs of these committees and to provide them with considerable information and literature. A Treatment Facilities Workbook is sent to all area, district and other chairpeople. This workbook is a comprehensive guide about carrying the message "inside," containing shared experience, suggestions, general information, guidelines and literature. Treatment Facilities chairpersons receive Box 4-5-9, *About A.A.*, the "Treatment Facilities Newsletter," and a current list of the 92 chairs in the U.S. and Canada. All chairs have copies of the U.S. and Canadian Directory of intergroups and central offices for referral purposes.

Mail comes to the Treatment Facilities desk from four sources: (1) newly sober alcoholics in treatment facilities; (2) local A.A.s who have become or are interested in becoming active on treatment facilities committees; (3) treatment facilities administrators or personnel requesting information about A.A. and assistance in setting up meetings, and; (4) area Treatment Facilities committees' meeting minutes and reports.

Another major staff activity entails serving as secretary to both trustees' and Conference Committees on Treatment Facilities. The staff member also gathers material for an occasional treatment facilities article in Box 4-5-9 and prepares biannual editions of the "Treatment Facilities Newsletter" from Treatment Facilities committees throughout the U.S. and Canada.

Susan Ulseth



Reports from the A.A. Grapevine

Directors' report: The twelve months since the 45th General Service Conference have seen significant change and growth in virtually every aspect of the Grapevine's life. Circulation rose by about 10,000 over the course of the year; sales of related materials were very strong; the corporation ended the year well ahead of budget; the groundwork was laid for launching a Spanish edition in mid-1996; and a new management structure was put in place, to take effect at the end of this Conference.

Circulation: After a prolonged decline that began with the April 1990 price increase and continued through late 1994, circulation finally rebounded in 1995. A program of sending special mailings from the office was instrumental in effecting the turnaround. Mailings to former subscribers, past delegates, correctional and other service committees, intergroup/central offices, Loners/ Internationalists, and others resulted in a healthy influx of subscriptions, and enhanced awareness of the Grapevine throughout the Fellowship. In addition, a "bill me later" option was offered for the first time this year, and a new full-color magazine order form was developed to attract new readers.

Finances and Magazine Price Increase: Financially speaking, 1995 was an unexpectedly good year. The 1995 budget called for a net loss of \$109,000, and the Grapevine actually ended the year with a net loss of only \$32,790 — \$3,290 on operations, and \$29,500 on the Spanish Grapevine project. Those results were attributable primarily to very strong sales of related materials (especially *The Language of the Heart*) and to cost-cutting that kept expenses low.

Nothing, however, intervened to lower magazine expenses, as costs of paper and postage rose dramatically. One result was that in spite of the higher-than-budgeted circulation, gross profit on the magazine was lower than budget and also lower than the 1994 level. Therefore, in January the board approved and forwarded to the trustees' Finance Committee a 1996 budget that called for a magazine price increase of 25%, effective April 1, 1996. Even with the price increase, the 1996 budget anticipates a \$93,000 deficit; by 1997, when the effect of the increase will be felt more strongly, management expects a net income in the neighborhood of \$71,000.

The board voted at the January meeting to transfer to the investment account the \$78,000 interest earned on the unfulfilled subscription liability investment account in the General Service Board Reserve Fund, thus bringing the investment account within the guidelines of plus or minus 5% of the total liability. The board also forwarded to the trustees' Finance Committee a request to draw down \$100,000 cash to fund operations.

In order to minimize any decline in circulation that might occur as a result of the price increase, management will continue the program of special mailings, and will develop new ways of introducing the Grapevine to potential subscribers over the coming year. In addition, to provide greater value for the higher price, the size of the Grapevine will be increased to 64 pages every month (for

the past several years, some issues have been 64 pages, some have been 48).

Related Materials: Immediately after last year's Conference, at the May 6 meeting, the board took a hard look at some of the related materials that showed minimal sales, or had an extremely low gross profit margin, and voted to discontinue several items: *A.A. Today*, the miniature Grapevine, the Victor E. name tags, and all discount packages. The board also raised the prices of some items with gross profit margins of 30% or less: the Co-founders' Memorial Issues, the A.A. Grapevine Workbook, Grapevine binders, the display holder, and the packages of 50 back issues.

Overall, sales of related materials were higher than budgeted, and sales of *The Language of the Heart: Bill W.'s Collected Grapevine Writings* was especially high. Other books and booklets, as well as the cassette tapes, also came in better than budgeted, though for the most part volumes were lower than the 1994 levels.

In July, the board voted to produce the Wall Calendar in full color for the first time. Since the redesign of the magazine in June 1994, when the practice of full-color covers on every issue was initiated, the staff has been receiving a large number of excellent color photos from A.A. members. When the call for black-and-white calendar photos went out, it incorporated a request for color photographs to be used on the magazine cover, and the result was an influx of superb color photos, but very few high-quality black-and-white pictures. As the editors began selecting material for the calendar, it became clear that putting together a black-and-white calendar of acceptable quality would be difficult, but a color calendar was a strong possibility. Cost estimates indicated that only a minimal price increase would be necessary, and thus a management proposal for a color calendar went to the board and was accepted. Sales of the calendar, and its companion Pocket Planner, were strong enough to make it necessary to go back to press on both.

Spanish Magazine and Other Materials: The 45th Conference approved the development of a Spanish edition of the magazine, to be funded for up to five years by the General Service



Board Reserve Fund, subject to approval of a business plan by the trustees' Finance Committee. Questionnaires designed to establish a probable initial circulation base were mailed widely throughout the Fellowship in June and July, and distributed at the International Convention in San Diego. The business plan, which assumes a starting circulation of 6,000, was approved by both the Grapevine Board and the trustees' Finance Committee in October 1995—with recognition by both of these bodies that the new magazine is a risk and needs the continuing support of Hispanic A.A.s in the U.S. and Canada as well as good overseas circulation. The plan is based on a bimonthly magazine, to be launched with the July-August issue, and the pricing structure is comparable to that of the English magazine. To date, a Spanish-speaking editor has been hired, and the hardware and software needed for design and production are in-house.

Spanish translations of the Slogans, Serenity Prayer, and Preamble were made available just before last year's Conference, and *El Lenguaje del Corazon*, the Spanish translation of *The Language of the Heart*, was published in late June 1995 and introduced at the International Convention. The 1994 budget called for sales of about 10,000 copies at the Convention, an expectation that was not realized. The board is hopeful that with the advent of the Spanish magazine, more Hispanic A.A.s will become aware of the other Grapevine materials available to carry the message in Spanish.

Board and Management Structure: In September, the board forwarded the names of Ray Stiver and Gregory Tobin to the trustees' Nominating Committee as candidates for nontrustee director. In October, the board forwarded the name of Chuck Crist to the Nominating Committee as candidate for general service trustee.

In executive session after the July board meeting, directors accepted the request of executive editor Ann Warner to retire effective April 30, 1996. The board search committee, chaired by Elaine Johnson, Class A trustee, solicited the resumes of qualified applicants for the position, and after interviews in January, Ames Sweet was named the new executive editor by unanimous vote of the board.

At several meetings, directors engaged in discussion of possible changes in the composition of the board, to make the board more effective and also, if possible, to cut costs. No conclusions were reached; however, as the result of the retirement of the executive editor and changes in the management structure, one staff position on the board has been left vacant. In order to cut costs, planning committee meetings will be held on Saturdays beginning in June, thus eliminating the expense of one extra day in New York for out-of-town directors.

General Service Conference Business: The board forwarded to the Conference Committee on the Grapevine several items for that committee's agenda: a proposal for a Conference-approved pamphlet on the Grapevine; several suggestions for new related materials that might be produced in 1998; and a suggestion that the committee discuss the use of industry mailings lists by the Grapevine.

At the October meeting, the board voted to forward to the trustees' Finance Committee and the Conference Finance Committee a request that "beginning with fiscal year 1996, the interest income earned from the unfulfilled subscription investment with the General Service Board Reserve Fund, after adjustment to ensure that the liability is fully funded, be transferred to the Grapevine's operating cash on an annual basis."

Two conference calls between directors and delegate members of the Conference Grapevine Committee have enhanced communication and promoted understanding of the work of the board.

Other Board Business: At the January meeting, the board

GRAPEVINE CIRCULATION — GEOGRAPHIC BREAKDOWN

	CIRCULATION		INCREASE/ DECREASE
	APRIL 1996	APRIL 1995	
UNITED STATES			
Alabama	1,367	1,329	38
Alaska	571	487	84
Arizona	1,891	1,722	169
Arkansas	677	695	— 18
California	12,694	12,147	547
Colorado	1,751	1,551	200
Connecticut	2,061	2,006	55
Delaware	457	415	42
District of Columbia	284	278	6
Florida	6,288	6,001	287
Georgia	3,010	2,884	126
Hawaii	517	420	97
Idaho	594	584	10
Illinois	5,291	5,210	81
Indiana	1,892	1,893	— 1
Iowa	1,485	1,572	— 87
Kansas	1,569	1,528	41
Kentucky	1,258	1,112	146
Louisiana	1,165	1,136	29
Maine	891	852	39
Maryland	1,861	1,814	47
Massachusetts	3,849	3,831	18
Michigan	3,743	3,519	224
Minnesota	3,101	3,112	— 11
Mississippi	790	797	— 7
Missouri	2,227	2,164	63
Montana	664	681	— 17
Nebraska	1,345	1,407	— 62
Nevada	693	656	37
New Hampshire	756	707	49
New Jersey	3,521	3,531	— 10
New Mexico	709	689	20
New York	7,981	7,829	152
North Carolina	2,929	2,848	81
North Dakota	508	508	0
Ohio	3,691	3,388	303
Oklahoma	1,474	1,432	42
Oregon	1,373	1,254	119
Pennsylvania	5,403	4,959	444
Rhode Island	539	493	46
South Carolina	1,322	1,239	83
South Dakota	503	524	— 21
Tennessee	1,618	1,561	57
Texas	5,479	5,363	116
Utah	683	598	85
Vermont	476	421	55
Virginia	2,748	2,664	84
Washington	3,537	3,432	105
West Virginia	535	532	3
Wisconsin	2,976	2,870	106
Wyoming	350	334	16
Puerto Rico	87	85	2
U.S. Possessions	86	81	5
Total	113,270	109,145	4,125
CANADA			
Alberta/NWT	1,274	1,328	— 54
British Columbia/Yukon	1,655	1,747	— 92
Manitoba	484	534	— 50
New Brunswick/ Prince Edward Island	566	559	7
Nova Scotia/ Newfoundland/Labrador	793	870	— 77
Ontario	4,212	4,175	37
Quebec	419	420	— 1
Saskatchewan	760	782	— 22
Total	10,163	10,415	(252)
FOREIGN			
	1,799	1,650	149
Grand Total	123,232	120,210	3,022
(exclusive of monthly orders)			



voted to add to the permissions policy for translation of Grapevine materials into other languages a provision that if a foreign country requests permission to translate material that has already been translated by the Grapevine, permission be denied and the requesting entity be required to use the Grapevine's translation. In accordance with this policy, El Salvador and Mexico requested and received permission to reprint the Grapevine's translation of *The Language of the Heart*.

In October, the board approved modifications to the employee retirement plan that allow early retirement at age 55 with 10 years' service, or age 60 with eight years' service, and lower the early retirement penalty from 6 % to 4 % per year.

In January, directors expressed their deep appreciation and gratitude for the work of the Grapevine support staff, especially recognizing the high attendance after the blizzard in January and the long hours employees have put in during a year when orders for both the magazine and related materials were exceptionally strong.

At the March planning committee meeting, directors enjoyed a joint meeting and sharing session with members of the Grapevine Editorial Advisory Board.

Donald Weaver, chairperson

Staff report: In June 1944, the Grapevine "office" consisted of a half dozen volunteers working out of an apartment in New York City. In 1945, the Grapevine hired its first paid employee—a combination typist, clerk, secretary and circulation supervisor—for \$40.00 a month. (It wasn't until 1962 that it became possible to pay an editor.) Today, the corporation has 20 paid employees, a budget of nearly two million dollars, and is about to embark on a Spanish-language edition of the magazine.

Occupying a quarter of the space of the General Service Office, on the tenth floor at 475 Riverside Drive, the Grapevine office is arranged around four departments, each with their own focus and function: accounting/bookkeeping, circula-

tion, shipping and editorial. Currently, the office is managed by an executive editor and a managing editor (both members of A.A.), and a nonalcoholic controller/business administrator. The executive editor has oversight responsibility as chief executive for the Grapevine operation and reports directly to the Grapevine Corporate Board. The managing editor is responsible for all magazine editorial and production functions and supervises the GvR program. The controller/business administrator manages all business aspects of the corporation and handles all financial planning.

Recently the Grapevine hired Mara Hennessey to serve as executive secretary and Jaime Manrique to serve as editor of Spanish resources. Cynthia Keyworth, who has been at the Grapevine for many years as copyeditor and editorial assistant, was promoted to the position of senior editor, and Bob Slotterback, formerly the Grapevine's bookkeeper, was promoted to the position of assistant controller.

With a welcome increase in magazine circulation and higher-than-anticipated related item sales, not to mention all the preparatory work associated with launching the new Spanish edition, the Grapevine office has enjoyed a busy and fulfilling year.

Ames Sweet, managing editor



Literature Distributed - 1995

ENGLISH

Books

Alcoholics Anonymous	498,718
Alcoholics Anonymous (soft cover)	404,754
Alcoholics Anonymous (large print)	18,256
Alcoholics Anonymous (pocket abridged)	95,266
Daily Reflections	139,724
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (reg. ed.)	217,625
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (gift ed.)	34,420
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (soft cover)	173,010
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (large print)	8,611
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (pocket ed.)	23,710
A.A. Comes of Age	15,916
As Bill Sees It	66,023
Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers	15,440
"Pass It On"	15,395
Total	1,726,868

Booklets

The A.A. Service Manual/ Twelve Concepts for World Service	33,190
Living Sober	165,350
Came to Believe	88,461
A.A. in Prisons: Inmate to Inmate	24,912
Total	311,913

Pamphlets

A.A. and Employee Assistance Programs	11,191
A.A. and the Armed Services	6,036
A.A. and the Gay/Lesbian Alcoholic	31,026
A.A. as a Resource for the Health Care Professional	16,979
A.A. for the Native North American	25,466
A.A. for the Woman	111,735
The A.A. Group	76,621
A.A. in Your Community	25,426
A.A. in Correctional Facilities	17,302
A.A. in Treatment Facilities	19,131
The A.A. Membership Survey	26,676
The A.A. Member - Medications and Other Drugs	88,350
A.A. Tradition - How It Developed	29,948
A.A.'s Legacy of Service	12,214
A Brief Guide to Alcoholics Anonymous	120,297
Circles of Love and Service	21,931
Bridging the Gap	22,905
Members of the Clergy Ask About A.A.	12,255
The Co-Founders of Alcoholics Anonymous	15,130
Do You Think You're Different?	131,157
44 Questions	221,432
G.S.R.	30,447
How A.A. Members Cooperate	17,475
How It Works	57,555
If You Are a Professional	21,891
Inside A.A.	50,110
Is A.A. for You?	293,648
Is A.A. for Me?	106,629
Is There an Alcoholic in Your Life?	92,530
It Happened to Alice	42,144
It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell	52,956
The Jack Alexander Article	35,220
Let's Be Friendly With Our Friends	10,762

Letter to a Woman Alcoholic	93,602
A Member's-Eye View of A.A.	58,965
Memo to an Inmate Who May Be an Alcoholic	43,157
A Message to Correctional Facilities Administrators	8,165
A Newcomer Asks	292,804
Problems Other Than Alcohol	111,948
Questions and Answers on Sponsorship	278,843
Speaking at Non-A.A. Meetings	17,375
The Twelve Concepts for World Service Illustrated	16,883
The Twelve Steps Illustrated	89,522
The Twelve Traditions Illustrated	42,010
This Is A.A.	255,284
Three Talks to Medical Societies by Bill W.	18,392
Time to Start Living	64,275
Time to Start Living (large print)	10,381
Too Young?	97,843
Understanding Anonymity	63,585
What Happened to Joe	42,493
Young People and A.A.	114,176
Total	3,574,278

Miscellaneous

Wallet cards-two-fold	579,094
Wallet cards-I Am Responsible	63,282
Wallet cards-Anonymity	31,315
Anonymity Display Card	5,112
Parchment-scrolls	2,587
Placards	428
C.P.C. Workbook	881
Correctional Facilities Workbook	1,616
P.I. Workbook	1,223
Treatment Facilities Workbook	419
A.A. Guidelines	54,989
Group Handbook	3,186
Wire Racks	2,218
Cassettes (tape cassettes)	2,828
Alcoholics Anonymous (cassette album)	4,050
A.A. Comes of Age (cassette album)	345
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (cassette album)	2,290
TV Public Service Announcement	293
Radio Public Service Announcements	380
Twelve Steps Shade displays	1,885
Twelve Traditions Shade displays	1,802
Fact Files	5,212
Total	765,435
Grand Total	6,378,494

SPANISH

Books

Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous soft cover)	28,244
Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous hardcover)	3,529
Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous abridged pocket size)	8,109

New Panel 46 delegate Robbie Sullivan (Montana) followed her husband Mark (Panel 44); the second couple to follow each other as delegates since the late '70s.

Como Lo Ve Bill (As Bill Sees It)	6,021
A.A. Llega a su Mayoría de Edad (A.A. Comes of Age)	2,883
El Dr. Bob y los Buenos Veteranos (Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers)	2,336
Reflexiones Diarias (Daily Reflections)	6,510
Total	57,632

Booklets

Viviendo Sobrio (Living Sober)	13,605
El Manual de Servicios de A.A./Doce Conceptos para el Servicio Mundial (A.A. Service Manual/Twelve Concepts)	1,771
Doce Pasos y Doce Tradiciones (Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions)	24,767
Llegamos a Creer (Came to Believe)	4,924
A.A. en Prisiones de Preso a Preso (Inmate to Inmate)	5,103
Doce Pasos y Doce Tradiciones (pocket ed.)	270
Total	50,440

Pamphlets

A.A. en Su Comunidad (A.A. in Your Community)	4,878
44 Preguntas (44 Questions)	20,689
Esto es A.A. (This is A.A.)	23,844
Es A.A. para Usted? (Is A.A. for You?)	43,688
Carta a una Mujer Alcohólica (Letter to a Woman Alcoholic)	7,549
Hay un Alcohólico en su Vida? (Is There an Alcoholic in Your Life?)	10,158
Carta a un Preso que Puede Ser Un Alcohólico (Memo to an Inmate)	8,022
El Punto de Vista de un Miembro de A.A. (A Member's-Eye View)	4,719
Alcohólicos Anónimos por Jack Alexander (Jack Alexander Article)	3,433
Tres Charlas a Sociedades Medicas por Bill W. (Three Talks to Medical Societies)	5,081
Un Principiante Pregunta (A Newcomer Asks)	14,017
Como Trabaja el Programa (How It Works)	5,421
Lo que le Sucedió a José (What Happened to Joe)	10,353
Comprendiendo el Anonimato (Understanding Anonymity)	3,009
El Grupo de A.A. (The A.A. Group)	6,657
Preguntas y Respuestas sobre el Apadrinamiento (Questions and Answers on Sponsorship)	9,556
El Miembro de A.A. - Los Medicamentos y Otras Drogas (The A.A. Member - Medications and Other Drugs)	5,285
Las Doce Tradiciones Ilustradas (The Twelve Traditions Illustrated)	4,676
A.A. en Centros de Tratamiento (A.A. in Treatment Centers)	3,802
Los Jóvenes y A.A. (Young People and A.A.)	12,223
La Tradición de A.A. - ¿Cómo se Desarrolló? (A.A. Tradition - How It Developed)	3,093
Una Breve Guía a A.A. (A Brief Guide to A.A.)	10,571
A.A. en las Instituciones Correccionales (A.A. in Correctional Facilities)	3,129
Problemas Diferentes del Alcohol (Problems Other Than Alcohol)	5,500
Es Mejor que Estar Sentado en una Celda (It Sure Beats Sitting In a Cell)	7,523
¿Cómo Cooperan los Miembros de A.A.? (How A.A. Members Cooperate)	1,804
Dentro de A.A. (Inside A.A.)	3,738

A.A. como Recurso para los Profesionales de la Salud (A.A. as a Resource for the Health Care Professional)	3,609
Un Ministro Religioso Pregunta Acerca de A.A. (The Clergy Asks)	2,910
R.S.G. (G.S.R.)	3,596
¿Se Cree Usted Diferente? (Do You Think Your Different?)	8,667
Le Sucedió a Alicia (It Happened to Alice)	3,671
Hablando en Reuniones no-A.A. Speaking at non-A.A. Meetings	2,912
A.A. Para la Mujer (A.A. for the Woman)	9,599
Encuesta Sobre los Miembros de A.A. (A.A. Membership Survey)	1,751
A.A. y los Programas de Alcoholismo Empresariales (A.A. and Employee Assistance Programs)	1,570
Es A.A. Para Mi? (Is A.A. for Me?)	7,516
Tiempo Para Empezar a Vivir (Time to Start Living)	2,467
Los Doce Pasos Ilustrados (The Twelve Steps Illustrated)	7,630
Total	298,316

Miscellaneous

Guias (Guidelines)	5,291
Parchments, Spanish	1,212
Tarjetas Tamaño Billetera (wallet cards)	25,443
Alcohólicos Anónimos (cassette album) (Big Book on cassette)	583
Los Doce Pasos (cassette album) (Twelve Steps on cassette)	823
Total	33,352
Grand Total	439,740

FRENCH

Books

Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous - format relie)	3,942
Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous - format poche)	3,076
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve & Twelve - format relie)	1,746
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve & Twelve - format poche)	3,581
Le Mouvement des A.A. devient Adulte (A.A. Comes of Age)	591
Reflexions de Bill (As Bill Sees It)	3,169
Reflexions Quotidiennes (Daily Reflections)	5,008
Total	21,113

Tenth Step

In last year's *Conference Report* we married off Dorothy Newrohr (North Dakota) to the wrong Jim (Redemske). Actually, it is Jim Wilson (Southern Indiana) who is Dorothy's new husband and the Panel 44 newly weds are residing in Indiana. Our apologies to all — especially Mrs. Redemske.

Plaquettes (Booklets)

Nous en sommes venus a croire (Came to Believe)	1,958
Vivre ... sans alcool! (Living Sober)	2,889
Le Manuel du Service et les Douze Concepts	1,802
Total	6,649

Brochures (Pamphlets)

Voici les A.A. (This is A.A.)	18,932
Les A.A.: 44 Questions (44 Questions)	3,027
Les A.A.: sont-ils pour vous? (Is A.A. for You?)	24,389
Les A.A. pour la femme (A.A. for the Woman)	990
Cooperation des membres des A.A. (How A.A. Members Cooperate)	340
Les A.A. et les programmes d'aide aux employes (A.A. & Employee Assistance Programs)	279
Le membre des A.A. face aux medicaments et a la drogue (The A.A. Member - Medications & Other Drugs)	912
Les A.A. - Article du Saturday Evening Post (The Jack Alexander Article)	232
Collaborons avec nos amis (Let's Be Friendly With Our Friends)	207
Questions et reponses sur le parrainage (Questions and Answers on Sponsorship)	2,780
Les A.A.: Une ressource pour les medecins (A.A. as a Resource for the Health Care Professional)	1,105
Les A.A. dans les centres de traitement (A.A. in Treatment Facilities)	325
La Tradition des A.A. et son developpement (A.A. Tradition/How It Developed)	1,424
Vous vous occupez prof. d'alcoolisme? (If You Are a Professional)	1,049
L'Histoire de Nicole (It Happened to Alice)	503
Jean face a son probleme d'alcool (What Happened to Joe)	501
Les A.A. dans votre milieu (A.A. in Your Community)	2,447
Problemes autres que l'alcoolisme (Problems Other Than Alcohol)	2,273
Point de vue d'un membre sur les A.A. (A Member's-Eye View of A.A.)	343
Les Douze Traditions illustrees (The Twelve Traditions Illustrated)	874
Les A.A. dans les etablissements correctionnels (A.A. in Correctional Facilities)	158
Ca vaut mieux que de languir en prison (It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell)	393
Petit guide pratique sur les A.A. (A Brief Guide to A.A.)	1,971
Les membres du clerge se renseignent (Members of the Clergy Ask About A.A.)	365
Les deux fondateurs d'A.A. (The Co-founders of A.A.)	399
Message a l'intention d'un detenu (Memo to an Inmate)	571
Message aux Dir. d'Etabl. Correctionnels (Message to Correctional Facilities Administrators)	85
Le groupe des A.A. (The A.A. Group)	2,062
Les Douze Concepts illustres (Twelve Concepts Illustrated)	555
Le sens de l'anonymat (Understanding Anonymity)	554
Trois causeries a des societes medicales (Three Talks to Medical Societies)	698
Y-a-t-il un alcoolique dans votre vie? (Is There an Alcoholic in Your Life?)	1,546
Le R.S.G. (The G.S.R.)	1,548

Causeries a l'exterieur des A.A. (Speaking at Non-A.A. Meetings)	369
Trop jeune? (Too Young?)	1,137
La Structure de l'Association des A.A. (Inside A.A.)	1,468
L'Heritage des Services des A.A. (A.A.'s Legacy of Service)	238
Cercles d'amour et de service (Circles of Love & Service)	1,440
Vous croyez-vous different? (Do You Think You're Different?)	996
Lettre a une femme alcoolique (Letter to a Woman Alcoholic)	893
Sondage de 1992 sur les membres des A.A. (The A.A. Membership Survey)	1,935
Les jeunes et les A.A. (Young People & A.A.)	1,194
Votre B.S.G. (Your G.S.O.)	1,888
Il est encore temps de vivre (Time to Start Living)	837
Un nouveau veut savoir (A Newcomer Asks)	8,033
Les A.A. sont-ils pour moi? (Is A.A. for Me?)	1,055
Favoriser de rapprochement (Bridging the Gap)	169
Les Douze Etapes Illustrees (Twelve Steps Illustrated)	1,578
Les A.A. et les gais et lesbiennes alcooliques (A.A. for the Gay and Lesbian Alcoholic)	289
Les A.A. et les Autochtones d'Amerique du Nord (A.A. and the Native North American)	326
Total	97,682

Lignes de conduite A.A. (Guidelines)	Total	4,453
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Divers (Miscellaneous)

12 & 12 (cassette album)	331
Le Gros Livre (cassettes album)	333
Carte 12 Etapes/12 Traditions (Wallet card 12 Steps & 12 Traditions)	2,021
Carte anonymat (Francais/anglais) (Anonymity wallet card)	148
Cassettes	54
Notre Methode (How It Works)	18,015
Manuel de Groupe	83
Manuel de l'Information Publique	26
Manuel des Centres de Detention	10
Manuel de la CMP	9
Messages d'Interet Publique (Radio P.S.A.)	5
Priere Serenite (Carte) (Serenity Prayer wallet card)	22,695
Slogans (serie de 5) (Five A.A. Slogans)	233
Suggestions Reunions Debutants (Guide for Leading Beginners Meetings)	170
Manuel des Centres de Traitement	6
Dossier d'Information sur les A.A. (Fact File)	273
Total	44,412
Grand Total	174,309



Area Service Highlights

Alaska: Our area has 217 groups, 12 districts and a land mass equal to 1/5 the United States. We have an area assembly two times a year and a state roundup every two years. Though our distances are great, we are blessed with excellent communication systems and some districts teleconference their meetings. Our C.P.C. and P.I. committees give health care officials literature to take into the villages. In the Aleutian islands, there is a very small group that periodically calls a meeting at a pre-arranged time, uses a speaker phone on both ends, and participates in a larger meeting in a populated area. Some of our districts are thinking of doing this kind of Twelfth Step work for loners or very small isolated groups. We are very active and happy to be growing and learning new ways of carrying the message.— *Charlotte Ingalls*

Alberta/Northwest Territories: A considerable portion of Area 78 includes the Northwest Territories, which cover the Canadian Arctic and have about 30 groups. It is currently under consideration to pass on the responsibility for some of the N.W.T. to other Canadian areas. Even without the N.W.T. we cover about 400,000 square miles, so effective communication is essential. We have about 590 groups served by 49 districts. Seventeen of those districts and about 200 groups are located in Edmonton and Calgary, our 2 major cities, with the balance scattered over a vast area. We have implemented the committee system at the area level. I marvel at the high level of maturity we display at our area meetings, a marked contrast from a few years ago. To me that indicates that we have developed a good understanding of our Three Legacies, thus enabling us to focus on our primary purpose.— *Bob Watt*

Arizona: Area 3 is divided into 15 counties; within each county are 64 districts. Each district has one D.C.M. and 3 to 20 groups with a G.S.R. for each group. We have 4 assemblies per year and an annual convention. Our service structure patterns that of the Conference, with all assignments to committees randomly selected by computer for a two-year term. Arizona is ethnically diverse, with Hispanic and Native American groups throughout the area. Our Spanish districts were host for the 22nd Hispanic Convention, U.S. In 1994 a request was made to G.S.O. asking permission to make a cassette recording of the Big Book in the Navajo language. As this would be a major undertaking, it was decided instead to translate Chapter Five only and then send a

few copies to some Navajo A.A. groups for their response. This project is still on-going. Our challenges include improving our communication throughout the area, increasing group participation in the area, and continuing to effectively carry A.A.'s life-giving message.— *Bob Cordero*

California (Mid-Southern): Area 9 is a very service-oriented area, with an active and effective committee system. Our C.P.C. committee has created a slide program for any professional organization that is interested in this information. We have a permanent Archives, that maintains regular visiting hours as well as hosting two area events. The Grapevine committee is still active in the Adopt a Group (in Russia) program and in the promotion of the newly published Spanish version of the Grapevine. The Spanish groups in our area are consistently growing. The finance committee's major role is to advise the treasurer and the area on our financial issues; the Convention Liaison is kept busy at all the many conventions within our 26 districts. We have two new committees, Special Needs and Literature.— *Lona Wright-Parker*

California (Northern Interior): This is a challenging and exciting time to be delegate in my area. The G.S.R.s are actively assuming their responsibilities at our four assemblies a year which has generated increased P.I./C.P.C., Grapevine and Archives activity at the district and group level. The unity and leadership among the 29 districts resulted in over 100 events in the last year. One example is the recommendation to use our prudent reserve fund to purchase compatible upgrades of our computer systems to streamline the interchange of information among officers. Another is the purchase of translation equipment for our two linguistic districts. We are actively focused on the subject of Special Needs in the Fellowship. I am truly thankful to be a part of our continued growth as we continue "To Come of Age" as an area.— *Joe Burnes*

California (San Diego/Imperial): Area 8 has 824 registered groups with 25,684 members, served by 19 English- and three Spanish-speaking districts. We hold five area assemblies per year. We have a committee system, which mirrors that of the General Service Conference. Last June, we were able to utilize over 6,000 local A.A. volunteers in welcoming A.A.s to San Diego, for the 60th International Convention. It was an honor to be chosen as host city for this spectacular event. Each June, all of the service entities, including our intergroups, hold a Unity Day Celebration. Our Archives committee hosts an annual R.O.O.T.S. event, remembering our oldtimers, and our C.P.C. committee sponsors a yearly forum. We join the Southern California and Mid-Southern California Areas annually in a Three Area DCM Sharing Session. We are looking forward to hosting the Pacific Region Service Assembly (PRAASA) in 1997.— *J. P. Paynter*

Delaware: Area 12 has 195 groups, 13 districts and 3 intergroups. We hold four annual assembly meetings, with each one preceded 10 days in advance by an area committee meeting. We also have a three-day weekend convention, always well attended. This year, we will host NERC in Wilmington in October. Many of our service-minded volunteers are pitching in to help. Recently, we held our first one-day mini-assembly, which was well attended and co-supported by groups and the assembly. Our special committees include Grapevine, Archives, Literature, C.P.C., P.I. and Convention. Intergroups take care of institutional commitments. Among our challenges are to get more people involved in service work.— *Bert Mitchell*

Georgia: We have 755 groups, 41 institutional groups and approximately 17,000 members. Our area assembly is three



times a year; 751 attended our January assembly and all 49 districts were present. We have six standing committees: P.I., C.P.C., Treatment, Corrections, Archives, and Grapevine. Our state prepaid convention rotates around the state and is in October; we have seven geographic regions in the state and conduct a cluster forum in each region during the year. Our standing committees hold three service workshops in different areas. We have a centrally located state office to maintain all records and to enhance communication and unity between our groups. Our "Hospitality Committee" is preparing to welcome members from all over the world during the 1996 Olympics. We hope to meet the challenge of "Preserving Our Fellowship" through "Participation" and "informing the uninformed."— *Joycie Wren*

Idaho: Area 18 has ten districts, covering the entire state of Idaho. We have approximately 180 active groups. We conduct five area committee meetings and two assembly/conventions per year. We are combining P.I. and C.P.C. on an East and West basis in an effort to cut travel time and cost. Hospitals and Institutions have been active on an East and West basis for a long time. Our H&I is self-supporting on an area level due to group contributions and the "Pink Can." Our Archives is fantastic and growing all the time. We conduct business from guidelines adopted in 1988, based on the A.A. *Service Manual*, Traditions and Concepts. We fully fund our delegate and one other committee member to Pacific Region Service Assemblies, Pacific Northwest Conference, Regional Forums, and all elected members to local conference/ assemblies. We in Idaho serve A.A. with great enthusiasm, dedication, and love.— *Marti Hooper*

Illinois (Northern): Area 20 serves 25 districts with 1,000 registered groups. Each district has a monthly meeting for the district servants and G.S.R.s. We have four committee meetings a year, which set the agenda for the four assemblies held each year, and a spring conference. We also join the Southern Illinois and the Chicago areas in a state conference each year. Other conferences include a Big Book Conference, a Delegate Pre-Conference Workshop and a Post-Conference Workshop. Recently we have added a Records Keeper and a Literature Committee. We are also addressing the special needs of those members that are physically challenged. We also have a Computer Committee, originally established to keep track of the area equipment, teach if necessary and repair. Recently they have begun to research the feasibility of expanding communications with the use of computers and fax machines— *Thomas Gore*

Indiana (Southern): Area 23 has 26 districts and over 500 groups; we hold four assembly meetings rotating around the area. We alternate with our friends in northern Indiana in hosting our annual Indiana State Convention. Our literature and archive displays are readily available and maintain a high profile at area, district and intergroup functions. We have added an intergroup liaison to help communicate with the intergroups and to minimize duplication of services. We hope to focus our energies and attention on our standing committees as they meet to plan and implement the most effective ways and means to carry our message. Enthusiasm for service can be infectious; when we sponsor people into service and make it an altruistic part of our recovery the real joy of living is no longer a promise; it becomes a reality.— *Mike Smith*

Kansas: Area 25 has approximately 379 groups in 30 districts; we hold two full assemblies and two committee meetings annually. An ad hoc Archives committee is working on a recommendation to the assembly for the disposition of the material collected over the past few years. We have also formed an

ad hoc committee to develop a Twelfth Step workshop that will help us work with the still-practicing alcoholic who does not have benefit of a treatment facility and/or detox unit. This year we will be looking at the feasibility of changing our committee structure to function something like the committee structure at the General Service Conference. We will also be looking at the possibility of adding a Literature chair. Our area committees are very active and work closely with their district counterparts to achieve greater participation and unity!— *Carolyn Hammond*

Kentucky: Area 26 includes the state of Kentucky, 4 counties in Southern Indiana and Metropolis, Illinois. We have 31 active districts and approximately 630 registered groups. Our area meetings are held quarterly. Presently we have eight standing committees (one a newsletter committee), and six intergroups. Our "primary purpose" this year is to inform our D.C.M.s and G.S.R.s about the benefits of service and the advantages of having functioning standing committees. Several of our committees have had very little support over the past few years and we are hoping that workshops will generate more participation. Our hope is to have a G.S.R. from every district on every committee. Area 26 is alive and well and growing and we hope to keep it that way.— *Gen Greiwe*

Maine: Area 28 also encompasses a portion of New Brunswick, Canada. We have roughly 450 reported groups with an active membership of over 7,000. Our one central office is located in Portland which also acts as the depository of our archives. An 800 number hotline is active statewide and utilized by many districts. In nonelection years we hold two service assemblies; in election years the fall session is dedicated primarily to selecting a new slate of officers. Usually five to six area committee meetings are scheduled as well as Pre-Conference and Post-Conference Forums to allow the delegate to be provided with a group conscience on Conference agenda items prior to attending and to report back actions of the Conference. We have our annual three-day Roundup/Convention about the middle of July which in recent years has been usually held at Sugarloaf Ski Resort high in Maine's western mountains. We boast attendees from all over the Fellowship.— *Ted Sturtevant*

Manitoba: Work is progressing on carrying the message to remote (fly-in) communities in the northern part of our province. Sister groups in the south have been maintaining telephone contact with these remote groups, finding out what is needed and bringing the information to our assemblies. Some literature donations from groups have been sent to the remote areas. An ad-hoc committee has formed under P.I./C.P.C. to pursue ways of carrying the message to aboriginal peoples, both in remote areas and the more populated south. Literature is a problem as there are seven aboriginal tongues in our area, and each has several dialects. One member has translated the Big Book onto cassette tape in the Sauiteaux language. Information has been sent out to aboriginal counselors and there have been meetings with them. The first aboriginal conference will be held in Winnipeg in May. We have also prepared a brief outline of our area general service structure and would be interested in similar outlines from other areas.— *Jack Shaver*

Maryland: Area 29 has 47 districts with 867 registered groups, and between 13,000 and 14,000 A.A. members. The area committee meets four times annually while the area assembly meets on five occasions. Our standing committees are Archives, C.P.C., Corrections, Finance, Grapevine, Literature, Registrar, Treatment, and Workshops. Ad-hoc committees are developed when necessary to insure that vital services are accomplished.

An ad-hoc committee is working on preparations for hosting the Northeast Regional Alcoholics Anonymous Service Assembly (N.E.R.A.A.S.A.) in February 1997. Every August, we have our Weekend Assembly with workshops geared to the D.C.M.s., G.S.R.s, intergroups, and others interested in getting involved in the service structure. The biggest challenges for the area remain to acquire the group conscience through effective communication and participation, combined with the practice of our Seventh Tradition.— *Arnold Ross*

Massachusetts (Western): Area 31 consists of 260 registered groups and 370 meetings each week, not including treatment and correctional facilities. We have 10 listed Spanish-speaking meetings. We have appointed a permanent archivist and have instituted the use of Local Committee Members (L.C.Ms). We have two active intergroup offices. Our State Convention is a combined effort with Area 30 (Eastern Mass), which has had a positive effect in uniting our areas in Fellowship. Our area committees definitely live up to Conference theme, "Preserving Our Fellowship—Our Challenge." Hosting the 1995 Northeast Regional Forum was a great success, well attended and all enjoyed themselves and walked away with a different perspective of general service and A.A. service in general.— *Jack Blume*

Michigan (Western): Area 34 is the approximately western half of Michigan and the eastern tip of the upper peninsula, and is comprised of 443 groups in 16 districts. The assembly rotates throughout the area on a monthly basis. P.I./C.P.C., Corrections, Treatment, Directories, Grapevine, Archives, and Special Needs committees report each month. The area takes its inventory in the nonelection year. We sponsor a yearly service workshop, and participate in a statewide service workshop. Area 34 sent four new people to their first East Central Regional Forum. We meet quarterly with Michigan's Areas 32 and 33 in the spirit of unity and cooperation to share on how to better carry the A.A. message of recovery from alcoholism. — *Jim Waldron*

Minnesota (Northern): Area 35 has 535 groups divided into 19 districts, divided into 4 zones. Each year we have two area assemblies, an area service workshop and four area committee meetings. We have six committees: P.I., C.P.C., Corrections, Treatment, Literature and Grapevine. In addition, Area 35 has a *Northern Light* newsletter editor, a records secretary, an archivist and an archives committee. We cooperate with the other areas in the West Central Region in an annual Regional Service Conference and participate actively in the biannual West Central Regional Forum. Our groups participate in district activities and our districts participate in area activities, insuring that group conscience continues to be the guide. There is a very strong commitment to sponsorship in Area 35.— *William Perrizo*

Mississippi: We have 24 districts with approximately 200 registered groups, and hold four service assemblies a year. In August 1996 we are honored to be hosting the 52nd S.E. Conference in conjunction with the 50th Mississippi Area Convention. The theme is "Our Key to Unity—the Twelve Traditions." Area 37 is service oriented with service committees on P.I., C.P.C., Corrections, Treatment, Literature, Archives and Grapevine. All committees have area-wide structures. On the coast and in Jackson we have active intergroups, supporting the surrounding locations with Twelfth Steps and informational phone service. They also carry a full line of A.A. literature as a service to surrounding groups.— *Gary Miller*

Montana: The 300 groups divided into 16 districts of Area 40 continue to grow in terms of accomplishing our primary purpose. We have eight committees: Archives, C.P.C., Corrections,

Finance, Grapevine, Literature, P.I. and Treatment. Preserving our Fellowship is a challenge we take seriously in our area. Another challenge is our large geographical territory combined with relatively small population figures. With approximately 4,400 members spread across 146,000 square miles, preserving our Fellowship at the district level has been difficult in some parts of Montana. We continue to employ the timeless technique of one alcoholic talking to another as area committee members and others make visits to groups of all sizes throughout the area. Just as the West was built through a spirit of cooperation and a sense of common welfare, we remain ever mindful of Unity.— *Robbie Sullivan*

Nebraska: Our area has 708 registered groups meeting every week in 30 districts. We hold four area committee meetings a year and one Area Reunion. Actual assemblies are held in alternate years. Roundups and jamborees are also very popular in Area 41. We have two central offices and quite a few central committees and intergroups. Our state has quite a few prisons and regional centers, or state hospitals, so our members are kept quite busy carrying the message to institutions. We have a permanent archives (with an archivist) in Omaha and a traveling archives for special events. We have active Literature, C.P.C./P.I., and Treatment committees as well. Service is carried to our entire state by a system of Four Corners Workshops held at various locations.— *Mark Richwine*

New Brunswick/Prince Edward Island: Area 81 has 13 districts, four in Prince Edward Island and nine in New Brunswick. We have workshops in January and June, and an area officer meeting preceding the spring and fall assemblies. The assemblies are a joint effort of district roundups which are bid for at least six months in advance. This affords each district the opportunity to host area functions and allows for greater participation of service people and unsuspecting future trusted servants. New Brunswick is officially a bilingual Province with some districts predominately French-speaking and the cost of French literature at affordable prices has been an ongoing concern. Although we are comparatively small in numbers, we are big in enthusiasm, and participation at the area level continues to demonstrate it is through service that the greatest rewards are to be found.— *Rikki Schock*

New Hampshire: Our area has 15 districts serving 567 groups. Over half of the approximately 675 weekly meetings are held in four main population centers; the rest are held in rural towns and mountain villages, many with only one meeting per week. Mountainous terrain and cold winter weather often makes travel to the area meetings difficult. Despite these geographical restrictions all districts have active D.C.M.s who attend our monthly area committee meetings. One of our goals is to increase the interest of G.S.R.s. Our area assembly office functions also as a statewide central office, selling literature and serving as a conduit for A.A. group information. Our P.I./C.P.C. and Corrections committees are actively working to reach the hand of A.A. further into the community. The Archives committee is continuing to record the stories of oldtimers, and the Literature/Grapevine committee folks are preparing displays for our 31st State Convention. A.A. in New Hampshire is doing its part to help preserve the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous.— *Anne Righton Malone*

New Jersey (Southern): Area 45 has almost 600 groups holding almost 2,000 meetings per week. We are structured into four sections, each coordinated by a section leader or D.C.M.-at-large. These sections are subdivided into 31 districts, including one Spanish-speaking. We conduct area committee and assembly meetings on a quarterly basis, and have 12 standing committees

and three intergroups. We cooperate with Area 44 in committee commitments for statewide events such as the N. J. Medical Conference. There is great potential for service in our area as the regular population increases. We are unanimously agreed on the 50-30-10-10 financial formula. We are blessed with an active and harmonious area in which all service entities are working together toward our primary purpose. Our most recent standing committees are Seniors Helping Seniors and Young People's Committee. We instituted a Policy, Admissions, Report and Charter Committee to help guide us in accordance with our Steps, Traditions and Concepts.— *John Kane*

New Mexico: Quarterly meetings are held by all the committees at our area assembly. The site of our assembly rotates based on bids received from any district wishing to serve. Our state convention also is chosen by the same bid process. The area has purchased translating equipment, now available for the Spanish-speaking as well as Native American (or other linguistic) needs. One of our men's prisons now has meetings running simultaneously in Spanish and English. In a state that covers approximately 400 miles border to border, divided into 16 districts with 368 groups, our C.P.C., Treatment and P.I. work closely together so as not to duplicate their efforts. "Bridge the Gap" is growing by leaps and bounds—it is a wonderful way for the newer A.A. to be of service. We are always looking for newer and better ways to improve the way we carry the message. We claim "Progress" not "Perfection."— *Betty Piatt*

New York (Hudson/Mohawk/Berkshire): A.A. in the HMB Area started with the Glen Falls Original Group in 1939 and has continued to grow. At the present time, we have well over 12,000 members, 800 groups, and 1,200 weekly meetings. We have over 42 T.F. groups, with 77 meetings, 19 TFC groups, 29 meetings. We have 14 districts within 5 clusters. Over the years we have been quite successful in carrying the A.A. message, but we do have some problems and misunderstandings with A.A.'s "Singleness Of Purpose" and with the Traditions. We also need to have more members become involved in A.A.'s "Legacy of Service." We will grow through these problems. Most of our troubled meetings have improved, some of our newer members are showing an interest in service, and we feel confident that within our area, the hand or A.A. will continue to be extended to those yet to come.— *John T. Walsh*

New York (Western): We have approximately 360 registered groups in 23 districts with about 50 active in our full area assembly meeting. We have three active intergroups with one central office with paid staff and one in the planning stages. The P.I. and C.P.C. committees are quite active and have given many presentations at high schools, colleges, nurses associations and other professional groups. Our Corrections committee goes into seven area prisons and jails on a regular basis; Treatment sponsors more than a dozen speakers meetings per week. Our committees stress A.A.'s singleness of purpose and hold monthly meetings. This year our assembly will host a Service Spring Convention, district workshops and the N. Y. State Informational Workshop. The Buffalo Fall Convention will be sponsored by the Central Committee Inter Groups.— *Jack Boyle*

North Dakota: Area 52 has about 3,200 members in a total of 168 registered groups and 13 districts. Three assemblies per year are hosted by various districts and the September assembly is held in combination with our State Convention. Assemblies are well attended with all D.C.M.s and majority of G.S.R.s present. All of our districts hold monthly meetings and most have annual miniconferences. All G.S.R.s and D.C.M.s are assigned to

a committee for the duration of their terms. This gives all trusted servants a vote and encourages their participation in area affairs. G.S.R.s and D.C.M.s have stressed the importance of the Seventh Tradition to their groups and districts with a resulting rise in contributions. This action, combined with an effort to reduce expenses on the area level, has improved our financial condition considerably. Area 52 is dedicated to carrying the message and preserving our Fellowship.— *Mike Friederichs*

Ohio (Northwest)/Michigan (Southeast): Area 55 is small geographically, with approximately 300 groups. The alternate delegate also serves as the area chairman for two years, then serves as the delegate. All other area officers are elected every two years. We hold monthly assembly meetings. Only G.S.R.s can vote at the assembly. Giving a vote to the D.C.M.s and officers, and studying and following the *Service Manual*, are two of the challenges we face in our area over the next two years. We have one intergroup in our area with nine committees; there are five active general service committees. We have a Group Services committee, a Shut-in committee and a very active Archives committee. Our two other committees are C.P.C. and Grapevine. A Mini Conference is held each year in March, to communicate to the delegate the informed conscience of our area, prior to the Conference. As we abide by the Traditions, with our focus on Tradition Two, our area will certainly continue to grow in love and service to one another.— *Linda Firsdon*

Ohio (Southwest): Area 56 has 30 districts, serving over 500 groups, in 16 counties. To educate our D.C.M.s and G.S.R.s we hold discussion tables every other month. We also have an ad hoc committee working on a "jobs description" booklet so that people have a better idea of what is expected of the area's committees and of what they are volunteering for. This will include the delegate, area chairpeople, area committee chairpeople, the D.C.M. and G.S.R. Our long-range goal is to get a D.C.M. for each of our 30 districts. To do this we want to start a district meeting in inactive districts to see if we can get them active in Third Legacy Service. We are looking forward to a happy and active two years.— *Mary Heiser*

Ontario (Western): Our area has 500 groups and 23 districts, all active in area service; there are seven intergroups and 10,000 members. Our area subcommittee chairs are divided into North-East and South-West for P.I., C.P.C., Corrections, Grapevine and Treatment. It is our mission this term to make a concentrated effort to reach and support those districts that are struggling in achieving their own active subcommittees. We try to be active maintaining good communications among all branches of service. Because of good active leadership over the past years we are now blessed with an abundance of dedicated active members.— *Jim Dick*

Oregon: Area 58 includes most of Oregon, with 32 rural and urban districts and one Spanish-speaking district-at-large. At four quarterly assemblies each year our approximately 720 groups are represented by between 200 and 250 G.S.R.s. A highlight of our last assembly was our first workshop on Special Needs. Another highlight was the recent visit by our C.P.C. Exhibit in Portland, for the American Probation and Parole Association. We also had an informal panel that travelled to the districts at their request to put on a G.S.R. School. This four-hour presentation about service is aimed at the new G.S.R. or anyone interested in general service. We found this to be a very good tool that reached a lot of interested people. We are truly blessed with so many people willing to become informed about A.A. and willing to take up the challenge of preserving our Fellowship.— *Jim Jarchow*

Puerto Rico: Area 77 has 126 groups, 9 of which are English-speaking, and 8 districts. The area committee has 20 service coordinators, who meet once a month, and also holds two area assemblies during the year. An area office in Bayamon is open every weekday to service the districts and groups, organize Twelve Step calls and maintain communication with the community in general. Our groups support the office with their contributions. We ran a promotion on the new Spanish Grapevine and so far have 800 subscribers. In February we have our National Convention; this year Jim Estelle was our guest speaker. During the 1995 Thanksgiving weekend we had an International A.A. Hispanic event called "Encuentro de Nuevos y Veteranos," where members from the U.S., Central America, Spain, Canary Islands, Puerto Rico and other countries shared on the Three Legacies of Recovery, Unity and Service.— *José E. González, Jr.*

Quebec (Northwest): Area 90 has roughly 8,000 members represented by some 420 groups and 23 districts. Although the majority of our groups are French-speaking, other language groups include English, Spanish, Portuguese, and in our Native Groups, Algonquin, Cree, Mohawk, Montagnais and Inuit. There are 25 groups in correctional facilities. During the 1994 Conference a committee of five Canadian delegates was formed, which was named the Remote Community Working Service Committee. This committee was established to share the message of A.A. with the still-suffering alcoholics, mainly Natives, scattered in the James Bay Region. In July 1995 G.S.O. approved that a special forum be held in Val D'Or, Quebec, the Abitibi-Temiscamingue Region, in August 1997. Although all are invited, special invitations will be made to Native members. We hope to be able to share with them the A.A. experience. They would then be better prepared upon returning to their native villages to transmit the A.A. message. A committee has been formed for this special forum and is co-chaired by a white and Native member, as will be all subcommittees.— *Robert Pelot*

Quebec (Southwest): The southwestern area of Quebec, is the smallest geographic area of the province, yet contains the largest A.A. population of the four Quebec areas. To serve this large concentration of A.A. members, the approximately 600 groups have formed 30 districts which are grouped by language into 23 French, Six English and one Spanish district. The area has an extremely active C.P.C. committee that is working with many professional organizations. Since the merging, in 1992, of Montreal Intergroup with the area committee, we have continued to offer, through our Telephone Hotline Committee, the vital link to the still-suffering alcoholic. The area recently added a Grapevine section to our area *La Vigne*. Also we hope to actively promote and support the Spanish Grapevine with our Spanish-speaking members. The past year was a wake-up call to the challenge of the Seventh Tradition, in that for the first time in our history we were unable to meet our area expenses through our revenues. This has proved an excellent opportunity to further sensitize our groups to the essential nature of our Seventh Tradition "where money and spirituality mix."— *Bill Archer*

Rhode Island: Although Rhode island measures only about 35x60 miles, our concern for carrying the message to the sick and suffering alcoholic is evidenced by our having over 500 groups. We now have monthly area committee meetings and quarterly area assemblies. Besides the usual committees, we have eight districts. We have also recently elected an area registrar. In an attempt to foster greater participation by G.S.R.s we have revised the agenda at our area assemblies so that the first order of business is *Group Interest*. I thank all the many delegates who sent me information on how they conduct their area business.— *Ernie Bourgeois*

Saskatchewan: Area 91 has over 340 groups, in 21 districts, scattered over an area of 651,900 kilometers, with a population of 1,101,526 people. Committee chairpersons for Grapevine, Treatment, Literature, C.P.C. and P.I. volunteer from among our district committee members and area table officers. We also have an area Corrections coordinator and Archives chairperson. The Literature, Grapevine and Archives committees have displays that are set up at each assembly and are also available for group or district functions. We also have a District Development Fund, which assists districts to have past or present service members carry the message by holding workshops in those areas. Overall Alcoholics Anonymous is alive and well in Saskatchewan. We are very proud of the dedication that our own Gerry Flegel has shown as Western Canada regional trustee.— *Wendy Zaparaniuk*

South Carolina: Area 62 has 23 districts and 288 groups reported with a membership of 5,865. The area is divided into three regions and the area assembly is always held in the middle region; the State convention and other activities rotate from region to region. The assembly begins with the D.C.M. meeting followed by the committees, and the G.S.R. meeting. Area 62 is vigilant in adhering to the Traditions, and I have been able to see Tradition One in action many times. We also ask ourselves "Are we carrying the message and practicing these principles in all our affairs?"— *Robert Merritt*

South Dakota: Area 63 has 152 registered groups, in 14 districts, spread out over 76,000 square miles. We have four assemblies per year. We have six area committees. Because of the distance from east to west some of the committees have two chairpersons, one east and one west. This year each of the D.C.M.s will serve on one of the committees. One of the biggest challenges we have is carrying the message to the Native American population. Our Minority committee, working with P.I., C.P.C., and Institutions committees, has been working to meet this challenge. Our Literature committee has joined with Grapevine. Archives has been active with displays that include tapes of the 1955 20th Anniversary Convention in St. Louis. This January we took an area inventory with a moderator from outside our area, which I believe went very well.— *George Reynolds*

Tennessee: Area 64 has 519 groups and 38 districts. Our area assemblies meet four times a year. Each of the standing committees has a sharing session/meeting prior to reporting to the assembly body during the business meeting. The delegate meets with the D.C.M.s to discuss any problems they may be having and to pass along information from G.S.O., while the alternate delegate holds a G.S.R. orientation/sharing session. We maintain a state office in Murfreesboro that is also used to store Sate archives. From 1977 to the end of 1995 Area 64 has exploded from 87 groups to a grand total of 519. This is due, I believe, to a tremendous effort of our trusted servants and to the rotation of assemblies across the great state of Tennessee.— *Ralph Jones*

Texas (Northwest): Our area has 12 districts (10 are active), with G.S.R.s and D.C.M.s. Our area covers a large territory with a small population. We have over 270 registered groups with many of them being linguistic (Spanish). We have four area assemblies a year. Many of our committees have slacked off in 1995, but our Corrections and Literature committees have been very active, as well as Treatment and Newsletter committees. We are working on structuring the other committees. We had good area participation at the Southwest Regional Forum last December. Our members are able, willing, and ready to carry the message to the still-suffering alcoholic anywhere, anytime, and at any length.— *Gilberto Lucero*

Texas (Southwest): Audrey C., with only ninety days sobriety and at her first workshop, suggested the theme "To Live It—Give It" for our January Workshop. We wanted to have something centered around the Conference theme. "Preserving Our Fellowship—Our Challenge" is, actually, *my* challenge. So my personal challenge is to listen more, talk less, and pray. Our area has purchased translation equipment; this is important as we now have seven Spanish districts, 27 in all, and 442 groups. We have just appointed an ad hoc committee to consider budgets for all the area officers/committees. We have over 1,000 subscriptions for the Spanish Grapevine. Southwest Texas knows that there are other areas that love A.A. as much as we do, but we also know that there is no other area that loves A.A. more than we do.— *Tom McMullen*

Vermont: We have approximately 250 groups and hold four full area assemblies and six area committee meetings. Our convention this year picked the theme "Back to Basics." We have an active Grapevine chair and our out-going treasurer did a good job at making sure our finances were in order. My service sponsor some twenty-five years ago was Herb Morse, who was called office manager for years at the old G.S.O. when Bill W. was still alive. I'd like to pass along his message. He used to tell me: "Don't tell me how I'm doing it wrong—tell me how *we* can do it better."— *Don McGee*

Washington State East: Area 92, the first new area since 1973, includes small parts of four areas outside of Washington state, one of these being B.C. Yukon. We also include northern Idaho, a small piece of western Montana and a small piece of northeast Oregon. We decided to keep most of the existing Washington Area structure with three quarterlies and one assembly a year. That seems to have worked very well with over 40% of the registered groups coming to the assembly and 100% of the districts at all quarterlies. At our first quarterly we had 70-90 people, along with all of our 17 districts. We have approximately 400 groups in our new area. It is an honor beyond words to be allowed to be the first delegate from Washington State East Area.— *Ben Beigler*

Wisconsin (Northern)/Upper Peninsula Michigan: Area 74 serves over 600 registered groups through 22 districts. We hold two area conferences and two area assemblies. After years of struggling with the issue of a constitution and bylaws, the last assembly adopted guidelines that describe the area's service structure and its practices, screens area officer reimbursements, standing committee funding requests, and other budgetary matters. It was also empowered to investigate and report on such issues as prudent reserve and tax status, aiding in the development of an informed group conscience. Our Archives committee has begun to interview all members having 35 or more years of sobriety. This will preserve their experience, strength, and hope for future generations of alcoholics.— *Tom Canard*

Wyoming: We have 11 districts, 125 registered groups, and more than 2,000 members. We have two area assemblies; area conventions are held in May and October. Our finance committee enacted an area budget; our challenge is to adhere to this well-drafted work. All area committees are active; Grapevine and Archives have exhibits. Many districts have service workshops and area 76 for the most part is very much Big Book oriented. We have many meetings that aren't groups, which we try to encourage to become groups. Our small intimate groups are full of love and sharing. Our prayer is that we will always be united in Recovery and Service.— *Nina VanPatten*

Additional Committee Considerations That Did Not Result in Recommendations

Advisory Action 40 of the 1990 General Service Conference states: "Items discussed, but no action taken or recommendation made, as well as committee recommendations which are not adopted, be included in a separate section of the Final Conference Report." Those committee recommendations which are not adopted (less than 2/3 of the total Conference votes in favor), but which received at least a simple majority of the votes, are considered "strong suggestions" of the Conference. All items, listed by committee, are as follows:

AGENDA

- The committee reviewed the Conference Evaluation Questionnaire and forwarded to the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference some minor format changes.
- The committee asked the staff and trustees' Committee on Conference to search for ways to be sure that discussion and question time be available following presentations.
- The committee discussed the committee's conference calls and decided they should be held only on an "as needed" basis at the discretion of the chairperson of the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference.

COOPERATION WITH THE PROFESSIONAL COMMUNITY

- The committee reviewed with appreciation the Progress Report of the trustees' C.P.C. Committee Review of C.P.C. Literature and Service Material. The committee made some modifications, and suggested that these:
 - a) Be returned to the trustees' C.P.C. Committee for their follow up; and that
 - b) after considering the Conference C.P.C. Committee's suggestions, a final report of the review of C.P.C. Literature and Service Material be prepared by the trustees' Committee on C.P.C. and forwarded to the 1997 Conference Committee on C.P.C.
- The committee reviewed the C.P.C. Workbook, and requested that a typographic omission of the word "other" in the explanatory line about Tradition Three on page 10 be fixed. The line ought to read "There are no other requirements for A.A. membership."
- The committee decided that since the C.P.C. Workbook was revised only last year, they would make no further changes this year.
- Although it might add a little expense and weight to the C.P.C. Kit, the committee would like to include in the kit the items (not already included) listed on page 29 of the C.P.C. Workbook; and also add a sample of the *About A.A.* sign-up card.

When Panel 45 delegate Sandra Kelly (Central Michigan) and her husband arrived at the hotel Saturday morning they discovered they had left their carry-on bag (containing return airline tickets, camera, grandchildren's pictures, etc.) in the taxi. After making the necessary phone calls, Sandra turned it over to God. At 8:00 am the next day the cab driver showed up at the hotel with the lost luggage. Who says New York is a cold town and cab drivers are not honest?

CORRECTIONAL FACILITIES

- The committee reviewed the Correctional Facilities Workbook and requested that the trustees' Correctional Facilities Committee prepare copy on youth detention centers, women's institutions, and short-term correctional facilities for the workbook, and present it to the 1997 Conference Correctional Facilities Committee for approval.

FINANCE

- The committee discussed the need for an alternative approach to pie charts and determined it was not necessary.
- The committee discussed the agenda item, "unless literature sales or contributions, or both, increase substantially we will have to raise prices and cut discounts or reduce services." Some thought this statement threatening while others saw it as a realistic assessment in light of the steady decline of contributions. The committee discussed finances in general and the spirit of the Seventh Tradition as it related to A.A. as a whole. It also discussed the need for education within the Fellowship. Raising the level of awareness through discussion may be one of the reasons for the increase of donations in the first quarter. Education could also decrease the "them vs. us" perception as well as the feeling that everyone does it "my way." We more clearly defined an overall goal, which is not necessarily to get groups to increase donations, or even to get groups who do not contribute to finally contribute but that donations are an expression of participation and gratitude. Everyone can claim ownership to a piece of the A.A. miracle, regardless of the size of his or her donation, and no one should be embarrassed if they can't send a large amount.
- The committee discussed methods of communication within the Fellowship and realized that there are many tools available to aid in the communication/education process. Some of these are:
 - a) "They [delegates] have the job of helping their committees obtain the financial support their areas and G.S.O. need." (*The A.A. Service Manual*, p. S69)
 - b) The Quarterly Contribution Letter, sent to delegates by G.S.O., which reflects area contribution activity.
 - c) Quarterly Contribution Reports, sent by G.S.O. to the delegates, with group contribution activity.
 - d) Quarterly Contribution Letter, sent by G.S.O. to each group, reflects the group's contribution activity.
 - e) General Service Conference presentations.
 - f) General Service *Final Conference Report* to each group.
 - g) A.A.W.S. Highlights.
 - h) *Box 4-5-9*.
 - i) Regional service assemblies.
 - j) Regional Forums information that can be disseminated further to those who were not able to attend.
 - k) Invite speakers to local/regional events.
 - l) Area information packages generated by each area and an emphasis on the delegate's use of: the new services video, when available; the Inflation Chart, What's Wrong With This Picture flyer.

- The committee also felt that more detailed, fully-encompassing information should be available concerning the routine services G.S.O. provides—such as free literature, translations, new

items published, and awards received. Perhaps the delegates should approach the education of their area as a challenge to sustain the spirit of the Seventh Tradition.

GRAPEVINE

- The committee discussed returning the "About Alcoholism" section (gray pages) to the Grapevine and felt that no action was necessary. The committee saw no clear need or desire in the Fellowship for the section. Information from the alcoholism field does not promote A.A.'s primary purpose and is readily available elsewhere.
- The committee discussed several suggestions for related materials for possible production in 1998 and forwarded to the Grapevine Corporate Board for development: 1) a third volume of *Best of the Grapevine*, and 2) audio recordings by and about young people in Alcoholics Anonymous.
- The committee discussed a suggested rewording of the A.A. Preamble and felt that no change is needed.
- The committee reviewed the A.A. Grapevine Workbook and endorsed it with minor editorial changes and updating.

INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS/REGIONAL FORUMS

- The committee suggested that at the 1997 joint meeting of the Conference and trustees' Committees on International Conventions/Regional Forums there be a review of the background information that led to the 1995 Conference Policy and Admissions Advisory Action: "The Conference Committee on International Conventions continue to meet on an annual basis, discussing Regional Forums when there are no International Convention items; and that the committee be renamed Conference Committee on International Conventions/Regional Forums."
- The committee also suggested that at the 1997 joint meeting of the Conference and trustees' Committees on International Conventions/Regional Forums, a Composition, Scope and Procedure for the Conference Committee on International Conventions/Regional Forums be discussed.
- After lengthy discussion, the committee agreed that all current Convention Site Committee members participate in voting for possible site cities for the International Convention in 2005.

LITERATURE

- The committee discussed whether a story of a bisexual alcoholic be included in the pamphlet, "Do You Think You're Different?" and made no recommendations.
- In light of the fact that *Box 4-5-9* is in the process of preparing an article on the importance of sharing our experience, strength

Another Small Miracle

When Rodney Rabren left SE Texas for the Conference, his new grandson was in critical condition. "I came here to do what I could to carry the message and God did His job with my problems at home," said Rodney. When he returned to Texas his grandson was there to meet him. "When I came to A.A. I was told that if I did my job to stay sober and help others, God would take care of the rest. This is so clear to me today."

and hope with newcomers in regard to confidentiality within Alcoholics Anonymous, the committee decided to defer the decision for publication of other material in regard to confidentiality and review the question again at the 1997 General Service Conference.

- The committee considered a request for a pamphlet directed to the concerns of the nonbeliever (atheist and/or agnostic) and made no recommendations.
- The committee considered a request for feedback and further guidance on how to proceed concerning the topic of Big Book Questionnaire and Outline and decided not to proceed with a questionnaire at this time.

POLICY/ADMISSIONS

- The committee discussed the issue of floor actions and suggested that the committees responsible continue to establish the Conference agenda's order of business.
- The committee discussed requests to identify the source of agenda items and concluded that the proper procedures are already in place.
- The committee discussed the policy for Conference observers and suggested that the trustees' Committee on the Conference create a guideline letter explaining the role of an observer.
- The committee discussed the feasibility of forming a Conference Archives Committee and determined that at present a sufficient need had not been articulated. The committee further asked that any additional input from areas on this issue be forwarded to the trustees' Archives Committee for further review.
- The committee discussed the future growth of the Conference and its effect on A.A. as a whole and suggested that the trustees' Committee on the Conference furnish a report with more guidance on this issue for the Conference Policy/Admissions Committee at the 47th General Service Conference.
- The committee discussed a request from the Conference Literature Committee to approve filming in designated areas of the Conference and took no action.

PUBLIC INFORMATION

- The committee reviewed the 1996 Membership Survey Questionnaire approved by the 1995 General Service Conference and decided to make no changes.
- The committee discussed at length the proposal to remove the following questions from the 1996 Membership Survey Questionnaire: race; marital status; anything to do with drugs; and decided unanimously to take no action on this proposal. The committee recognized that there is no reference to drugs in the 1996 Membership Survey Questionnaire approved by the 1995 General Service Conference.
- The committee considered a request to undertake a complete review of public information pamphlets looking for duplication with other A.A. literature and emphasis on A.A.'s primary purpose and agreed that there was no need to undertake a complete review of public information pamphlets at this time.
- The committee deferred discussion of the A.A. Web Site as a public information tool until the 1997 General Service Conference.
- The committee reviewed the Public Information Workbook and suggested that information about "cards and signs" and "tele-

phone directories" be added to the Workbook. The committee also suggested that the following information be added to the Public Information Workbook folder: Radio and television public service announcement scripts; service piece "Suggestions for Working with Your Local Radio and Television Stations to Help Carry the Message"; and service piece "A.A. Fact Sheet."

REPORT AND CHARTER

- After reviewing the chart submitted, illustrating Third Legacy Procedure, the committee agreed that an illustration in *The A.A. Service Manual* might help people new in general service understand the procedure and suggested that diagrams of Third Legacy Procedure be prepared for consideration by the 1997 Conference Report and Charter Committee.
- The committee discussed clarifying who is eligible to vote in the "How Do We Elect the D.C.M." section of *The A.A. Service Manual* and agreed that the current information is adequate since *The A.A. Service Manual* offers some options, and districts and areas may determine the best way to conduct their elections.
- The committee considered adding a footnote to "A Resolution" on page S35 of *The A.A. Service Manual* indicating that the 1995 General Service Conference recommended that the first 164 pages of the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, the Preface, the Forewords, "The Doctor's Opinion," "Doctor Bob's Nightmare" and the Appendices remain as is and decided that no action is necessary since the Conference has historically resisted any effort to change the Big Book, with the exception of updating some of the stories.
- The committee discussed whether or not the first 164 pages of the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, should have the same rewrite status as the Steps, Traditions, and Warranties of Article XII of the Conference Charter. Since one Conference's actions are not binding on another and the Conference has historically resisted any effort to change the Big Book in any way other than updating stories, the committee saw no need for a recommendation.
- The committee considered a small, two-or three-ring-binder format for *The A.A. Service Manual* and agreed that it is not financially feasible.
- The committee considered printing *The A.A. Service Manual* every two to five years and agreed that the practice of printing *The A.A. Service Manual* annually should continue, since the Fellowship should be kept informed and savings would be negligible.
- The committee considered the need for a footnote following the Introduction in *Twelve Concepts for World Service* indicating that, with permission of A.A. World Services, other Twelve Step programs, as well as A.A. service structures in other countries, have adapted their own Twelve Concepts, rewording them in an appropriate manner to reflect their own governmental/legal requirements and service structures. It was the consensus that this matter be reviewed by the 1997 Conference Report and Charter Committee to allow time to gather additional background information with regard to which body ultimately has responsibility for granting such permission.
- The committee reviewed the action of the 1995 Conference that resulted in the inclusion in the *Final Report* of proposed floor actions that the Conference voted not to consider and agreed that it was appropriate to include that information.
- The committee asked that consideration be given to listing online groups/meetings on A.A.'s Web Site.

TREATMENT FACILITIES

- The committee reviewed and discussed the sampling survey on Treatment Facility items conducted by the chairperson and alternate chairperson of the Conference Treatment Facilities Committee, beginning with Item No. 6: Do you or your committee have any concerns that you would like to have discussed by the Conference Treatment Facilities Committee? Helpful suggestions in response to concerns were: Encouraging areas to get more districts involved in treatment facilities service work; having more treatment facilities workshops; making service calls to treatment facilities; encouraging more discussion on carrying the message into treatment facilities; emphasizing Bridging the Gap service work. *Improvement in communication is always desired, especially in the current changing treatment environment.*
- The committee discussed the future direction of the Conference Treatment Facilities Committee and referred to the 1997 Conference Treatment Facilities Committee the review of both the committee's scope and its literature to make sure that the changing landscape of treatment programs is reflected.
- The committee discussed ways to inform the Fellowship about current changes going on in the treatment field and encouraged the A.A. membership to share these changes with the Treatment Facilities desk at the General Service Office.
- The committee shared ways to get "temporary contacts" for patients at the beginning of their treatment and felt that providing "temporary contacts" or "bridging the gap" contacts should be left up to the autonomy of the Treatment Facility Committee involved. Suggestions were also made to use central/intergroup office lists, area Treatment Facilities Committee chairpersons and "bridging the gap" committees as a means for "temporary contact" service work.
- The committee considered adding material to the Treatment Facilities Workbook on making Twelfth Step calls on "wet drunks" and, although the committee recognized the importance for each of us to understand working with others, it was decided the Treatment Facilities Workbook was not the proper format for this material. The committee referred the subject of making Twelfth Step calls on "wet drunks" to the trustees' Treatment Facilities Committee for further discussion.

CONFERENCE COMMITTEE ON TRUSTEES

- No other considerations.

Committee Recommendations Which Did Not Result in Conference Advisory Actions

GRAPEVINE

- The committee recommended that the Grapevine Corporate Board and staff utilize mailing lists similar to those used by the General Service Office to disseminate information about the Grapevine.

LITERATURE

- It was recommended that the video production company be authorized to videotape a short piece of the 46th General

Service Conference session (as well as a committee meeting) for possible limited use in the video project recommended by the 45th General Service Conference, subject to proper safeguards for anonymity, with no individually identifiable faces or voices. The video project will be brought back to the General Service Conference through the trustees' Literature Committee and the 47th General Service Conference Literature Committee for Conference approval.

- It was recommended that the manuscript originally commissioned as a history book be relabeled "collected observations of Alcoholics Anonymous" and that it be placed in the Archives and made available for purchase at cost upon request after editing for anonymity and various specific concerns relating to accuracy of content and style.
- It was recommended that the "Landmarks in A.A. History" section of *A.A. Comes of Age* be returned to its original form, as published in 1957, at the next printing.

REPORT AND CHARTER

- With a clear understanding that groups listed in the directory are listed at their own request, and a directory listing does not constitute or imply approval or endorsement of any group's approach to or practice of the traditional A.A. program, the committee recommended that online A.A. groups/meetings be listed in A.A. Directories on a supplementary page at the end of the Individual Groups section under the heading "Online Groups/Meetings," and that an e-mail or equivalent URL (Universal Resource Listing) contact address be provided in place of a contact person's phone number.
- Recognizing the unique characteristics of online groups with membership in many areas throughout the U.S. and Canada and also internationally, the committee recommended that members of online groups/meetings participate in the general service structure through regular face-to-face groups meeting in one location.

Floor Actions Which Did Not Result in Conference Advisory Actions

Floor Action #1:

Propose a Conference resolution that the 46th General Service Conference recommend to the Fellowship of A.A.s of the world that the first 164 pages of the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, the Preface, the Forewords, "The Doctor's Opinion," "Doctor Bob's Nightmare" and the Appendices be unchanged without approval of three quarters of groups of the world.

Floor Action #2:

Propose a Conference recommendation that the General Service Board and its subsidiary boards, A.A. World Services Inc. and The A.A. Grapevine, Inc., initiate no litigation regarding the protection of copyrights or trademarks.

Wrong Door!

In his confusion the first day, John Kane (Southern New Jersey) walked into the ladies room by mistake and ran right into Wendy Zapaniuk (Saskatchewan). Rushing out, flustered, John said: "I haven't done that since I was drinking!" Wendy, holding her sides laughing: "That's the first time sober I've been followed into a John by a John."

The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. • Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.
COMBINED STATEMENTS OF INCOME, EXPENSES AND CHANGES IN NET ASSETS
Years Ended December 31, 1995 and 1994

	General Service Board of A.A.						
	General Fund	Reserve Fund	Capital Projects Fund	A.A. World Services, Inc.	A.A. Grapevine, Inc.	Combined 1995	Combined 1994
INCOME AND COST OF LITERATURE							
Gross Sales				\$ 9,444,548	\$2,122,036	\$11,566,584	\$11,623,022
Less: Discounts				1,015,710	37,606	1,053,316	586,386
Net Sales				8,428,838	2,084,430	10,513,268	11,036,636
Cost of Literature Distributed							
Printing				(3,566,779)	(443,960)	(4,010,739)	(3,374,661)
Royalties on books				(814,226)	-	(814,226)	(885,108)
Direct shipping and warehousing				(940,665)	(479,786)	(1,420,451)	(1,247,780)
Gross Profit from Literature				3,107,168	1,160,684	4,267,852	5,529,087
CONTRIBUTIONS - A.A. Groups and Members	\$ 3,664,861					3,664,861	3,855,445
CONVENTION INCOME (Schedule A-2)	3,701,053					3,701,053	-
INVESTMENT INCOME	2,967	\$ 555,401		6,723	79,338	644,429	629,762
Total Income	7,368,881	555,401		3,113,891	1,240,022	12,278,195	10,014,294
RECURRING OPERATING EXPENSES - OPERATING ENTITIES (Schedule A-1)	5,679,538			2,259,855	1,243,317	9,182,710	8,943,941
Change in postretirement health benefit liability (Note 5)		287,802				287,802	-
Total Recurring Operating Expenses - All Entities						9,470,512	8,943,941
SPANISH MAGAZINE PROJECT					29,500	29,500	-
DIRECT CONVENTION EXPENSES (Schedule A-2)	4,333,080					4,333,080	-
Total Operating Expenses	10,012,618	287,802		2,259,855	1,272,817	13,833,092	8,943,941
EXCESS OF INCOME (EXPENSE) FOR YEAR BEFORE CUMULATIVE EFFECT OF ACCOUNTING CHANGE	(2,643,737)	267,599		854,036	(32,795)	(1,554,897)	1,070,353
Cumulative effect of change in accounting principle - postretirement health care benefits (Note 5)	-	(1,663,529)		-	-	(1,663,529)	-
EXCESS OF INCOME (EXPENSE) FOR YEAR	(2,643,737)	(1,395,930)		854,036	(32,795)	(3,218,426)	1,070,353
NET ASSETS							
Balance, January 1	57,013	9,255,302	\$ 1,571,492	2,330,026	353,689	13,567,522	12,784,180
Decrease - depreciation on capital projects			(254,413)			(254,413)	(287,011)
			1,317,079			10,094,683	13,567,522
Intercompany donations and interfund transfers	2,643,737	(1,282,240)	-	(1,464,737)	103,240	-	-
Balance, December 31 (Exhibit B)	57,013	6,577,132	1,317,079	1,719,325	424,134	10,094,683	13,567,522

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

**The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. • Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.
SCHEDULE OF OPERATING EXPENSES BY ACTIVITY**

Years Ended December 31, 1995 and 1994

	Group Services	Fellowship Services	General Service Conference	World Service Meeting	Regional Forums	International Convention	Publishing	Grapevine	Supporting Services	1995 Total	1994 Total
Salaries	\$ 624,780	\$ 682,198	\$ 100,074		\$ 70,054	\$ 86,415	\$ 753,970	\$ 383,812	\$1,749,003	\$4,450,306	\$4,339,169
Payroll taxes	47,615	51,845	6,987		5,483	7,087	56,883	32,236	142,704	350,840	342,156
Health and group insurance	126,937	82,968	11,531		6,566	8,525	108,813	53,834	334,228	733,402	704,069
Retirement expense	46,111	50,376	6,801		5,529	6,254	55,211	25,279	137,360	332,921	293,079
Other program printing	232,704	37,166	49,008	\$ (242)	2,128		921		2,380	324,065	328,467
Mailing labor	107,736	7,365			1,103		5,057		206	121,467	110,396
Postage and express	223,123	41,205	26,728		18,250	1,477	5,736	18,149	25,830	360,498	269,615
Writers fees	37,717	1,955	4,590	1,557	80		7,712			53,611	41,696
Foreign literature assistance		141,863								141,863	134,593
Selling expenses							60,219	122,381	7,680	190,280	175,310
Professional fees									133,057	133,057	182,333
Contracted services	6,472	50,286	1,726		7,234	532	11,482	1,229	38,009	116,970	116,556
Occupancy	75,958	73,182	5,811		4,194	4,133	99,608	62,098	286,968	611,952	628,537
Telephone	21,596	14,986	2,782		1,210	1,466	17,669	10,763	56,189	126,661	122,656
Equipment maintenance	219	224					1,083		55,317	56,843	52,767
Furniture and equipment	704	32,500					7,295		26,259	66,758	93,629
Stationery and office supplies	40,145	2,534	4,331		12,252	18	5,731	23,837	72,601	161,449	165,296
Office service and expense	6,444	8,810	11,800		676	126	13,036	23,836	160,230	224,958	213,265
Travel, meals and accommodations	640	30,576	297,071		49,111	181	6,683		328,011	712,273	796,677
Bad debts									(9,361)	(9,361)	22,306
Delegate fees			(78,063)	(40)						(78,103)	(188,631)
	1,598,901	1,310,039	451,177	1,275	183,870	116,214	1,217,109	757,454	3,546,671	9,182,710	8,943,941
Allocation of supporting services to activities	881,251	722,042	248,671	703	101,342	64,053	1,042,746	485,863	(3,546,671)	-	-
Total Recurring Operating Expenses	2,480,152	2,032,081	699,848	1,978	285,212	180,267	2,259,855	1,243,317	-	9,182,710	8,943,941
Services	\$2,480,152	\$2,032,081	\$699,848	\$ 1,978	\$285,212	\$180,267				\$5,679,538	\$5,364,658
Publishing	-	-	-	-	-	-	\$2,259,855			2,259,855	2,287,781
Grapevine	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	\$1,243,317		1,243,317	1,291,502
										9,182,710	8,943,941
COMPARATIVE TOTALS - 1994	\$2,351,283	\$1,788,783	\$707,648	\$55,248	\$231,336	\$230,360	\$2,287,781	\$1,291,502		\$8,943,941	

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.

Income and Direct Expenses of 60th Anniversary Convention

San Diego, California, June 29 to July 2, 1995

INCOME

Registrations		\$ 3,655,126
Literature sales	\$120,982	
Less: Cost of books sold	<u>75,055</u>	<u>45,927</u>
Total Income (Exhibit A)		<u><u>3,701,053</u></u>

DIRECT EXPENSES

Housing Costs	340,963	
Less: Dormitory receipts	<u>202,573</u>	138,390
Convention consultants' fees and expenses		376,414
Public relations, legal and accounting fees		39,101
Stadium production		1,065,981
Entertainment		236,086
Printing, signs and supplies		308,238
Busing costs - net		614,689
Host committee expense		50,201
Registration expense		243,817
Simultaneous translation expense		107,239
Rentals (convention center, equipment, booths, etc.)		553,310
AI-Anon expense		88,865
Pre-convention travel		51,757
Transportation, subsistence and hotels		226,763
Insurance, telephone and sundry		148,844
Writedown of unsold convention books		<u>83,385</u>
Total Direct Expenses (Exhibit A)		<u><u>4,333,080</u></u>

EXCESS OF INCOME (EXPENSES)
(632,027)

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

**The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. • Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.
COMBINED BALANCE SHEETS
Years Ended December 31, 1995 and 1994**

	General Service Board of A.A.			A.A. World Services, Inc.	A.A. Grapevine, Inc.	Combined 1995	Combined 1994
	General Fund	Reserve Fund	Capital Projects Fund				
<u>ASSETS</u>							
Cash	\$ 285,249	\$ 2,500,405		\$ 361,806	\$ 90,305	\$ 3,237,765	\$ 4,054,289
Accounts and interest receivable	21,898	118,099		163,434	58,162	361,593	400,331
Intercompany balances	(259,225)	(1,563,949)		540,868	1,282,306	-	-
Inventories							
Books, pamphlets, etc.				1,378,346	203,492	1,581,838	1,166,133
Paper, pre-publication costs, etc.				43,801	115,761	159,562	120,725
Investments							
U.S. Treasury Notes, due 1996/2004, at cost (market value: 1995- \$7,760,665; 1994 - \$8,756,440)		7,473,908				7,473,908	8,971,419
Fixed Assets							
Leasehold improvements, computer hardware and software (net of accumulated depreciation - 1995 - \$1,771,701; 1994 - \$1,654,199)			\$1,317,079			1,317,079	1,571,492
Deferred charges	63,565			61,436	83,668	208,669	716,139
Other assets				20,251		20,251	20,251
Total Assets	111,487	8,528,463	1,317,079	2,569,942	1,833,694	14,360,665	17,020,779
<u>LIABILITIES</u>							
Accounts payable	\$ 54,474			\$ 622,057	\$ 121,587	\$ 798,118	\$ 728,633
Accrued royalties				182,397		182,397	207,247
Deferred income							
Orders and subscriptions				46,163	1,287,973	1,334,136	1,271,544
Advance registration fees						-	1,245,833
Accrued postretirement health benefit obligation (Note 5)		\$ 1,951,331				1,951,331	-
Total Liabilities	54,474	1,951,331	\$ -	850,617	1,409,560	4,265,982	3,453,257
Net Assets (Exhibit A)	57,013	6,577,132	1,317,079	1,719,325	424,134	10,094,683	13,567,522
Total Liabilities and Net Assets	111,487	8,528,463	1,317,079	2,569,942	1,833,694	14,360,665	17,020,779

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

**The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
 Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc.
 Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.
 Combined Statements of Cash Flows
 Years Ended December 31, 1995 and 1994**

CASH FLOWS PROVIDED (USED)

	<u>1995</u>	<u>1994</u>
FROM OPERATING ACTIVITIES:		
Excess of income (expense) for year	\$(3,218,426)	\$1,070,353
Changes in assets and liabilities:		
Accounts receivable	38,738	2,107
Inventories	(454,542)	118,021
Deferred charges and other assets	507,470	(323,695)
Accounts and accruals payable	44,635	210,647
Deferred income	(1,183,241)	1,298,053
Postretirement health benefits obligation	1,951,331	-
<u>Net Cash Flows Provided (Used)</u>		
<u>By Operating Activities</u>	<u>(2,314,035)</u>	<u>2,375,486</u>
FROM INVESTING ACTIVITIES:		
Proceeds from sales of investments	1,497,511	1,254,058
Purchases of investments	-	(1,495,625)
<u>Net Cash Flows Provided (Used)</u>		
<u>By Investing Activities</u>	<u>1,497,511</u>	<u>(241,567)</u>
Net Increase (Decrease) in Cash	(816,524)	2,133,919
Cash, beginning of year	4,054,289	1,920,370
Cash, end of year	<u>3,237,765</u>	<u>4,054,289</u>

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

Report of the Independent Auditor

AUDITOR'S OPINION

The Board of Trustees
The General Service Board of
Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
475 Riverside Drive
New York, New York 10115

February 26, 1996

Ladies and Gentlemen:

We have audited the accompanying combined balance sheets of THE GENERAL SERVICE BOARD OF ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS, INC. and its wholly owned subsidiaries, ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS WORLD SERVICES, INC. and ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS GRAPEVINE, INC., as of December 31, 1995 and 1994, and the related combined statements of income, expenses and changes in net assets and cash flows for the years then ended. These financial statements are the responsibility of the Organization's management. Our responsibility is to express an opinion on these financial statements based on our audits.

We conducted our audits in accordance with generally accepted auditing standards. Those standards require that we plan and perform the audit to obtain reasonable assurance about whether the financial statements are free of material misstatement. An audit includes examining, on a test basis, evidence supporting the amounts and disclosures in the financial statements. An audit also includes assessing the accounting principles used and significant estimates made by management, as well as evaluating the overall financial statement presentation. We believe that our audits provide a reasonable basis for our opinion.

In our opinion, the financial statements referred to above present fairly, in all material respects, the combined financial position of the three Corporations named above as of December 31, 1995 and 1994, and the combined results of their operations and cash flows for the years then ended in conformity with generally accepted accounting principles.

Respectfully submitted,

Owen J. Flanagan and Company
Certified Public Accountants

THE GENERAL SERVICE BOARD OF ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS, INC. NOTES TO COMBINED FINANCIAL STATEMENTS DECEMBER 31, 1995 AND 1994

Note 1 Organization: The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc. is a not-for-profit corporation organized for the purpose of assisting in the formation of A.A. groups and coordinating the A.A. program of rehabilitating alcoholics throughout the world. In furtherance of that objective, the Organization also publishes books, magazines, pamphlets and other material directly related to the A.A. program through two wholly owned not-for-profit corporations, A.A. World Services, Inc. and A.A. Grapevine, Inc. The activities of the General Service Board of A.A. itself are conducted in three separate funds, as follows:

The RESERVE FUND—This fund was established in 1954 for the purpose of accumulating a prudent operating reserve, which during 1977, was redefined by a special General Service Board Committee as the prior year's combined operating expenses of A.A. World Services, Inc., A.A. Grapevine, Inc. and the General Fund of the A.A. General Service Board. That committee also recommended that all investment activities of the operating entities be consolidated into the Reserve Fund. That Advisory Action was approved by the Board of Trustees and since that

time, all funds of the operating entities, in excess of those required for working capital, have been transferred to the Reserve Fund. Included in such transfers from A.A. Grapevine, Inc. have been amounts held as a deferred liability to subscribers, and, therefore, they are reflected as a liability of the Reserve Fund. Any withdrawals from the Reserve Fund must be specifically authorized by the Board of Trustees on recommendation of the Finance and Budgetary Committee.

The CAPITAL PROJECTS FUND—This fund was established in 1990 to account for the costs of leasehold improvements and computer hardware and software incurred under major capital projects, and to record annual depreciation on such assets.

The GENERAL FUND—This fund is comprised of those assets not included in any of the other funds and may be used for any purpose for which the Corporation was formed. These purposes presently include activities related to communication and information services to A.A. groups and members, public information, cooperation with the professional community and various regional, national and international meetings, conferences and conventions.

All net assets of the Corporation are free of donor restrictions.

Note 2 Accounting Policies: The Corporations use the accrual method of accounting, where income is recorded in the period earned and expenses are recorded in the period incurred and to which they pertain. Contributions are recorded as income when the cash is received.

Intercompany balances and donations have been eliminated in the combined totals in the accompanying financial statements.

Operating expenses of the General Service Office are shared between the General Service Board of A.A. and A.A. World Services under a cost allocation system applied consistently from year to year. Expenses related to service activities are charged to the General Service Board, while expenses in connection with publishing activities are allocated to A.A. World Services. Administrative and overhead costs are apportioned between the program activities they support.

Occupancy costs related to A.A. Grapevine's share of office space at the General Service Office have been allocated based on its proportionate square footage; substantially all other expenses related to magazine activities are paid and recorded directly by A.A. Grapevine under its separate accounting system.

Inventories: Inventories held by A.A. World Services, Inc. and A.A. Grapevine, Inc. are recorded at cost under the first-in, first-out, "FIFO" method of accounting. Proper allowance has been made for slow-moving or damaged merchandise. Literature distributed without charge is not accounted for separately, but is included in the cost of printing as a reduction of inventory.

Fixed Assets: The costs of major capital projects involving leasehold improvements and computer system acquisitions are capitalized and depreciated over the term of the applicable lease, or the useful life of the equipment, in the Capital Projects Fund. In accordance with consistent practice, the costs of these expenditures continue to be recorded as an expense of the General Fund, but are then capitalized and depreciated through changes in net assets in the Capital Projects Fund.

Normal recurring expenditures for furniture and equipment are considered to be immaterial and are charged to expense in the year of purchase.

The following table sets forth, by classification of assets, the depreciation lives, the provision for depreciation for the year ended December 31, 1995 and the accumulated reserves for depreciation at that date:

	Life	Cost	Current Year	Reserve
Leasehold improvements	Terms of			
475 Riverside Drive	Leases	\$1,625,457	\$ 171,101	\$ 641,628
Furniture	8 Years	689,598	83,312	356,348
Computer—hardware	5 Years	502,054		502,054
—software	5 Years	271,671		271,671
		<u>3,088,780</u>	<u>254,413</u>	<u>1,771,701</u>

All depreciation is provided on the straight line basis.

Investments: Investments held by the Reserve Fund of the General Service Board of A.A. are carried at cost. No recognition is made in the accounts for any changes in aggregate market value above or below cost because all of the investments are U.S. Treasury Notes with short or medium terms that are normally held to maturity.

Management Estimates: The management of the Corporations uses estimates and assumptions in preparing financial statements in accordance with generally accepted accounting principles. These estimates and assumptions affect the reported amounts of assets, liabilities, revenues and expenses. Actual results could vary from the estimates that management uses.

As described in Note 5 of this report, management made certain significant estimates in the calculation of liabilities for postretirement health benefits. These estimates include employee retention, health care cost trends and the actuarial lives of present and projected retirees eligible for benefits. It is reasonably possible that a change in these estimates will occur in the near term. The effect of changes in these estimates can not be determined.

Note 3 Retirement Plan: The Organizations sponsor a defined benefit pension plan effective to provide retirement benefits to eligible employees. The report of the plan's actuaries stated that as of January 1, 1995, the most recent valuation date to these financial statements for which information is available, the present value of accrued benefits under the plan was \$4,746,018, of which \$4,451,607 was vested. The market value of the assets of the trust fund at the same date was \$7,562,323. The assumed rate of return used in determining the actuarial value of vested plan benefits was 7.5%.

Pension expense has been consistently reported as the contribution made to actuarially fund plan benefits. That method of accounting was in accordance with generally accepted accounting principles that had been in effect since the issuance of Accounting Principles Board Statement No. 8 in 1966.

Effective as of 1987, however, Financial Accounting Standards Board (FASB) Statement No. 87 introduced a new concept of "net periodic pension cost," in which pension cost would be accrued ratably over an employee's years of service based upon actuarial factors which would not necessarily be the same as those presently used in calculating the annual funding requirement. In addition, FASB No. 87 would require, on a deferred recognition basis, an employer to report an asset or liability on the organization's balance sheet depending upon whether the plan was considered to be over- or under-funded. It is clear from the above actuarial data that there is no unfunded liability in the A.A. Retirement Plan. Management still believes the annual funding requirement is a more relevant measure of pension expense, and that the cost of additional actuarial calculations is not warranted. The difference would not be a material amount.

Pension expense for 1995 and 1994 was \$332,921 and \$293,079, respectively.

Note 4 Lease Commitments: At December 31, 1995, A.A. World Services, Inc., as fiscal agent for the General Service

Office, was subject to the following non-cancellable leases (exclusive of future operating increases) in New York City:

\$347,275 yearly office rental lease at 475 Riverside Drive effective July 1, 1995 through September 30, 2001.

\$121,116 yearly office rental lease at 475 Riverside Drive effective June 1, 1995 through September 30, 2001.

The minimum lease commitment at December 31, 1995 is \$2,739,000.

The rental expenses for the years ended December 31, 1995 and 1994, were as follows:

	1995	1994
Total Rent Expense	<u>\$567,200</u>	<u>\$592,100</u>
Allocated to:		
A.A. World Services	\$144,000	\$150,900
General Service Board	338,100	352,400
A.A. Grapevine	<u>85,100</u>	<u>88,800</u>
	<u>\$567,200</u>	<u>\$592,100</u>

Note 5 Postretirement Health Benefits: The Corporations provide health care benefits for retired employees, substantially all of whom become eligible if they attain retirement age while working at the General Service Office. Benefits are provided through health insurance contracts maintained by the Corporations, 25% of the cost of which is borne by the retirees.

Prior to 1995, the net cost for retiree health insurance were expensed as paid. Effective January 1, 1995, however, the Corporations adopted FASB Statement No. 106. The Statement requires employers to accrue a liability for the present value of the projected future costs of health care benefits over an employee's years of service.

The plan is unfunded. The assumed health care cost trend rate used to measure the expected cost of benefits covered by the plan is 5%. A discount rate of 7.5% has been used to measure the accrued postretirement health benefit obligation shown on Exhibit B. The following table sets forth the reconciliation of the plan's liability for 1995:

Liability - beginning of year	\$1,663,529
Service cost	\$234,542
Interest cost (at 7.5% discount rate)	<u>124,765</u>
	359,307
Benefit payments	<u>(71,505)</u>
Net change	287,802
Liability - end of year	<u>1,951,331</u>

An increase of 1% in the assumed health care cost trend rate from 5% to 6% would increase the liability at the beginning of the year by \$235,016 and the aggregate service and interest costs for 1995 by \$36,305, so that the liability at December 31, 1996 would be \$271,321 higher, or \$2,222,652.

The postretirement health benefit obligation at January 1, 1995 has been recorded by the Reserve Fund, as has the change to that liability during 1995. The assumption of this liability by the Reserve Fund was necessary because the operating entities are only permitted to retain enough net assets to satisfy current working capital requirements, and the postretirement health benefit obligation reflects long term costs that

Note 6 Tax Status: The Organizations are exempt from Federal income taxes under section 501(c) (3) of the Internal Revenue Code. They are also exempt from the New York State Franchise Tax.

Budget Highlights

1996 G.S.O. Budget

This budget describes the "OPERATIONS" of the General Service Office. It excludes any activities reported separately in the Reserve Fund or the Capital Projects Fund.

Income: The 1996 sales budget of \$9,384,000 is essentially flat when compared with the actual results for 1995 of \$9,445,000 and the 1995 budget of \$9,336,000.

Discounts allowed on sales for 1996 has been budgeted at \$756,000 approximately \$260,000 less than those taken in 1995 and \$230,000 less than budgeted for 1995. The 1996 budget has been prepared with adjustments in the discounts effective August 1, 1996. The overall bottom line discount of 5% will be discontinued and the 30% discounts allowed on miscellaneous and other items will be reinstated to 20%. When these additional discounts were implemented, in the Fall of 1994, it was for the primary purpose of reducing the Reserve Fund below its ceiling, using a method (discounts) to allow for greater distribution of items throughout the Fellowship to help carry the message.

Manufacturing costs are budgeted relatively flat. While there may be some increases in costs on certain items, we are expecting a reduction in the cost of several of our major publications that had risen with the large increase in paper prices from late 1994 through late 1995. A 5% increase has been budgeted for shipping and warehousing costs, anticipating increases in postage and freight.

Gross profit from literature, is budgeted at approximately \$3,276,000 or 5.4% increase over 1995. This is due primarily to the easing of the discounts allowed.

Contributions for 1996 have been budgeted at \$3,737,000, approximately 2% higher than 1995.

Total Revenue for the period after interest income from operations is anticipated at \$7,015,200, approximately 3.4% higher than 1995 total revenue of \$6,781,700.

Total Operating Expenses for 1996 have been budgeted at \$8,264,400, approximately 4% above the 1995 operating level. Included in the overall 4% increases are some nonrecurring type costs for such items as the Twelve and Twelve ASL Project, the Service Video, upgrades to the records/files systems for CD ROM storage technology, as well as the net cost to G.S.O. of the World Service Meeting. These costs aggregate approximately \$194,000. Excluding these items, operating expense increased approximately 1.6%.

An operating loss of \$1,249,000 is budgeted prior to the drawdown from the Reserve Fund. This drawdown allows for an orderly, prudent use of the Reserve Fund at a time when the Reserve Fund is near its upper limit.

1996 Grapevine Budget

The 1996 Budget was prepared with an increase in subscription prices of 25 percent, effective April 1, 1996 (the May issue).

Circulation is budgeted at an average of 130,000. The price increase of April 1, 1996 would normally decrease circulation by about 10 percent; however, in 1995 we have experienced a continuous pattern of growth and do not expect a decline in 1996, rather the decline may materialize in 1997 as renewals come due.

Income: Magazine income of \$1,623,000 is 6.1% higher than the \$1,528,800 in 1995, due to the increased circulation and the price increase. Other publishing income from books, cassette tapes and miscellaneous items, is budgeted at \$544,800, or 2% lower than 1995. This is due to an aging product line and the fact that we have no new items budgeted for 1996.

Direct Costs: Magazine direct costs are budgeted at 48.4% of income, as compared to 45.7% of income in 1995.

Total Gross Profit: Combining the magazine and other publishing items the gross profit of \$1,152,400 is 53.1% of budgeted income as compared to \$1,160,700 or 55.7% in 1995.

Total Operating Expenses: Changes in corporate structure and the need to reprint all price lists, catalogs, and flyers resulted in a net budget increase of 6.7%, or \$83,500.

Net Income: For 1996 net income is budgeted as a \$93,100 loss, as compared to a \$3,300 loss in 1995. The full impact of the price increase will not be realized in 1996, as there are over 1,250,000 copies of the magazine that were paid for before the price increase became effective.

1996 Spanish Grapevine Budget

Following the 1995 General Service Conference Advisory Action #7, the publication of the Grapevine magazine in Spanish was approved by the Grapevine Board of Directors and the trustees' Finance Committee of the General Service Board. Recognizing this publication as a new venture, both boards will review the financial impact on the Fellowship and the progress of circulation and continue to monitor the viability of this venture.

The magazine will be bimonthly and is budgeted to begin in July/August. Circulation is budgeted at 6,000 copies for a total sale of 18,000 copies in 1996.

Income of \$22,500 less direct costs to produce and distribute of \$15,500, leaves a gross profit of \$7,000, or 31%. Operating expenses of \$103,000 include the salary and benefits of a Spanish editor, printing of order forms and the purchase of circulation and desktop publishing equipment. This leaves a net loss of \$96,000 for the year.

The General Service Office 1996 OPERATING BUDGET

INCOME	1995 Actual	1996 Budget
GROSS SALES	\$ 9,444,548	\$ 9,384,222
Discounts allowed	1,015,710	756,000
<u>Net Sales</u>	<u>8,428,838</u>	<u>8,628,222</u>
Cost of Literature Distributed		
Manufacturing	3,566,779	3,560,873
Royalties	814,226	806,316
<u>Gross Margin</u>	<u>4,047,833</u>	<u>4,261,033</u>
DIRECT SHIPPING AND WAREHOUSING	940,665	984,799
<u>Gross Profit from Literature</u>	<u>3,107,168</u>	<u>3,276,234</u>
Contributions Received	3,664,861	3,737,000
Interest Income	9,690	2,000
<u>Total Revenue</u>	<u>6,781,719</u>	<u>7,015,234</u>
 OPERATING EXPENSES		
Salaries	3,797,295	3,875,000
Payroll taxes	292,792	300,000
Insurance	635,043	648,200
Retirement expense	290,410	312,000
Other program printing	324,065	333,110
Mailing, labor, etc.	121,468	131,900
Postage & express	342,349	357,359
Writers' fees	53,611	135,225
Other literature assistance	141,863	146,500
Selling expenses	67,900	58,500
Professional fees	109,652	103,500
Contracted services	111,746	128,700
Occupancy	524,489	522,500
Telephone	111,502	122,550
Furniture & equipment maintenance	56,842	52,050
Furniture & equipment	63,789	81,000
Stationery & office supplies	137,612	143,850
Office service & expense	177,363	178,400
Travel, meals, & accommodations	592,737	619,050
Bad debts	(13,135)	15,000
TOTAL OPERATING EXPENSES	<u>7,939,393</u>	<u>8,264,394</u>
Income (loss) for period	(1,157,674)	(1,249,160)
Drawdown from Reserve Fund	1,157,674	1,249,160
Net income (loss) for period	<u>— 0 —</u>	<u>— 0 —</u>

The Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.

1996 BUDGET

	1995 Actual	1996 Budget	Spanish Grapevine	
			1995 Actual	1996 Budget
PAID CIRCULATION—AVERAGE	<u>126,434</u>	<u>130,000</u>	<u>— 0 —</u>	<u>18,000</u>
INCOME FROM MAGAZINE				
Subscription income	\$ 1,522,232	\$ 1,614,400	\$	\$
Single copies and back issues	<u>6,617</u>	<u>8,625</u>		<u>15,500</u>
<u>Total magazine income</u>	<u>1,528,849</u>	<u>1,623,025</u>		<u>22,500</u>
<u>Total direct costs</u>	<u>698,877</u>	<u>785,275</u>		<u>15,500</u>
GROSS PROFIT ON MAGAZINE	829,972	837,750	— 0 —	7,000
OTHER PUBLISHING INCOME	555,581	544,805		
<u>Total direct costs</u>	<u>224,869</u>	<u>230,150</u>		
GROSS PROFIT ON SPECIAL ITEMS	330,712	314,655		
<u>TOTAL GROSS PROFIT</u>	<u>1,160,684</u>	<u>1,152,405</u>		
COSTS AND EXPENSES				
EDITORIAL COSTS				
Salaries, including temporary help	186,135	150,930		26,000
Payroll taxes and benefits	47,935	46,025		4,000
Occupancy costs	51,311	53,950		
Office supplies and expenses	16,200	16,100		1,000
Product development	<u>1,229</u>	<u>13,000</u>		
<u>Total Editorial</u>	<u>302,810</u>	<u>280,005</u>		<u>31,000</u>
CIRCULATION AND BUSINESS				
Salaries, including temporary help	466,876	495,000		
Payroll taxes and benefits	150,983	165,211		
Occupancy costs	51,311	53,950		
Office expense	31,473	31,100		
Subscriber services	8,423	14,000		
Selling expense — regular	89,170	126,200	29,500	50,000
— GvR program	24,788	27,800		
Postage	<u>18,149</u>	<u>22,750</u>		<u>10,000</u>
<u>Total Circulation and Business</u>	<u>841,173</u>	<u>936,011</u>	<u>29,500</u>	<u>60,000</u>
GENERAL AND ADMINISTRATIVE				
Consultant fees	3,996	4,000		
Insurance	5,434	5,750		
Professional fees	23,405	24,100		
Meetings and conferences	41,632	42,900		
Furniture and equipment	2,969	9,200		
Canadian exchange and other	<u>21,898</u>	<u>24,900</u>	<u>— 0 —</u>	<u>12,000</u>
<u>Total General and Administrative</u>	<u>99,334</u>	<u>110,850</u>	<u>29,500</u>	<u>12,000</u>
TOTAL COSTS AND EXPENSES	<u>1,243,317</u>	<u>1,326,866</u>	<u>29,500</u>	<u>103,000</u>
INCOME (LOSS) FROM OPERATIONS	<u>(82,633)</u>	<u>(174,461)</u>		
Add: Interest earned	<u>79,338</u>	<u>81,400</u>		
NET INCOME (LOSS) FOR PERIOD	<u>(3,295)</u>	<u>(93,061)</u>	<u>(29,500)</u>	<u>(\$ 96,000)</u>

() denotes red figures

1995 Contributions From Groups — by Delegate Area

(in U.S. dollars)

AREA #	GENERAL SERVICE CONFERENCE AREA	#GPS. RE-PORTED	#GPS. CONTRIB.	% OF GPS. CONTRIB.	TOTAL GROUP CONTRIB.	MEMBER-SHIP	CONTRIB. PER CAPITA	AREA #	GENERAL SERVICE CONFERENCE AREA	#GPS. RE-PORTED	#GPS. CONTRIB.	% OF GPS. CONTRIB.	TOTAL GROUP CONTRIB.	MEMBER-SHIP	CONTRIB. PER CAPITA
1	Ala./N.W.Fla	414	205	49.5%	\$26,826.36	7,828	\$3.43	59	Pennsylvania	1,408	745	52.9	111,882.82	33,637	3.32
2	Alaska	245	84	34.2	8,191.64	3,760	2.17	60	East	752	359	47.7	36,755.78	11,099	3.31
3	Arizona	816	343	42.0	57,843.18	16,556	3.49	61	West	244	101	41.3	11,294.74	5,694	1.98
4	Arkansas	233	104	44.6	11,320.35	3,916	2.89	62	Rhode Island	299	183	61.2	28,973.43	6,123	4.73
5	California							63	South Carolina	159	54	33.9	4,881.02	3,513	1.38
6	Southern	1,931	701	36.3	96,210.19	63,356	1.51	64	South Dakota	488	211	43.2	35,721.77	9,813	3.64
7	N. Coastal	1,967	1,009	51.2	158,773.84	62,078	2.55	65	Tennessee	431	191	44.3	49,149.65	16,791	2.92
8	N. Interior	674	324	48.0	40,305.70	19,101	2.11	66	Texas	231	85	36.7	11,895.28	6,082	1.95
9	San Diego/Imp.	836	336	40.1	50,348.79	25,824	1.94	67	Northeast	526	246	46.7	35,744.53	16,847	2.12
10	Mid-South	1,741	709	40.7	84,916.09	54,127	1.56	68	Northwest	441	176	39.9	32,383.62	10,240	3.16
11	Colorado	616	351	56.9	49,822.22	15,911	3.13	69	Southwest	278	151	54.3	23,726.84	5,009	4.73
12	Connecticut	1,362	544	39.9	60,508.05	33,014	1.83	70	Utah	230	108	46.9	10,516.42	4,524	2.32
13	Delaware	196	110	56.1	19,349.27	3,206	6.03	71	Vermont	1,153	639	55.4	77,206.45	22,483	3.43
14	D.C.	449	214	47.6	38,994.67	14,799	2.63	72	Virginia	1,428	622	43.5	91,975.34	28,917	3.18
15	Florida							73	West Virginia	301	118	39.2	8,779.24	3,494	2.51
16	North	627	355	56.6	55,507.59	14,295	3.88	74	Wisconsin	619	261	42.1	19,487.18	9,941	1.96
17	South/Bahamas/ V.I.	1,497	776	51.8	118,465.58	30,688	3.86	75	N. Wis/Upper Pen. Mich.	913	427	46.7	43,050.90	17,803	2.41
18	Georgia	684	478	69.8	64,172.79	18,922	3.79	76	South	114	59	51.7	5,232.20	1,987	2.63
19	Hawaii	263	156	59.3	24,085.51	5,370	4.48	77	Wyoming	138	70	50.7	4,823.18	1,749	2.75
20	Idaho	195	100	51.2	8,779.75	3,051	2.87	78	Puerto Rico	592	234	39.5	25,535.24	7,980	3.19
21	Illinois							79	Alberta/N.W.T.	738	376	50.9	51,365.40	13,520	3.79
22	Chicago	1,161	317	27.3	44,168.02	27,120	1.62	80	B.C./Yukon	150	60	40.0	6,431.84	4,149	1.55
23	North	1,022	361	35.3	32,816.09	21,462	1.52	81	Manitoba	220	95	43.1	8,866.34	3,537	1.94
24	South	462	192	41.5	21,437.53	7,687	2.78	82	N.B./P.E.I.	264	110	41.6	9,439.00	3,630	2.22
25	Indiana							83	N.S./Nfld./Lab. Ontario	606	249	41.0	33,932.15	14,489	2.34
26	North	658	275	41.7	29,376.72	10,521	2.79	84	East	170	64	37.6	7,808.82	2,259	3.45
27	South	539	276	51.2	29,593.93	10,661	2.77	85	Northeast	92	16	17.3	2,178.02	1,511	1.44
28	Iowa	635	290	45.6	31,891.47	13,398	2.38	86	Northwest	507	187	36.8	27,985.16	10,033	2.78
29	Kansas	376	191	50.7	24,853.64	9,569	2.59	87	Quebec ¹	603	295	48.9	15,242.53	15,569	0.98
30	Kentucky	641	334	52.1	50,293.15	11,159	4.50	88	Southwest	232	139	60.0	8,359.39	3,306	2.52
31	Louisiana	548	204	37.2	28,047.44	10,833	2.58	89	Southeast	366	344	94.0	9,163.37	6,935	1.31
32	Maine	464	148	31.8	13,141.38	7,855	1.67	90	Northwest	406	357	87.9	22,027.82	8,095	2.71
33	Maryland	887	377	42.5	49,748.24	13,934	3.57	91	Saskatchewan	331	137	41.3	10,666.88	4,220	2.52
34	Massachusetts								Total U.S./Canada	55,930	24,865	44.5	\$3,220,355.88	1,251,192	\$2.57
35	East	1,525	587	38.4	70,929.07	52,292	1.35		Individual, in memoriam, & special meetings				189,797.37		
36	West	248	116	46.7	14,636.43	5,322	2.75		Specials				225,845.34		
37	Michigan								Total for U.S. & Canada				\$3,635,998.59		
38	Central	563	210	37.3	32,332.66	12,842	2.51		FOREIGN AND OTHER						
39	Southeast	647	267	41.2	52,046.13	16,815	3.09		Birds of a Feather				267.00		
40	West	438	185	42.2	27,455.64	9,403	2.91		Correctional facility groups				1,040.39		
41	Minnesota								Foreign				26,381.42		
42	North	531	233	43.8	17,896.53	8,198	2.18		Internationalists				100.00		
43	South	1,003	400	39.8	48,688.97	21,865	2.22		Loners				974.00		
44	Mississippi	232	106	45.6	12,483.03	4,029	3.09		Treatment facility meetings				80.00		
45	Missouri								World Hello				20.00		
46	East	558	279	50.0	37,603.24	8,643	4.35		Grand Total				\$3,664,861.40		
47	West	207	103	49.7	12,604.00	6,164	2.04								
48	Montana	309	123	39.8	14,812.41	4,594	3.22								
49	Nebraska	707	356	50.3	45,188.80	15,193	2.97								
50	Nevada	371	157	42.3	15,060.22	8,258	1.82								
51	New Hampshire	551	207	37.5	19,983.55	9,019	2.21								
52	New Jersey														
53	North	1,273	447	35.1	61,350.95	31,684	1.93								
54	South	473	251	53.0	40,487.27	8,807	4.59								
55	New Mexico	358	160	44.6	17,467.16	5,885	2.96								
56	New York														
57	Central	706	267	37.8	38,064.11	11,063	3.44								
58	H.M./B.	770	271	35.1	24,419.07	11,719	2.08								
59	Southeast	1,816	776	42.7	154,507.46	56,132	2.75								
60	West	310	99	31.9	9,981.36	5,691	1.75								
61	North Carolina	830	446	53.7	74,298.82	12,989	5.72								
62	North Dakota	170	80	47.0	9,612.90	3,325	2.89								
63	Ohio														
64	Cent. & S.E.	602	175	29.0	16,415.67	8,620	1.90								
65	Northeast	1,231	304	24.6	33,758.70	24,496	1.37								
66	N.W. Ohio/ S.E. Mich.	281	118	41.9	11,105.48	3,841	2.89								
67	S.W. Ohio	534	218	40.8	27,075.83	10,680	2.53								
68	Oklahoma	381	240	62.9	30,598.25	6,503	4.70								
69	Oregon	730	353	48.3	40,492.31	14,096	2.87								

¹ Reflects not only those groups that contributed directly to G.S.O., but also those groups that contributed to G.S.O. through their Conference areas (per lists of percentages submitted by areas).

² Group contributions reported on this schedule do not include contributions received as special, individual, in-memoriam, and special meetings.

1996 Conference Committees

Conference Agenda

Jeannot Bouchard
 Larry Cassady
 Mike Friederichs
 Thomas Gore
 Charlotte Ingalls
²George O'Neil
¹Rodney Rabren
 Wendy Zaporaniuk

Secretary: Richard Bush

Finance

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 Jack Boyle
 Linda Fredricks
¹JoAnne Frey
 John Goldberg
 Gen Greiwe
 James Jarchow
 Bill Perrizo

Secretary: Donald Meurer

Literature

²Charles Bartell
 Joe Burnes
 José González
 Carolyn Hammond
 John Kane
 Phyllis McCoy
 Robert Pelot
 Ann Santen
¹Paul Sherman

Secretary: Pat Rosenstiel

Report and Charter

Bill Archer
 Mary Bridges
 Bob Merritt
¹Robert Reynolds
 Arnold Ross
 Jack Sanderson
²Bob Simmons
 Lona Wright-Parker

Secretary: Lois Fisher

Cooperation With the Professional Community

Ernest Bourgeois
 Linda Firsdon
¹Diana Habbe
 Aime Imbeault
 Doug Mead
 George Reynolds
²Jim Tims
 Bob Watt

Secretary: Eileen Gatz

Grapevine

Bob Cordero
 Jim Dick
 Jeanne Ertmann
 Matt Hartman
²Jim Madger
 Gary Miller
 Betty Piatt
¹Clifford Riggins
 John Walsh

Secretary: Ann Warner

Policy/Admissions

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²Dan Eberlein
 Thomas McMullen
¹Ernie Mills
 Bert Mitchell
 J.P. Paynter
 Nina VanPatten
 Karen Williams

Secretary: John Grant

Treatment Facilities

Ben Beigler
 Tom Finn
 Clark Fisher
²Pam Reising
 Michael Smith
 Ted Sturtevant
 Roberta Sullivan
¹Anton Taschner

Secretary: Susan Ulseth

Correctional Facilities

Gilberto Lucero
 Anne Malone
²Alex Palmer
¹Eva Sanchez
 William Schmertz
 James Waldron
 Ed Wolf
 Joycie Wren

Secretary: Sarah Price

International Conventions/ A.A. Regional Forums

Jeannot Bouchard
 Larry Cassady
 Tom Finn
 Gilberto Lucero
 Joe Quinlan
 Jack Shaver
 Nina VanPatten
 Jim Waldron

Co-secretaries: Valerie O'Neill
 Lois Fisher

Public Information

Bert Gillis
 Mary Heiser
 Martha Hooper
 Ralph Jones
²Sandra Kelly
 Don McGee
¹Charles Nalepa
 Joe Quinlan
 Jack Shaver

Secretary: Valerie O'Neill

Trustees

Jack Blume
 Tom Canard
 Sandy Clunies
¹Kevin Doyle
 Robert Hickey
²Raymond Mitchell
 Jim Redemske
 Mark Richwine
 Rikki Schock

Secretary: Helen Turnquest

1997 CONFERENCE CHAIRPERSONS AND ALTERNATE CHAIRPERSONS³

Committee	Chairperson	Alternate
Agenda	Wendy Zaporaniuk, Saskatchewan	Charlotte Ingalls, Alaska
Cooperation With the Professional Community	Robert Watt, Alberta/NWT	Linda Firsdon, NW Ohio/SE Michigan
Correctional Facilities	Gilberto Lucero, NW Texas	Joycie Wren, Georgia
Finance	James Jarchow, Oregon	Bill Perrizo, N. Minnesota
Grapevine	Gary Miller, Mississippi	Bob Cordero, Arizona
Literature	Joe Burnes, California/Northern Interior	Carolyn Hammond, Kansas
Policy/Admissions	J.P. Paynter, California/San Diego Imperial	Tom McMullen, SW Texas
Public Information	Martha Hooper, Idaho	Jack Shaver, Manitoba
Report and Charter	Arnold Ross, Maryland	Bill Archer, SW Quebec
Treatment Facilities	Roberta Sullivan, Montana	Ben Beigler, Washington East
Committee on Trustees	Jack Blume, W. Massachusetts	Rikki Schock, New Brunswick/PEI

¹Chairperson

²Alternate Chairperson

³The 1996 Committee chairs rotated at the end of the 46th General Service Conference.

1996 Trustees' Committees

Archives

William Bungay, *chairperson*
 Jacques Filteau
 Gary Glynn
 Tom Maguire
 Robert Miller, D.D.
 Gerry Ouellette
 MaryJane Roy
 Francine Ward
 Frank Mauser, *secretary*

Conference

Michael McPherson, *chairperson*
 Chuck Crist
 Jacques Filteau
 Arthur Knight
 Julian Rhinehart
 Richard Roughton
 MaryJane Roy
 Donald Weaver
 Richard Bush, *secretary*

Cooperation With the Professional Community

Fran Polek, *chairperson*
 William Bungay
 John N. Chappel, M.D.
 Jacques Filteau
 *Anne Geller, M.D.
 Tom Maguire
 Robert Miller, D.D.
 Julian Rhinehart
 MaryJane Roy
 *Ray Stiver
 *Patricia Walters
 Francine Ward
 Eileen Gatza, *secretary*

Correctional Facilities

Les Leuthaeuser, *chairperson*
 John N. Chappel, M.D.
 *Roy Drake, S.J.
 Arthur Knight
 Raul Marin
 Peter Roach
 *Warren Stafford
 *Martha Watson
 Donald Weaver
 Sarah Price, *secretary*

Finance & Budgetary

Gary Glynn, *chairperson*
 Peter Brock
 Chuck Crist
 Gerry Flegel
 Gay Garner
 Arthur Knight
 Gerry Ouellette
 Donald Weaver
 Dennis Manders
senior advisor
 Donald Meurer, *secretary*

International

Larry Nelson, *chairperson*
 William Bungay
 John N. Chappel, M.D.
 Michel Girard
 Les Leuthaeuser
 Raul Marin
 Frank Polek
 Peter Roach
 Joanie Moncrief, *secretary*

International Conventions/ A.A. Regional Forums

Elaine Johnson, Ph.D.,
chairperson
 Gerry Flegel
 Gay Garner
 Michel Girard
 Les Leuthaeuser
 Michael McPherson
 Larry Nelson
 Peter Roach
 Richard Roughton
 Valerie O'Neill, *secretary*
—International Conventions
 Lois Fisher, *secretary*
—Regional Forums

Literature

Julian Rhinehart, *chairperson*
 *Frank Berls
 William Bungay
 *Jim Clough
 Gay Garner
 Gary Glynn
 Arthur Knight
 Fran Polek
 Richard Roughton
 Francine Ward
 Vincina McCarthy, *consultant*
 Eleanor Widdoes, *consultant*
 Pat Rosenstiel, *secretary*

Nominating

Gerry Flegel, *chairperson*
 Peter Brock
 Gary Glynn
 Elaine Johnson, Ph.D.
 Michael McPherson
 Robert Miller, D.D.
 Larry Nelson
 MaryJane Roy
 Jane Murphy Schulberg
 Helen Turnquest, *secretary*

Public Information

Jane Murphy Schulberg,
chairperson
 Gerry Flegel
 Michel Girard
 Tom Maguire
 Raul Marin
 Robert Miller, D.D.
 Gerry Ouellette
 *James Puckett
 *Ben Shapiro
 Valerie O'Neill, *secretary*

Treatment Facilities

John N. Chappel, M.D.,
chairperson
 Michel Girard
 *Russ Higgins
 Elaine Johnson, Ph.D.
 *Joyce King
 Les Leuthaeuser
 *Martha Lewis
 Raul Marin
 Peter Roach
 Jane Murphy Schulberg
 Sarah Price, *secretary*

General Sharing Session

Peter Brock, *chairperson*
 John Grant, *secretary*

All members of the General Service Board, A.A.W.S. and GV Boards, G.S.O. and GV staffs, and trustees' committees participate in this "town meeting."

Officers of the General Service Board

Chairperson
 Jim Estelle
 First vice-chairperson
 John N. Chappel, M.D.
 Second vice-chairperson
 Elaine M. Johnson, Ph.D.
 Secretary
 Gerry Flegel
 Treasurer
 Gary Glynn
 Assistant secretary
 John Grant
 Assistant treasurer
 Donald Meurer

The new slate of officers
 is given on page 45



*Denotes appointed committee members
 Jim Estelle and George Dorsey are ex officio members of all committees.

1996 Conference Members

NONALCOHOLIC (CLASS A) TRUSTEES

W.J. (Jim) Estelle, Jr. (3681 Mesa Verde Dr., El Dorado Hills, CA 95762) was elected chairman of the board at the meeting following the 1993 Conference. Jim was director of the Texas Department of Corrections for 12 years, and brought his background in correctional administration to the board when he served as a Class A trustee, 1977-1986. Now retired, he is involved in many professional societies on criminal justice and corrections and is on the board of a California service organization that serves the needs of the families of indigent jail and prison inmates.

John N. Chappel, M.D. (School of Medicine, University of Nevada, Reno, NV 89557) was elected to the board in 1989. A graduate of the University of Alberta Medical School, John has been professor of psychiatry, University of Nevada School of Medicine, since 1974. He serves as consultant to many professional organizations and is widely published in the field of alcoholism. John chairs the Treatment Facilities Committee and serves on the Cooperation With the Professional Community, Correctional Facilities, and International Committees.

Gary A. Glynn (1112 Park Ave., New York, NY 10128) was elected to the board in April 1993 after serving as a consultant to the trustees' Finance Committee, Employee's Retirement Committee and the A.A.W.S. Board. A graduate of the University of Vermont and the Wharton School, University of Pennsylvania, he has been an investment analyst and portfolio manager for 25 years, and is active in various professional organizations and committees. Gary is treasurer of the General Service Board and chairs the Finance & Budgetary Committee; he also is a member of the trustees' Literature, Nominating and Archives Committees.

Elaine M. Johnson, Ph.D. (6631 Hunters Wood Circle, Catonsville, MD 21228) was elected to the board in May 1992. A graduate of Morgan State University, Baltimore, and the University of Maryland, Elaine has a distinguished background in the fields of alcoholism and substance abuse. She has lectured widely, been a consultant to national and international government and professional organizations and published many articles in professional journals. Elaine is director of the Center for Substance Abuse Prevention, which is a component of the Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration under U.S. Dept. of Health and Human Services. Elaine chairs the International Conventions/Regional Forums Committee and also serves on the Treatment Facilities and Nominating Committees, and is a member of the Grapevine Corporate Board.

Arthur L. Knight, Jr. (865 Church Rd., Lake Forest, IL 60045) was elected to the board in 1995. Art's professional background is in the field of business, where he has held positions as president, director, and chief executive officer of manufacturing, distribution and financial services companies. He is a graduate of Dartmouth College and holds an M.B.A. from the University of New York, Buffalo. Now retired, Art serves on a variety of business, professional and civic boards. Art serves on the Conference, Literature, Correctional Facilities, and Finance & Budgetary Committees.

Robert Oran Miller, D.D. (Episcopal Diocese of Alabama, 521 N. 20th St., Birmingham, AL 35203) was elected to the board in 1995. Elected ninth Bishop of the Diocese of Alabama, in 1988, Bob has served as deacon and rector in several parishes in Alabama and held positions on various councils of the Episcopal church. He received an honorary Doctorate of Divinity from the University of the South, where he serves on the board of trustees.

Bob serves on the Archives, Cooperation With the Professional Community, Public Information and Nominating Committees.

Peter Roach (1332 Edmison Dr., Peterborough, ON K9H 6V3, Canada) was elected to the board in 1994. Peter has been an elementary and secondary school teacher and a director of education. Now retired he is involved extensively in community activities and serves on several civic and professional boards, and is chair of the Pastoral Council for his parish. Peter serves on the Correctional Facilities, International, International Conventions/Regional Forums and Treatment Facilities Committees.

ALCOHOLIC (CLASS B) TRUSTEES

C. Peter Brock (4625 S. 34th St., Arlington, VA 22206) was elected general service trustee in April 1994. With a professional background in the education, financial and health fields, he is currently a director of alcoholism and mental health programs. Peter serves on the Financial and Budgetary and Nominating Committees, and chairs the General Sharing Session on board weekends and is an A.A.W.S. director.

²**Carl Budd** (1405 Collins St., Rock Springs, WY 82901) was elected West Central regional trustee in April 1996. A Panel 30 delegate, Carl has remained active in his area, particularly in collecting material for the area archives. After many years in the oil and gas industry, he retired in 1995 from the Department of the Interior, after 14 years of service.

William Bungay (24 Johnson's Ave., Corner Brook, Newfoundland, A2H 1V8, Canada) was elected Eastern Canada regional trustee in April 1994. Bill, a Panel 39 delegate, has a background in accounting and business. He chairs the Archives Committee and also serves on the Cooperation With the Professional Community, International and Literature Committees.

²**Chuck Crist** (820 N. Braddley Dr., Chandler, AZ) was elected general service trustee in April 1996, after serving three years as a director on the Grapevine Board. Chuck, a Panel 40 delegate, works in the computer field.

¹**Gerry Flegel** (Box 1246, Humboldt, Saskatchewan, S0K 2A0 Canada), elected Western Canada regional trustee in May 1992, is a former Panel 38 delegate. Gerry is enjoying retirement after teaching math, computer science and accounting in Saskatchewan high schools for the past 30 years. He chairs the Nominating Committee and serves on the International Conventions/Regional Forums, Finance & Budgetary and Public Information Committees.

Gay Garner (528 Hammet Dr., Decatur, GA 30032) was elected Southeast U.S. regional trustee in April 1993. A former Panel 38 delegate, Gay has also served her area as G.S.R., D.C.M. and area chairperson and has been active in local P.I./C.P.C. activities. Her professional background is in the entertainment business, management and advertising sales. Gay chairs the A.A.W.S. Board and also serves on the Literature, International Conventions/Regional Forums and Finance & Budgetary Committees.

Michel Girard (67, Aubert Blvd., Repentigny, Quebec, J6A 4N9, Canada), a Panel 42 delegate, was elected trustee-at-large/Canada in May 1995. He has been active in service in his area and served on the boards of A.A. French Publications and *La Vigne*. Michel is now retired from a 30-year position with a

¹ Rotating at the close of the 1996 Conference meeting.

² New trustee, elected by the General Service Board, April 1996.

telecommunications company. He serves on the International Conventions/Regional Forums, Public Information, International and Treatment Facilities Committees.

Les Leuthaeuser (1912 Ave. B, Scottsbluff, NE 69361) was elected West Central U.S. regional trustee in May 1992. In service work for over 20 years, Les was a Panel 30 delegate and has served as area chair and area finance committee chair. He is self-employed in the home improvement/home repair business. Les chairs the Correctional Facilities Committees and also serves on the International Conventions/Regional Forums, Treatment Facilities and International Committees.

Garry McAuley (6115-51 Avenue, Stettler, Alberta, T0C 2L2, Canada) was elected Western Canada regional trustee in April 1996. A Panel 40 delegate, Garry now chairs Area 78's Remote Communities Committee. He is safety advisor at a petroleum/gas company.

Michael McPherson (315 W. 86th St., New York, NY 10024) was elected general service trustee in April 1993. Prior to that Michael was an A.A.W.S. director, where he served as chair for the A.A.W.S. Publications Subcommittee and was a member of the trustees' Finance Committee. He is chief administrative officer for a large nonprofit corporation. Michael chairs the Conference Committee and also serves on the International Conventions/Regional Forums and Nominating Committees, and is a member of the A.A.W.S. Board.

Raul Marin (234 Addax Dr., San Antonio, TX 78213) was elected Southwest regional trustee in May 1995. Raul has long been active in the southwest Texas area as G.S.R., D.C.M., area chair and delegate (Panel 30). He has been involved in starting bilingual Spanish groups, conferences and intergroups. Raul is an architect, now semi-retired. He serves on the Correctional Facilities, International, Public Information and Treatment Facilities Committees.

Larry Nelson (192 Elm Ave., Imperial Beach, CA 91932) was elected trustee-at-large/U.S. in April 1993. A former Panel 38 delegate, Larry has been active in many service activities in his area. He is a pharmacist on the staff of a large health maintenance organization clinic. Larry chairs the International Committee and serves on the Nominating and International Conventions/Regional Forums Committees and is a member of the Grapevine Corporate Board.



Fran Polek (2301 E. 61st Ave., Spokane, WA 99223), a Panel 27 delegate, was elected general service trustee in May 1992, after serving four years as a Grapevine director. He has served as chair of the Grapevine Corporate Board and of the trustees' Literature Committee. Fran is a Professor of English Emeritus, active in research, lecturing, and writing. He currently chairs the Cooperation With the Professional Community and also serves on the Literature and International Committees, and is a member of the Grapevine Corporate Board.

Julian Rhinehart (1127 Seno Court, Boulder City, NV 89005) was elected Pacific regional trustee in April 1994. Julian was a Panel 41 delegate, where he chaired the Conference P.I. Committee. He has long been active in area service. Retiring from the Federal Government in 1994 after a 25-year career in public relations, he now does freelance writing and consulting work.

Julian chairs the Literature Committee and serves on the Conference and Cooperation With the Professional Community Committees, and is a member of the A.A.W.S. Board.

MaryJane Roy (430 Moonstone Beach Rd., Wakefield, RI 02879) was elected Northeast U.S. regional trustee in May 1995. MaryJane began her service work in young people's groups, local central offices and at the group level. She was a Panel 42 delegate, and chaired the Conference C.P.C. Committee. MaryJane, a physician's assistant, is clinical director of a vascular lab. She serves on the Archives, Cooperation With the Professional Community, Conference and Nominating Committees.

Jane Murphy Schulberg (138 E. 38th St., New York, NY 10016) was elected a general service trustee in April 1993, after serving four years as a director on the Grapevine Corporate Board. Jane, who is a producer/writer with a television media house, has been active at many levels of local A.A. She chairs the Public Information Committee and also serves on the Nominating and Treatment Facilities Committees and is a member of the Grapevine Corporate Board.

Donald Weaver (1325 Seemore, Kalamazoo, MI 49001) was elected East Central regional trustee in April 1993. Don currently chairs a prison meeting and has held many service jobs in his area, including Panel 34 delegate. A landscaper, he is also involved with various community activities. Don chairs the Grapevine Corporate Board and also serves on the Finance & Budgetary and Correctional Facilities Committees.

A.A. World Services Directors

Gay Garner, *chairperson, regional trustee*
 Peter Brock, *general service trustee*
 George Dorsey, *G.S.O. general manager*
 Jacques Filteau, *nontrustee director*
 Michael McPherson, *general service trustee*

Gerard Ouellette, *nontrustee director*
 Julian Rhinehart, *regional trustee*
 John Grant, *G.S.O. staff member*
 Richard Roughton, *nontrustee director*

A.A. Grapevine Directors

Donald Weaver, *chairperson, regional trustee*
 Chuck Crist, *nontrustee director*
 Elaine Johnson, Ph.D., *Class A trustee*
 Thomas Maguire, *nontrustee director*
 Larry Nelson, *regional trustee*
 Fran Polek, *general service trustee*

Jane Murphy Schulberg, *general service trustee*
 Francine Ward, *nontrustee director*
 Ames Sweet, *Grapevine managing editor*
 Ann Warner, *Grapevine executive editor*

General Service Office Staff

George Dorsey, *general manager*
 Richard Bush
 Lois Fisher
 Eileen Gatz
 John Grant
 Joanie Moncrief
 Daniel Mooney

Valerie O'Neill
 Sarah Price
 Pat Rosenstiel
 Helen Turnquest
 Susan Ulseth
 Tom Jasper, *services director*
 Frank Mauser, *archivist*

Grapevine Staff

Ames Sweet, *managing editor*

Ann Warner, *executive editor*

Others Assisting the Conference (nonvoting)

Caryl Bertolino, *staff assistant*
 Rosa Blanco, *financial secretary*
 Daniel Brown, *typesetter*
 Angel Calvillo, *translator*
 Joseph Dennon, *staff assistant*
 John de Stefano, *Spanish editor*
 Yee Eng, *staff assistant*
 Al Herr, *artist, Conference Report*
 Margie Janicek, *receptionist*
 Cynthia Keyworth, *GV editorial asst.*
 John Kirwin Jr., *assistant controller/business administration*
 Steve Linek, *purchasing*
 Vinnie McCarthy, *publications director*
 Lynda Maziarz, *staff assistant*
 Don Meurer, *controller, A.A.W.S.*
 Lilianna Murphy, *data processing manager*
 Paul Murphy, *GV editorial staff asst.*
 Ramona Ortiz, *staff assistant*
 Ivelisse Rivera, *staff assistant*
 Miguel Rodriguez, *copy dept.*
 Linda Samuels, *staff assistant*
 Bob Scherer, *Grapevine controller*
 Frank Segui, *staff assistant*
 Elaine Soroka, *special projects manager*
 Cynthia White, *staff assistant*
 Andre Washington, *purchasing*
 Eleanor Widdoes, *writer/editor, Early Bird Box 4-5-9, Conference Report*

Trustees emeritus

Michael Alexander
 Gordon Patrick

Area Delegates

What do panel numbers mean? Delegates to each Conference are made up of two "panels." One is even-numbered and includes those elected to start serving in an even year. The other is odd-numbered and includes those elected to start serving in an odd year. The 45th Conference includes Panel 45 (delegates now serving for their second year) and Panel 46 (new delegates).

UNITED STATES

State	Area no.	Panel	
Alabama/N.W. Florida	1	45	Clark Fisher 2104 Gusmus Ave. Muscle Shoals, AL 35661-3010
Alaska	2	46	Charlotte Ingalls 1116 Ichabod St. North Pole, AK 99705
Arizona	3	46	Robert Cordero 2912 N. Rio de Flag Dr. Flagstaff, AZ 86004
Arkansas	4	45	Mary Bridges 137 Valley Dr. Camden, AR 71701
California Southern	5	45	Eva Sanchez 2119 De La Vina, No. H Santa Barbara, CA 93105
Northern Coastal	6	45	James (Jim) Madger 4368 Ridgecrest Pl. Eureka, CA 95503
Northern Interior	7	46	Joe Burnes Box 2649 Visalia, CA 93291
San Diego/Imperial	8	46	J.P. Paynter 134 Countrywood Ln. Encinitas, CA 92024-3109
Mid-Southern	9	46	Lona Wright-Parker 715 S. Palomino Anaheim Hills, CA 92807
Colorado	10	45	Linda B. Fredricks 11665 Valle Verde Dr. Colorado Springs, CO 80926
Connecticut	11	45	Anton (Tony) W. Taschner 16 Cindy Lane Berlin, CT 06037
Delaware	12	46	Bert Mitchell 3806 Brookfield Ave. Wilmington, DE 19803
District of Columbia	13	45	Sandy Clunies 6 Briardale Ct. Derwood, MD 20855-2027
Florida North	14	45	Daniel (Dan) Eberlein Box 494 Orange Lake, FL 32681
S. Florida/ Bahamas/V.I.	15	45	Diana R. Habbe 5009 W. Colonial Dr., #3 Tampa, FL 33611
Georgia	16	46	Joycie Wren 5430 Southlake Dr. Douglasville, GA 30135
Hawaii	17	45	Charles (Charlie) Nalepa Box 190 Kahului, HI 96732
Idaho	18	46	Martha (Marti) Hooper Box 488 New Plymouth, ID 83655

<u>State</u>	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>		<u>State</u>	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>	
Illinois				Montana	40	46	Roberta (Robbie) Sullivan Box 1870 Whitefish, MT 59937
<i>Chicago</i>	19	45	John M. Goldberg 1211 North LaSalle Dr., #802 Chicago, IL 60610	Nebraska	41	46	Mark Richwine 7921 Stockwell St. Lincoln, NE 68506
<i>Northern</i>	20	46	Thomas (Tom) Gore 835 Cedar Ave. Elgin, IL 60120	Nevada	42	45	Kevin Doyle 4525 Coran Lane Las Vegas, NV 89108-2817
<i>Southern</i>	21	45	Ann Santen 1395 Alice St. Collinsville, IL 62234	New Hampshire	43	46	Anne Malone Box 134 Durham, NH 03824
Indiana				New Jersey			
<i>Northern</i>	22	45	Clifford (Butch) Riggins 700 W. 60th St. Anderson, IN 46013	<i>Northern</i>	44	45	Robert (Bob) Simmons 941 Roosevelt Ave. Union, NJ 07083
<i>Southern</i>	23	46	Michael R. Smith 4 Sleepy Hollow Dr. Westfield, IN 46074-9503	<i>Southern</i>	45	46	John J. Kane, Jr. 549 Grant Ave. Collingswood, NJ 08107
Iowa	24	45	James (Jim) Redemske 513 Third St., S.E. Clarion, IA 50525	New Mexico	46	46	Betty M. Piatt Box 1747 Las Vegas, NM 87701
Kansas	25	46	Carolyn Hammond 12403 W. 105th St. Overland Park, KS 66215	New York			
Kentucky	26	46	Gen Greiwe 233 Merravay Dr. Florence, KY 41042	<i>Central</i>	47	45	Edward (Ed) Wolf 440 Foster Valley Rd. Owego, NY 13827
Louisiana	27	45	Charles (Charlie) Bartell 3935 Lennox Blvd. New Orleans, LA 70131	<i>Hudson/Mohawk/ Berkshire</i>	48	46	John Walsh 508 Creek Rd. Poughkeepsie, NY 12601
Maine	28	46	Ted Sturtevant RR1, Box 1045 Woolwich, ME 04579	<i>Southeast</i>	49	45	Paul Sherman 863 Artic St. Lindenhurst, NY 11757
Maryland	29	46	Arnold Ross 5904 Northwood Dr. Baltimore, MD 21212	<i>Western</i>	50	46	Jack (Bevo) Boyle 60 Cantwell Dr. Buffalo, NY 14220-2602
Massachusetts				North Carolina	51	45	Robert (Bob) Reynolds 28 Misty Mountain Rd. Franklin, NC 28734
<i>Eastern</i>	30	45	JoAnne Frey 386 Thurston St. Wrentham, MA 02093	North Dakota	52	46	Mike Friederichs 7595 180 Ave., SE Wahpeton, ND 58075
<i>Western</i>	31	46	Jack Blume 199 Silver St. Sheffield, MA 01257	Ohio			
Michigan				<i>Central Southeast</i>	53	45	William (Bill) Schmertz 136 E. Weisheimer Rd. Columbus, OH 43214
<i>Central</i>	32	45	Sandra Kelly 208 Cloverland Dr. Lansing, MI 48910	<i>Northeast</i>	54	45	George O'Neil 331 Granview Hubbard, OH 44425
<i>Southeast</i>	33	45	Pamela (Pam) Reising 29646 Pleasant Trail Southfield, MI 48076	<i>NW Ohio/SE Mich.</i>	55	46	Linda Firsdon 14221 New Rochester Rd. Pemberville, OH 43450
<i>Western</i>	34	46	James (Jim) Waldron 603 Stimson St. Cadillac, MI 49601	<i>Southwest</i>	56	46	Mary Heiser 111 S. Main St. Minster, OH 45865
Minnesota				Oklahoma	57	45	Phyllis D. McCoy 6910 S. 32nd West Ave. Tulsa, OK 74132
<i>Northern</i>	35	46	Bill Perrizo 1341 S. Fifth Ave. Fargo, ND 58103	Oregon	58	46	James (Jim) Jarchow Box 851 Gold Beach, OR 97444
<i>Southern</i>	36	45	Douglas (Doug) Mead 212 W. Woodley Northfield, MN 55057	Pennsylvania			
Mississippi	37	46	Gary Miller Box 957 Long Beach, MS 39560	<i>Eastern</i>	59	45	Joseph (Joe) Quinlan Rear 519 Birch St. Scranton, PA 18505
Missouri				<i>Western</i>	60	45	Matt Hartman 714 Western Ave. Beaver, PA 15009
<i>Eastern</i>	38	45	Jeanne Ertmann 65 Midland Dr. Wright City, MO 63390				
<i>Western</i>	39	45	Karen Williams 817 West Seminole Springfield, MO 65807				

State	Area no.	Panel	
Rhode Island	61	46	Ernest (Ernie) Bourgeois Box 40024 Providence, RI 02940-0024
South Carolina	62	46	Robert (Bob) Merritt Box 1652 Greenville, SC 29602-1652
South Dakota	63	46	George Reynolds 614 S. Broadway Watertown, SD 57201
Tennessee	64	46	Carl (Ralph) Jones 1496 Lawrence St. Kingsport, TN 37665
Texas			
<i>Northeast</i>	65	45	James (Jim) Tims Rt. 1, Box 226 Whitesboro, TX 76273
<i>Northwest</i>	66	46	Gilberto Lucero 2800 Frankfort Ave. El Paso, TX 79930
<i>Southeast</i>	67	45	Rodney Rabren 224 First St. Brazoria, TX 77422
<i>Southwest</i>	68	46	Thomas (Tom) McMullen 6802 Still Lake San Antonio, TX 78244-2020
Utah	69	45	Thomas (Tom) Finn 1218 E. 2550 N. North Ogden, UT 84414
Vermont	70	46	Don (McGee) McGee Box 671 Bromoseen, VT 05732
Virginia	71	45	Robert (Bob) Hickey 209 Ridgewell Circle Norfolk, VA 23503
Washington			
<i>East</i>	92	46	Ben Beigler 113 E. Bonnieview Grandview, WA 98930
<i>Western</i>	72	45	Ernie Mills 15822 Eighth Ave. N.E. Seattle, WA 98155
West Virginia	73	45	*Larry Cassady 618 Eighth St. Marietta, OH 45750
Wisconsin			
<i>No. WI/ Up Penn. MI</i>	74	46	Thomas (Tom) Canard W1785 Elk Lane Kaukauna, WI 54130
<i>Southern</i>	75	45	William (Bill) Anderson 6735 W. Moltke Ave. Milwaukee, WI 53210
Wyoming	76	46	Nina VanPatten 6340 Buckboard #2 Casper, WY 82604
Puerto Rico	77	46	José (Jr.) Gonzáles Box 102 Ciales, PR 00638-0102

CANADA

Province	Area no.	Panel	
Alberta/N.W.T.	78	46	Robert (Bob) Watt 16 LaFonde Cr. St. Albert, AB T8N 2N6
B.C./Yukon	79	45	Alexander (Alex) Palmer 33439 Huggins Ave. Abbotsford, BC V2S 2R8
Manitoba	80	46	Jack Shaver 27 Makinak Bay Winnipeg, MB R2Y 1B8
New Brunswick/P.E.I.	81	46	Rikki Schock R.R. #3, Belle River P.O. Belle River, PEI C0A 1B0
Nova Scotia/ Newfoundland/Labrador	82	45	Bert Gillis 39 Cottage Court Sydney, NS B1P 6S2
Ontario			
<i>Eastern</i>	83	45	Raymond (Ray) Mitchell 78 Brookdale Ave. Toronto, ON M5M 1P3
<i>Northeast</i>	84	45	Jack Sanderson 306-94 Allard St. Sault Ste. Marie, ON P6B 5E9
<i>Northwest</i>	85	45	Norman (Norm) Ames Box 134 Dryden, ON P8N 2Y7
<i>Western</i>	86	46	Jim Dick 86 Henderson St. Cambridge, ON N3C 2G1
Quebec			
<i>Southwest</i>	87	46	William (Bill) Archer 5731 Somerled, #5 Montreal, PQ H3X 1Z7
<i>Southeast</i>	88	45	Aime Imbeault 208, de la Montagne Notre-Dame du Portage PQ G0L 1Y0
<i>Northeast</i>	89	45	Jeannot Bouchard 6779 boul. Des Gradins Quebec, PQ G2J 1B1
<i>Northwest</i>	90	46	Robert Pelot 217, Terrasse Riopel Lafontaine, PQ J7Y 4H8
Saskatchewan	91	46	Wendy Zapanianuk #44 - 28th St. East Prince Albert, SK S6V 1W8

* Seated as Panel 45 delegate, replacing former delegate Martha Wright, who resigned.